FREEDOM IN CHRIST

By Jeannette Musselman

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AND BOOK REVIEWS

I wish to express my appreciation to:

My Pastor, Dale Hoch, for his spiritual guidance and blessings.

My friends, Carrie Waterman and Carolle Meilleur for reading my manuscript, for encouraging me and for graciously giving me their comments below.

Freedom in Christ is not a book that you read once and retire to your bookshelf or toss in the second-hand store box to be given away. It is a deep and profound teaching for those who desire the meat of the Word and who desire to know more about this loving God who has given us everything through his Son, Jesus. Jeannette Musselman is an excellent teacher who brings clarity and understanding so that every believer – young or old, will be equipped and approved unto God. This book is not breadcrumbs but fresh loaves of bread that will fill and satisfy as you apply yourself to study with it. Carolle Meilleur

Jeannette Musselman's book, Freedom in Christ, is a refreshing read. Its pages are full of healing and freedom from condemnation and guilt for the Christian and a spiritual compass for the lost toward God's unconditional love. Its message is a timely encouragement for this generation. This book clearly and powerfully brings out the truth about grace, mercy and faith. Thereby breaking people free of the obligation of religion and brings them into a life filled with personal desire in serving the Lord. It shows the way to having a Christian life filled with joy and peace. I highly recommend this book to anyone that wants a

blessing, especially to those who may be struggling with a heavy load of failure and guilt or overwhelmed with the battles that life so often brings our way. Pastor Dale Hoch – Senior Pastor of World Outreach Ministries

What an amazing book! It gives you powerful truths about who you are in Christ Jesus. Readers can walk in the power and presence of Jesus' love. You will learn about what Jesus accomplished on the cross for you. As you read of God's grace and provision, you will be encouraged in the goodness of our great and mighty God. This book has blessed me in many ways and I would recommend this book for anyone seeking a deeper relationship with Jesus. Carrie Waterman

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Freedom from Self-Righteousness (Religion)

➢ *My Testimony*

I would like to tell you how I came to believe in Jesus and receive Him as my personal Savior and Lord. However, before I do that, please let me take you to a person in the Bible who was a lot like me before I got saved.

> *"At Caesarea there was a man named Cornelius, a centurion in what was known as the Italian Regiment. He and all his family were devout and God-fearing, he gave generously to those in need and prayed to God regularly. One day at about three in the afternoon he had a vision. He distinctly saw an angel of God, who came to him and said, "Cornelius!" Cornelius stared at him in fear. "What is it, Lord?" he asked. The angel answered, "Your prayers and gifts to the poor have come up as a memorial offering before God. Now send men to Joppa to bring back a man named Simon who is called Peter. He is staying with Simon the tanner, whose house is by the sea." When the angel who spoke to him had gone, Cornelius called two of his servants and a devout soldier who was one of his attendants. He told them everything that had happened and sent them to Joppa" (Acts 10:1-8).*

Cornelius was a good person. He knew about God and he was trying with all his efforts to live a good life. He gave to the

poor and he acknowledged God in his life but he did not know what Jesus had done for him personally. He was not born again.

God even spoke to Cornelius in a dream but this didn't save him. God was directing him and wanting to reveal to Cornelius and his family the gospel message of Jesus Christ.

Now before I get into my testimony I want to carry on in Acts Chapter 10 with the story of Cornelius. God told Cornelius to send for Peter. While the men that Cornelius had sent were on their way to get Peter, God prepared Peter's heart through a vision not to call anything unclean that He had made clean. Cornelius was a Gentile, not a Jew. The Jews considered the Gentiles to be unclean. The Holy Spirit also told Peter, just as the men that Cornelius had sent arrived, to not hesitate in going with them for He had sent them.

> *"The next day Peter started out with them, and some of the brothers from Joppa went along. The following day he arrived in Caesarea. Cornelius was expecting them and had called together his relatives and close friends. As Peter entered the house, Cornelius met him and fell at his feet in reverence. But Peter made him get up. "Stand up," he said, "I am only a man myself. Now we are all here in the presence of God (Cornelius was speaking to Peter) to listen to everything the Lord has commanded you to tell us. Then Peter began to speak: "I now realize how true it is that God does not show favoritism but accepts men from every nation who fear him and do what is right.* ***You know*** *the message God sent to the people of Israel, telling the good news of peace through Jesus Christ, who is Lord of all.* ***You know*** *what has happened throughout Judea, beginning in Galilee after the baptism that John preached – how God anointed Jesus of Nazareth with the Holy Spirit and power, and how he went around doing good and healing all who were under the power of the devil, because God was with him.* ***We are witnesses*** *of everything he did in the country of the Jews and in Jerusalem. They killed him by hanging him on a tree, but God raised him from the dead on the third day and caused*

*him to be seen. He was not seen by all the people, but by witnesses whom God had already chosen – **by us** who ate and drank with him after he rose from the dead. He commanded **us** to preach to the people and to testify that he is the one whom God appointed as judge of the living and the dead. All the prophets testify about him **that everyone who believes in him receives forgiveness of sins through his name**. While Peter was still speaking these words, the Holy Spirit came on all who heard the message" ((Acts 10:23b-26, 33b-44, emphasis and parenthesis added).*

Now let's look at this passage of scripture a little closer.

You read that Cornelius was a devout and God-fearing man. Devout means feelings of deep respect, reverent, good and religious.

Cornelius and his household were devout (good, religious, reverent people, respectful of God), they gave to the poor and prayed but they still needed to hear the gospel message which was that everyone who believes in Jesus receives forgiveness of their sins through His Name. It wasn't until Peter told them this that they believed and were saved.

It says in the above scripture reference that **they knew** and heard about Jesus and what He was doing but **they did not know** that He died on a cross and was raised from the dead and that He had appeared to some witnesses who were testifying of His resurrection. **They did not know** that Jesus took all their sins on the cross so that they could believe and receive forgiveness of their sins and be saved. God had sent Peter to Cornelius and his household and close friends to tell them the gospel message of what Jesus did for them in His redemptive work so that they would believe, receive forgiveness of their sins and be saved.

I was a devout God-fearing person before I was saved. I prayed to God regularly (mostly give-me prayers). I acknowledged Him in my life. I went to Church faithfully but just like Cornelius, I did not know what Jesus did for me in His redemptive work. I only had head knowledge of Jesus. **I knew**

about him but I did not know Him personally. I did not have a personal relationship with Him. I was a religious person thinking that I could get to heaven by simply being good. I acknowledged Jesus in my life and I knew that he suffered for me and was nailed to the cross but I did not know that I needed His righteousness to get to heaven. I still thought I could get to heaven by being a good person, by my own righteousness and by going to Church. My own righteousness (my self-efforts) was not enough for me to get to heaven. If I could get to heaven by being a devout, God-fearing person without believing with my heart what Jesus did for me and receiving Him as my personal Savior and Lord, then Jesus suffered and died for nothing.

One day, my sister asked me if I wanted to receive Jesus into my heart as my personal Savior and Lord. I didn't understand what she was talking about. I had never heard this before. I was thinking to myself that this was not necessary because I was a good person and I went to Church and I prayed. I said the prayer with my sister only because I was too embarrassed to say "No". I didn't say the prayer with my heart. I didn't mean it when I said it because I didn't think it was necessary. **God knew that I did not mean it.** I think it was the next day while carrying a laundry basket down the hall of my home that the Holy Spirit asked me a question. The question was in the form of a thought that came to me. I didn't know it was the Holy Spirit talking to me at that time. I didn't know that I could hear God speak to me. However, I knew I had to answer this question. The question the Holy Spirit asked me was "Do you really want Jesus in your heart?" I will never forget it. I stopped to think about that question. I knew I had to answer that thought and I said "Yes" and I carried on with my laundry. When I said "Yes", I meant it. At that time, I didn't realize the importance of that answer as it changed my life forever. It changed my destiny. I didn't realize that there was a party going on in heaven at that very moment because I had just become a child of God.

Even though I was now saved, I lived like everyone else in the world lived. I still drank some, did some partying, etc. just

like the world did. However, I didn't use foul language or take God's Name in vain even before I got saved.

Up until that point in my life, I had never read the Bible but I started to read it. I didn't understand anything I was reading. It was like I was reading another language but I wanted to get to know God so I persisted.

Although I was only saved for a few days, God started to speak to me through thoughts even though I didn't realize it was Him at that time. My husband was in the final stages of accepting a job in another City further away from our families than we already were. I began to have flashbacks of how difficult it was when we moved away in the first place and I began to realize that I didn't want to move further away from our families. This was the Holy Spirit directing me although I didn't know it at that time. To make a long story short, instead of moving farther away we moved back to where our families were which is where God wanted us. Our home sold and we purchased another home all in 2 months. When we moved back home, I started attending Christian services with my sister and I received the baptism of the Holy Spirit with the evidence of speaking in tongues and I began to grow as a Christian. My husband, myself and our two young boys started attending a Church where we heard the gospel message preached. My husband received Jesus as his Savior and Lord six months later.

Even after I got saved, I continued to live a self-righteous life, thinking that I could gain God's acceptance and approval by doing all the right things.

A few years later, I took some Bible courses and I became aware of the difference between self-righteousness and Jesus' righteousness. I was told that the Bible says self-righteousness was as filthy rags to the Lord (see Isaiah 64:6). I even got up in front of the Church I was attending and said that I wasn't going to be self-righteous anymore. As soon as I said that I realized that I was making a self-righteous statement. I still didn't really get it. I didn't want to live a self-righteous life. I did receive

Jesus' righteousness for the salvation of my spirit but I was trying with all my self-efforts to earn the salvation of my **soul** and earn my rewards in heaven.

When God created us, He created us as a three-part being. We are a spirit, we have a soul and we live in a body. Our soul is our mind, our will and our emotions which flow out of our heart. I had been taught that my heart had good and evil in it and **I** had to get rid of the evil in my heart. It was up to **me** to get rid of the evil in my heart. So even though my spirit was saved by grace through faith in Jesus Christ, I went back under the law to live my Christian life trying with all my efforts (which is self-righteousness) to get rid of the evil in my heart and to obey the 10 commandments. The law (which includes the 10 commandments) is a system based on our own goodness, our own righteousness, not on Jesus' goodness or on His righteousness.

Every wrong thought that came to me, I confessed because I wanted to be right with God. I was so focused on getting rid of the sin in my life that I actually became sin conscious rather than Jesus conscious. So I lived like that even though I was saved until I began reading a book on the grace of God by a well-known Pastor which is when I began to understand the grace of God more completely.

I came to understand that the salvation of my soul was not getting rid of the evil in my heart but getting my mind renewed with the Word of God and allowing His Word to change me from the inside out. God's Word is active and alive, sharper than any double-edged sword and it is revelation knowledge of His Word that will bring about the changes that are necessary for our lives.

> *"You foolish Galatians! Who has bewitched you? Before your very eyes Jesus Christ was clearly portrayed as crucified. I would like to learn just one thing from you:* ***Did you receive the Spirit by observing the law, or by believing what you heard?*** *Are you so foolish?* ***After beginning with***

the Spirit, are you now trying to attain your goal by human effort?*" (Galatians 3:1-3, emphasis added).*

The Galatian believers were doing the same thing that I was doing. They got saved by grace through faith and then they went right back under the law to earn the salvation of their soul and to earn God's acceptance and love. Paul was saying that their human effort was self-righteousness. Paul was telling them that they got saved by believing in Jesus **and that their soul would be saved the same way**. He was saying not to go back under the law for the salvation of their soul but to receive salvation for their soul the same way they got saved – **by grace through faith in Jesus Christ**.

*"For it is by grace you have been saved, through faith – and this **not from yourselves**, it is the **gift** of God – **not by works**, so that no one can boast" (Ephesians 2:8-9, emphasis added).*

When we work to earn God's approval, it is self-righteousness. This scripture says that grace which is unearned, unmerited, undeserved favor of God is a **gift** from God. Salvation is a gift. It is not by works. It cannot be earned. It is free and needs to be received. No amount of self-righteousness will save us.

The moment we believe in Jesus and in His finished works on the cross, a divine exchange takes place. Jesus takes all our sins away (past, present and future sins) and He gives us His gift of righteousness. His righteousness is a gift to all who believe in Him. It no longer belongs to Jesus because He gifted it to us. We are made as righteous as Jesus is. We become the righteousness of God in Christ Jesus (see 2 Corinthians 5:21). It is no longer about our righteousness. It is no longer about me and what I can do but about Jesus and what He has already done for me. You see the law is all about **us** and how good **we** can be but grace is all about **Jesus** and what **He** has already done for us. **When I understood this, my focus changed from myself to Jesus.**

When I came to understand the grace of God it transformed my life. Now, instead of working with all my efforts to be acceptable to God and to be approved by Him which is really unbelief, I am laboring to rest in the finished works of Jesus Christ and who I am in Him. I am now depending on and relying on His Spirit to lead me in all things and to do through me what I cannot do. **To rest is to believe in the finished works of Jesus Christ**. Resting is not inactivity but it is a rest from our self-efforts. When we try to earn our salvation, it is unbelief. Let's look at this next scripture.

> *"So we see that they were not able to enter because of their **unbelief**" (Hebrews 3:19, emphasis added).*

Just prior to God giving the Israelites the 10 commandments, they were living self-righteous lives because they thought that they were well able to obey all the commands of God. They wanted God to bless them based on their own goodness and obedience not on His goodness. When they rejected God's grace, God gave them the 10 commandments and all of the other laws. They walked in unbelief and because they did not believe they were rebellious and disobedient to God. In addition to the above scripture, Hebrews 3:11 also says that they would never enter **God's rest** because of unbelief.

Anyone walking in self-righteousness is rejecting the grace of God. Anyone walking in self-righteousness is not resting (not believing) in the finished works of Christ and is walking in unbelief.

I was not aware that I was rejecting the grace of God when it came to the salvation of my soul. I misunderstood the scriptures regarding the salvation of my soul. I thought I had to save my own soul by my good works and by getting rid of the evil in my heart. I thought **I** had to do it.

The salvation of my soul is not me trying to get rid of the evil (sin) in my heart but about renewing my mind with the Word of God. As my mind was renewed with the Word of God, I came to know God the Father, God the Son and God the Holy

Spirit in real and personal ways. I came to know who I am in Christ and that I belong to His family. I came to know the promises of God for me and as I declared these promises I saw them manifest in my life. I came to know my inheritance in Christ Jesus and what Jesus bequeathed to me. I came to know that I am seated with Jesus as a co-heir at the right hand of God the Father far above all rule and authority of the enemy (see Ephesians 2:6). I came to know that I am the head and not the tail, the top and not the bottom (see Deuteronomy 28:13) and I began to walk in the victory that Jesus died to give me. I am getting to know my God and His Word more and more, day by day as I seek Him. The salvation of my soul will continue until the day I die.

Over time, I came to know the call of God on my life and I allowed Him to prepare me to answer that call and walk in it. Grace teaches me to wait for Him to open the doors without trying to open them myself. Grace teaches me to wait on His timetable and surrender my will to His Will. Grace teaches me to let go and let Him be in control. I depend upon the Holy Spirit's help to cease struggling in my own efforts and trust Him to lead me and guide me in His perfect plan for my life.

Now I read the Bible, go to Church, pray and give, etc. because I want to not because I have to. I thought I had to do these things to be accepted and loved by God. I now know that I am accepted by God and I am getting to know the love that Jesus and the Father have for me more and more. I love to read His Word because I am discovering Him, His grace, His goodness, His mercy, His promises, and yes even His discipline because He loves me. I am getting rooted and grounded in Him and in His ways of doing and thinking.

When we receive the grace of God and His gift of righteousness, we will accomplish far more for God than we could ever accomplish in our own strength and power.

> *"**How much more** will those who receive God's abundant provision of grace and of the gift of righteousness **reign in***

life *through the one man, Jesus Christ" (Romans 5:17b, emphasis added).*

Reigning in life is to be successful, fruitful, victorious, overcoming and conquering children of God. Does this mean that everything will be perfect in our lives? No, but even when things are not going the way we would want them to go, we are still reigning as long as we have our eyes fixed on Jesus (on His grace and His righteousness) and as long as we are allowing His grace to teach us so that our minds are renewed with the Word of God.

"For the ***grace of God*** *that brings salvation* ***has appeared*** *to all men.* ***It teaches*** *us to say "No" to ungodliness and worldly passions, and to live self-controlled, upright and godly lives in this present age, while we wait for the blessed hope – the glorious appearing of our great God and Savior, Jesus Christ, who gave himself for us to redeem us from all wickedness and to purify for himself a people that are his very own, eager to do what is good" (Titus 2:11-14, emphasis added).*

This scripture says the grace of God that brings salvation has appeared to all men. It says grace appeared to all men. Jesus appeared to all men. Jesus is the grace of God. Jesus is grace. To reject grace is to reject Jesus.

The above scripture says "**It** teaches us". The "It" in this scripture is referring to Grace**. Therefore, it is Grace that teaches us**.

How will we be able to say "No" to ungodliness and worldly passions and how will we be able to live self-controlled, upright and godly lives if we do not embrace the grace of God?

We need to hug the grace of God. We need to be thankful for the grace of God for without God's grace we will walk in disobedience, rebellion and unbelief. We will walk in religion rather than in intimacy with our Lord and Savior, Jesus Christ.

Jesus is grace. He is the embodiment of grace. He is grace clothed with flesh.

My life has been transformed since I have hugged the grace of God. I have come to cherish God's grace (His unearned, unmerited, undeserved favor). I have come to understand that although I was a good person, without Christ I was headed for hell just like someone who is evil or doing really bad things.

> *"But the cowardly, the* ***unbelieving****, the vile, the murderers, the sexually immoral, those who practice magic arts, the idolaters* ***and all liars*** *– their place will be in the fiery lake of burning sulfur. This is the second death" (Revelation 21:8, emphasis added).*

Did you notice the **unbelieving and liars** are listed among the murderers, the sexually immoral and those who practice magic arts? This scripture is saying that without Christ's righteousness, unbelievers and liars will not make it into heaven. Just being devout, religious, God-fearing people like Cornelius will not get us to heaven. The Bible tells us that if we do not believe in Jesus Christ as our personal Savior and Lord and embrace His gift of grace and righteousness, we will be among those who will be in the fiery lake.

God does not send anyone to hell. He provides the way to heaven. The choice is ours. **We** choose heaven or hell. It is our choice. God's will is that none should perish but have eternal life (see John 3:16).

> *"This day I call heaven and earth as witnesses against you that* ***I have set before you life and death****, blessings and curses.* ***Now choose life****, so that you and your children may live and that you may love the Lord your God, listen to his voice and hold fast to him" (Deuteronomy 30:19-20a, emphasis added).*

Since God did not want us to be like robots, He gave us a free will. He wanted us to freely choose to have a relationship with Him.

"All of us have become like one who is unclean, ***and all our righteous acts are like filthy rags****; we all shrivel up like a leaf and like the wind our sins sweep us away" (Isaiah 64:6, emphasis added).*

Living a self-righteous (religious) life is as filthy rags in God's eyes. Thinking that we can earn our own salvation and make it to heaven by being a good person, without receiving God's grace and gift of righteousness, is deception.

You may be saved but you may be mixing law and grace together just like I did until I came to understand grace. Please ask Holy Spirit to help you to live in grace and grace alone. Ask Him to show you where you are still living under the law. Every so often I ask Holy Spirit to show me as well as I don't want to slip back under the law and not recognize that I did. I want to live by grace alone.

You may be living a religious lifestyle just like Cornelius did and I did before we were saved. Would you like to receive Jesus Christ as your personal Savior and Lord? Would you like to receive God's grace and gift of righteousness which is found in the person of Jesus Christ to reign in life? If you do, please say the following prayer and please mean it with your heart:

Prayer: Father, in Jesus' Name, I recognize that I am a sinner in need of a Savior. I humble myself before You today and I respond to the salvation message of grace by faith. I believe that Jesus died for my sins, rose from the dead, and is now seated on the throne of God. I receive forgiveness of all my sins. I receive Jesus Christ as my personal Savior and Lord. I receive Your grace and Your gift of righteousness to reign in life through Jesus Christ. Please fill me with the power of Your Holy Spirit to walk in Your grace and Your gift of righteousness all the days of my life and help me to renew my mind with Your Word. Thank You, Jesus, for saving me.

If you received Jesus as your Savior and Lord, you now belong to His family. It is very important that you get connected with other members of God's family (see Hebrews 10:25). This

does not make you any more righteous than you already are but it will certainly help you to grow in Christ and is God's Will for your life. **Ask Holy Spirit to lead you** to a Church that preaches the full gospel so that you can hear the Word of God, enjoy corporate worship and have godly Christian fellowship.

➢ *Religion or Genuine Faith*

How do we know if we are walking in self-righteousness (religion) or genuine faith?

Let's look at the book of James which gives us insight into this.

> *"You see that a person is justified by what he does and not by faith alone" (James 2:24).*

In this scripture, was James **adding** good works to our faith to be saved? Let's look at the preceding verses to see what James is actually talking about.

> *"What good is it my brothers, if a man **claims** to have faith but has no deeds? Can **such faith** save him?" (James 2:14, emphasis added).*

KJV says "What does it profit, my brethren, though a man **say** he hath faith".

Amplified says "What is the use (profit), my brethren, for anyone to **profess** to have faith".

I looked up the word "say" in the Strong's Exhaustive Concordance and some meanings are to break silence **merely**; an extended or random harangue. It also means to boast.

Harangue means a long blustering speech.

A blustering speech to me is a long painful speech when you just want to tell the person to be quiet because it is so meaningless.

As we begin this study of James, we need to determine who James was talking to in his book. Was James talking to born again Christians or Jews? In James1:1, he addresses the 12 tribes of Israel. Now there may have been some Messianic Jews present but mainly he was talking to Jews who were not born again, with the intent that they might realize their poor spiritual condition and get saved and have **real genuine faith** in Jesus.

He is saying to them: What good is it my brothers if a man **claims** or **professes** or **says** he has faith? What good is it my brothers if a man **boasts** that he has faith; if a man **merely** breaks silence; if a man gives this **long blustering speech** that he has faith but has no deeds? What good is it my brethren if a man **only claims** to have faith but really doesn't have genuine faith; doesn't have heart faith in God? What good is it if a man only acknowledges that there is a God; if a man only has head knowledge **about** God but does not know Him personally, intimately or relationally? Can such faith save him?

> *"You believe that there is one God. Good!* ***Even the demons believe that*** *– and shudder" (James 2:19, emphasis added).*

What was James saying here? He was saying that the Jews, who he was talking to, believed that there is only one God and he points out that even the demons believe that there is only one God. These Jewish brethren claimed to believe in God. They claimed to have faith in God. James was pointing out to them that although they claimed to have faith in God, their actions did not correspond with their boasting. He goes on to say "Can such faith save him?". Can such faith save a man who only claims or professes or says he has faith in God but has no corresponding deeds?

James is trying to get his Jewish brethren to see their self-righteousness. A self-righteous (religious) person will claim to

have faith in God but their actions will not line up with what they say. They are walking in religion only. They are not walking in a personal relationship with Jesus Christ.

> *"Suppose a brother or sister is without clothes and daily food. If* ***one of you*** *says to him, "Go, I wish you well; keep warm and well fed, but does nothing about his physical needs, what good is it? In the same way, faith by itself, if it is not accompanied by action, is dead" (James 2:15-17, emphasis added).*

This is the response of someone who does not know God personally; who does not know or have the love of Jesus in them. James is saying: what good is your faith if you only say to this needy person "keep warm and well fed". It says that faith by itself if it is not accompanied by action is dead. James was telling these Jewish brothers that their faith was dead. They were not born again. He was saying to them that their faith in God was merely head knowledge. They only knew about God but had no relationship with Him. He said that even the demons believe that there is one God. In other words, he was saying that their faith was no greater than the demons' faith in God. Those he was talking to in this passage of scripture were not born again believers in Jesus.

> *"But someone will say, "You have faith;* ***I have deeds****." Show me your* ***faith without deeds*** *and* ***I will show you my faith by what I do****" (James 2:18, emphasis added).*

He is saying in this scripture that someone who says: "You have faith; **I have deeds**" is in the same spiritual condition as someone who **claims to have faith but has no deeds** (see James 2:14 above). In other words, these people in this scripture did not have faith. They only had deeds. Some people think they can get to heaven by their good deeds alone. It is the same with those who claim to have faith but no deeds. James says "Can such faith save him?". Neither one is in a right relationship with God. **What James goes on to say is "I will show you my faith by what I do".**

Faith and actions go together. We don't add works to our faith to be saved. Rather good works will automatically follow our right believing. When we believe right, we will live right.

> *"You **foolish** man, do you want evidence that **faith without deeds is useless**?" (James 2:20, emphasis added).*

James called those he was speaking to foolish and their faith useless. The foolish man built his house on the sand. In other words, he was saying to them that their faith was foolish. They built their faith on the sand and not on the Rock (the Rock referring to Jesus). He was saying: do you want evidence that faith without deeds is useless and then he goes on.

> *"Was not our ancestor Abraham considered righteous for what **he did** when he offered his son Isaac on the altar? You see, that **his faith and his actions were working together**, and his faith was made complete by what **he did**. (What did he do?) And the scripture was fulfilled that says, Abraham **believed** God, and it was credited to him as righteousness, and he was called God's friend. You see that a person is justified by what he does and not by faith alone (which is not faith at all)" (James 2:21–24, emphasis and parenthesis added).*

James was comparing the faith of those he was talking to, to Abraham's faith. He was saying: Let's look at Abraham's faith. Abraham had true genuine faith in God. He had heart faith. He says that Abraham **believed** God and it was credited to him as righteousness. It was Abraham's faith in God that made him righteous. It was Abraham's faith in God that **produced good works**. If Abraham only believed God like the Jewish brethren that James was talking to, who only claimed to have faith, Abraham would not even have considered offering his son Isaac as a sacrifice to God. It was because Abraham had a living, vital, intimate relationship with God that his faith had corresponding actions.

Therefore, the works of a born again Christian is to believe in Jesus and in His finished work and this belief will effortlessly produce in our lives corresponding actions just like Abraham's faith did. Our faith and our actions will work together. **Without true faith in God, we will have no corresponding actions.** It is because our faith is alive (not dead like the people that James was talking to) that good works will automatically flow from us. Abraham believed God. His faith was alive and because of his belief in God, because his faith was alive to God, his actions corresponded with his faith. **His actions were a result of his genuine faith in God.**

In the Church, we have been too busy trying to get people to do good works when we should be putting our efforts into helping them believe in God and helping them to grow in the knowledge of God the Father, God the Son and God the Holy Spirit. **This right believing will automatically produce good works**.

Abraham believed God and because he believed God he did right things. He walked after the Spirit. He listened to and obeyed the Spirit of God. Those who do not have heart faith in God (who are merely self-righteous/religious) will not walk after the Spirit.

When James says that a person is justified by what he does and not by faith alone, **he was not adding works to our faith to be saved**. He was saying to these Jews that they needed to believe like Abraham believed and when their actions followed their faith, it would prove to them that they have genuine faith and not **just** a profession of faith in God.

Abraham believed God and right actions were a result of his right believing. When we believe right, we will do right. **The emphasis here is always on believing, not on our good works**. You can have good works without faith.

What are the works of a born again Christian? Let's look at what **Jesus says** in this next scripture.

*"Do not **work** for food that spoils, but for food that endures to eternal life, which the Son of Man will give you. On him God the Father has placed his seal of approval. Then they asked him, "**What must we do to do the works God requires**?" Jesus answered: "**The work of God is this: to believe in the one he has sent**" (John 6:27-29, emphasis added).*

Did you see that? Working for food that spoils is the good works without true faith in God. Working for food that endures to eternal life **is to believe in Jesus**. When we believe, our actions will follow our right believing. The emphasis must be on believing in Jesus for nothing else can give us eternal life.

*"Therefore get rid of all moral filth and the evil that is so prevalent and **humbly accept** the word planted in you, which can save you" (James 1:21, emphasis added).*

He was telling them to get rid of all moral filth. The bible says that our self-righteousness is as filthy rags to the Lord (see Isaiah 64:6). When we walk in self-righteousness, we are walking in pride (moral filth). James was telling them to come out from under the law (self-righteousness) and humbly accept the gospel of Jesus, the gospel of grace and truth that would save them.

James continues on.

*"Do not **merely** listen to the word, and so deceive yourselves. Do what it says. Anyone who listens to the word but does not do what it says is like a man who looks at his face in a mirror and, after looking at himself, goes away and immediately forgets what he looks like. But the man who looks intently into the **perfect law that gives freedom** and continues to do this, not forgetting what he has heard, but **doing it** – he will be blessed in what he does" (James 1:22–25, emphasis added).*

James was saying: Do not merely listen to the word. Do not only listen to the word. In other words, you need to receive it

and believe it. How are we saved? We are saved **by grace through faith** in Jesus Christ. It is our belief in Jesus that saves us not just hearing about Jesus. So the **"doing"** here that James is talking about is believing in Jesus (believing the Word). Do not merely listen to the Word but believe it and when you believe it you will do what it says. The Word is Jesus. The Word James was preaching was the gospel of Jesus. In other words, he was telling them to believe in Jesus and receive Him. Don't just hear about Him. The perfect law that gives freedom that James was referring to is the law to believe, not the Old Covenant law. The New Covenant law is found in 1 John 3:23 "And this is his command: **to believe** in the name of his Son, Jesus Christ, and **to love** one another as he commanded us."

James was saying that if you only listen to the Word, you will walk away and forget what you heard but if you listen to the Word, receive the Word and believe the Word, you will remember the Word and your actions will follow your right believing.

> *"In the same way, was not even Rahab the prostitute considered righteous for what she did when she gave lodging to the spies and sent them off in a different direction? As the body without the spirit is dead, so faith without deeds is dead" (James 2:25–26).*

James is giving another example of true (genuine) faith. He first mentioned Abraham, now he is mentioning Rahab. She was a prostitute and God considered her righteous because of what she did. What did she do? She believed in God and because of her belief in God she risked her life and gave lodging to the spies. If she had not believed in God, she would have handed the two spies over to the King of Jericho. It was her belief in God that made her righteous and as a result of her belief in God, her actions followed and she did right. In other words, she put her faith into action and did what the Holy Spirit was guiding her to do.

Again, James was giving the unbelieving Jewish brethren an illustration of living faith. These brethren were claiming to have faith in God but had no deeds. He was describing to them that if they really believed in God, like Abraham and Rahab, good deeds would follow their right believing.

So the answer to our question above is that James was not telling them to **add** deeds to their faith to be saved. He was not saying that faith alone was not enough to save them. He was telling them that if they had genuine faith and truly believed in the Word of God, they would do what the Word told them to do. Good deeds would automatically follow their right believing.

> *"For it is by grace you have been saved, through faith – and this not from yourselves, it is the gift of God – **not by works**, so that no one can **boast**. For we are God's workmanship created in Christ Jesus to do **good works**, which God prepared in advance for us to do" (Ephesians 2:8-10, emphasis added).*

Remember one of the meanings of the word "**claims"** in James 2:14 was to boast.

So what is Paul saying here? He is saying that we are saved by grace through faith, not by works, **so that no one can boast** and then he says that we were created to do **good works**.

The word **"works"** in the phrase above: "created in Christ Jesus to do good **works**" and the word **"work"** in John 6:29 where it says: "The **work** of God is this: to believe in the one he has sent" have the same meaning. In other words, we were created in Christ Jesus to believe and because we believe, right actions will automatically follow. The good works in this scripture is to believe.

Under the Old Covenant law, obedience was the root of God's blessings. In other words, if you fully obeyed the law, you would be blessed. However, no one could fully obey the law because if you disobeyed only one commandment, you were guilty of disobeying all of the law (see James 2:10). In order to

bless His people God immediately, after giving the law, instructed His people regarding sacrifices. It was through these sacrifices that the people could be blessed by God if they disobeyed the law. When Jesus died on the cross, he fully obeyed the law for us, thus doing away with the law for the born again believer, not for the unbeliever (see 1 Timothy 1:9). Since Jesus fully obeyed the law for us, we can now enjoy the blessings of God by believing in Jesus and in His finished work; by believing what Jesus did for us in His redemptive work. He redeemed us from the curse of the law so that the blessings of God could flow in and through our lives (see Galatians 3:13-14).

I said that under the Old Covenant law, obedience was the root of God's blessings. Under the New Covenant of grace, we are not blessed because we obey the 10 commandments. That's self-righteousness. **We are blessed because by grace we believe in Jesus and what He did for us.** He fully obeyed the law for us. When we believe in Jesus and what He did for us, **the fruit of obedience to His Word** (not obedience to the Old Covenant law) will come forth in our lives automatically. Under the law, obedience is the root of our blessings, but under grace right believing in Jesus, who is our Root, produces the blessings of God. **Obedience is a fruit that stems from our right believing.** When we believe right: receiving His grace and His gift of righteousness, God's blessings will flow in our lives. When we believe right, we will obey His Word (Jesus) not because we have to but because we now want to even though we won't do it perfectly. This makes all the difference in the world.

> *"Through him and for his name's sake, we received grace and apostleship to call people from among all the Gentiles* ***to the obedience that comes from faith****" (Romans 1:5, emphasis added).*

KJV says "By whom we have received grace and apostleship, **for obedience to the faith** among all nations, for his name."

We think it is obedience to our good works and **our good deeds** when, in fact, **it is obedience to believe and to continue to believe in Jesus**. We tend to put the focus on us and the focus on what we need to do to be saved when we should have our focus on Jesus and all that He has already done for us.

Our obedience is to believe in Jesus. Everything else will follow when we believe right. Believe that you are **made** righteous because of the shed blood of Jesus. Believe that Jesus gave you His righteousness as a gift and that He took all your sins away (past, present and future sins). Believe that because of Jesus' obedience, we can now have and experience the blessings of God in our lives even when we make mistakes. We all fail at one point or another. No one is perfect except Christ. We need to believe that the blessings of God are chasing after us and overtaking us. Believe that God is for us and not against us. Believe that He is a good Father. Believe that His mercies are new every morning. Let us put our focus on Jesus and that it is His desire to bless His children. As good parents, we want our children blessed. How much more does God want to bless us, who loves us more than we could ever love our own children?

The blessings of God will flow into our lives when we believe in Jesus and because we believe in Him our faith has corresponding actions.

> *"Then I heard a loud voice in heaven say: Now have come the salvation and the power and the kingdom of our God and the authority of his Christ. For the* ***accuser*** *of our brothers, who* ***accuses them*** *before our God day and night, has been hurled down.* ***They overcame him by the blood of the Lamb and by the word of their testimony****" (Rev. 12:10-11b, emphasis added).*

We overcome the enemy of our soul by the **blood of the Lamb**, not by our obedience to the law or by our good deeds or because we have done everything perfectly. We overcome the enemy of our soul by believing in the shed blood of Jesus Christ, the Anointed One. When we got born again, we hadn't done

anything but believe in Jesus. We hadn't done any good works or done anything to obey except our obedience to believe in Jesus and receive Him as our personal Savior and Lord. Yet, the above scripture says that we are overcomers the moment we got saved. It says we are overcomers by the blood of the Lamb.

The scripture also says we overcome by the word of our testimony. What does this mean? It means that as we testify of the goodness of the Lord in the land of the living, we are overcomers/conquerors.

I am telling you today that our testimony is to testify of what Jesus has done for us. Every born again believer has a vital testimony. The testimony that takes place in the life of a believer is testifying of the goodness of the Lord to save us. Whether we were bad or good before salvation, we were all headed for hell without Jesus. Our testimony is what Jesus did for us at salvation and the changes that have taken place in our lives, our families and our thinking once we got saved. We need to start testifying about what Jesus has done for us. When we do this, we are testifying about the goodness of Jesus and we overcome the enemy of our soul.

In the book of Revelation when Jesus talks to the seven **Churches**, He ends each one with "To him who **overcomes**…."

We have often thought that to overcome we must do all the right things, like reading our Bible, praying, good works, not sinning, etc. These are all good things to do. Don't get me wrong. What I am trying to say is that in Revelation 12:11 it says that we overcome by the blood of the Lamb and by the word of our testimony. As soon as we believe in Jesus, **we are overcomers**. So when Jesus says to the seven Churches: "To him who overcomes", He is talking about believing in Him and in His finished work; what He did for us in the shedding of His blood. It says that we overcome by the blood of the Lamb and by the word of our testimony. The enemy, who is the accuser of our soul, will try to defeat us by telling us we haven't read the Bible enough, haven't prayed enough, haven't done enough good

works and that we can't be righteous because we did this bad thing. The enemy will continue to bombard us with thoughts of defeat, failure, hopelessness, etc. to keep us under his feet, but once we realize that we have been made overcomers at salvation **because of the blood of the Lamb,** we rise up against these accusations of the enemy and we put him under our feet.

When Jesus says: "To Him who overcomes", He is talking about believing in Him. We overcome by grace, through faith in Jesus, not by our good works so that no one can boast. The reason why Jesus said to the seven Churches "To him who overcomes…." was because there will always be people in Church who do not believe in Jesus and who need to overcome by the blood of the Lamb.

By saying this, am I saying that there is no room for improvement in the life of the believer? No, but not in the area of being made right with God. We are already righteous because we have been given the gift of righteousness. What I am saying is that we, as believers, need to get a revelation that we are overcomers in Christ Jesus. We need to stop putting ourselves down. We need to stop allowing the enemy to condemn us and make us feel like a failure and that we will never measure up. We need to purpose in our hearts to receive the grace of God in our lives; to receive the love of God for us personally; to allow God's Word to renew our minds so that we will have His mindset and not give any place to the thoughts that the enemy tries to implant into our minds. When we believe right, when we have genuine real faith, when we really believe that we are overcomers in Christ Jesus simply because of Jesus' shed blood, we will **want to** follow God's ways, even though we will not do it perfectly.

When our believing is right, we will follow Jesus, who is the Way. However, even when we get off course (and we will at times because our minds are in the process of being renewed with God's Word and none of us is perfect) and follow the world's ways and recognize that we have gone the world's way, do not condemn yourself but rather repent (turn from those ways

to Jesus) for you belong to Him. God wants us to walk in the Kingdom of God and not the way the world does but we will need His help to do this. We can ask for the Holy Spirit's help. He is waiting for us to ask Him for His help. He is ready, willing and eager to help us. Hebrews 4:16 says that we can approach the throne of grace with confidence so that we may receive mercy and find grace to help us in our time of need.

There is one last thing I would like to say regarding faith and works. Please read Hebrews Chapter 11 and notice that it was "by faith" that these people were able to do the things they did. It wasn't them adding these works to their faith that saved them or made them righteous. Rather it was because they believed (had genuine faith) that they were able to do what God asked them to do.

Therefore, put your focus on Jesus and getting to know Him as well as Father God and the Holy Spirit more and more (see Ephesians 1:17). Make **wanting** to get to know Him your priority. **Grow** in God's grace and peace **through the knowledge** of God and of Jesus our Lord (see 2 Peter 1:2).

➢ *How do we get Jesus to respond to us with Grace rather than the Law?*

I am going to start by setting before you two men in the Bible and we will take a look at how Jesus responded to these two men. To one, He responded with the law and to the other, He responded with grace. Why did he respond to one with the law and one with grace? Why didn't He respond to both of them the same way? Jesus looks at the heart of man. He knows what is in the heart of man. He responds to man by seeing what is in His heart. He knew how to reach each of these two men and He knows how to reach us as well.

In the first situation, **Jesus responded with the law** because this man was thinking that he could earn salvation by obeying the law. He was seeing himself as a good person who was made righteous by obeying the law. He did not see himself as a sinner in need of a Savior. He thought he was good enough to earn his own salvation which is self-righteousness. By giving this man the law, Jesus was, in fact, **extending grace** to him as He wanted him to see that he could not fully obey the whole law.

> *"A certain ruler asked him, "**Good** teacher, what must **I do** to inherit eternal life?" "Why do you call me good?" Jesus answered. "No one is good – except God alone. You know the commandments. Do not commit adultery, do not murder, do not steal, do not give false testimony, honor your father and mother." "All these I have kept since I was a boy", he said. When Jesus heard this, he said to him, "You still lack one thing. Sell everything you have and give to the poor, and you will have treasure in heaven. Then come, follow me." When he heard this, he became very sad, because he was a man of great wealth. Jesus looked at him and said, "How hard it is for the **rich** to enter the kingdom of God. Indeed, it is easier for a camel to go through the eye of a needle than for a **rich** man to enter the kingdom of God." Those who heard this asked, "Who then can be saved?" Jesus replied, "What is impossible with men is possible with God" (Luke 18:18-27, emphasis added).*

In this passage of scripture this ruler who was of the Jewish faith called Jesus a **good** teacher. He did not see Jesus as His Messiah, whom he was expecting to come, but rather he called Jesus a **good** teacher. He recognized Jesus as only a good man, nothing else. Jesus responded to this by saying that no one is good except God alone. Jesus did not rebuke the ruler for calling him "good" because He was, in fact, God. By not rebuking the ruler for calling Him "good" He was telling him that He was God. After Jesus declared that God alone is good thereby establishing that He was God, He answered the ruler's question of what he must do to inherit eternal life. The ruler thought that he could **do** something to deserve or earn eternal life so Jesus

responded by giving him the law. When we boast of our own self-efforts (our own righteousness) thinking that we can earn or deserve salvation by being good, God will respond to us with the law because we are still living under the law. He does this to bring us to the end of ourselves. So He listed five commandments for the ruler to obey and the ruler responded by saying that he has kept them since he was a boy. (Notice that in this same passage in Mark 10:20, the ruler no longer referred to Jesus as "good Teacher" but only as "Teacher" because he did not believe Jesus was God.) The ruler responded to Jesus in spiritual pride and self-righteousness. The ruler thought he was good because he obeyed the commandments which prompted another response from Jesus. Jesus then told him to sell everything he had and give it to the poor and then follow Him. He wanted the ruler to leave his riches and follow Him but since the ruler had great riches this request made him sad because he could not do what Jesus told him to do. Although this ruler obeyed the five commandments that Jesus first listed, he was not able to obey the first commandment which is "You shall have no other gods before me". This ruler was putting money before God (before following Jesus). Jesus had told this ruler that He was God by not rebuking him when he called him a good teacher. By not selling his riches and following Jesus he was putting his riches before God (before Jesus). He was not able to obey the first commandment which again is "You shall have no other gods before me". This ruler was guilty of not obeying any of the commandments because the Bible says that if you obey all the commandments except one you are guilty of not obeying any of them.

> *"For whoever keeps the whole law and yet stumbles at just one point is guilty of breaking all of it" (James 2:10).*

When Jesus said it is hard for a rich man to enter the kingdom of God, He wanted to reveal to the rich ruler his **spiritual condition**. When someone thinks they are **rich spiritually** because they are a good person and think they can earn their own way to heaven without Christ in their lives, it is

impossible for them to enter heaven just like it is impossible for a camel to go through the eye of a needle.

*"Blessed are the **poor in spirit**, for theirs is the kingdom of heaven" (Matthew 5:3, emphasis added).*

In this scripture, Jesus is also referring to a person's **spiritual condition** when He says "blessed are the **poor in spirit**". When someone recognizes their **poor spiritual condition**: that they are a sinner in need of a Savior and that Savior is Jesus Christ who is God in the flesh, that they cannot earn or deserve salvation and they come to Jesus just the way they are, Jesus says they are blessed and the kingdom of heaven belongs to them.

This ruler thought he was rich spiritually because he obeyed the commandments (so he thought) but, in fact, he was poor spiritually.

When the disciples asked Jesus who then can be saved because they knew a camel could not go through the eye of a needle, Jesus told them that it is impossible for man to save themselves but not for God to save them. Jesus was saying that man cannot earn or deserve salvation by observing the law because it is impossible to keep the whole law. Just like it is impossible for a camel to pass through the eye of a needle, it is impossible for us to obey the whole law and earn our own salvation. Salvation is found in God alone by receiving His grace through faith in Jesus Christ. He was saying to them that God is the only One who can save. They could not save themselves through their own self-righteousness. They needed the righteousness that was a gift from Jesus Himself.

Remember in John 6:27 Jesus was telling His disciples not to work for food that spoils but for food that endures to eternal life which the Son of Man would **give them**. When we believe in Jesus with our hearts, **He gives** us eternal life. It is a free gift.

*"Then they asked him, **What must we do to do the works God requires**? Jesus answered, The work of God is this: to*

believe *in the one he has sent" (John 6:28-29, emphasis added).*

The ruler thought he must **do** good works to earn salvation, to be acceptable to God and to earn His approval. He had a law mentality. It was all about his own righteousness. It was all about what he could do in himself. However, the disciples were asking God what they must do to do the works **God requires**. **They wanted to know and do what God requires**. Jesus responded to them very differently. He said that the work of God that they were to **do** is **to believe**. This ruler asked "what must **I do** to inherit eternal life" and Jesus responded with the law because of his self-righteous mentality. However, Jesus responded to the disciples question very differently because he saw their heart.

When Jesus gave the law to the rich ruler, it was in hope that he would realize his poor spiritual condition, repent and receive the free gift of salvation which is found in Jesus. It was in hope that this rich ruler would see that he was not able to fully obey the law, that he would recognize his sinful state and turn to Jesus, his Messiah, who was standing right in front of him and believe in Him.

Now let's look at a situation where **Jesus responded with grace** to another man instead of the law. He looked at this man's heart and saw that he was ready to receive His grace. This man knew his spiritual condition. He knew that he was a sinner and spiritually poor. He was not like the rich man who thought that he was able to keep all the law and earn salvation.

"Jesus entered Jericho and was passing through. A man was there by the name of Zacchaeus; he was a chief tax collector and was ***wealthy****. He wanted to see who Jesus was, but being a short man he could not, because of the crowd. So he ran ahead and climbed a sycamore fig tree to see him, since Jesus was coming that way. When Jesus reached the spot, he looked up and said to him, "Zacchaeus, come down immediately. I must stay at your house today."*

So he came down at once and welcomed him gladly. All the people saw this and began to mutter, "He has gone to be the guest of a sinner." But Zacchaeus stood up and said to the Lord, "Look, Lord! Here and now ***I give half of my possessions to the poor*** *and if I have cheated anybody out of anything, I will pay back four times the amount." Jesus said to him, "Today salvation has come to this house, because this man, too, is a son of Abraham. For the Son of Man came to seek and* ***to save what was lost****" (Luke 19:1-10, emphasis added).*

Zacchaeus was a chief tax collector who was also a Jew. He grew wealthy because he cheated people of their money. Tax collectors were known for this. They charged more taxes than the people owed and pocketed the extra. But this tax collector wanted to see Jesus so much that he climbed a sycamore tree. Jesus saw someone who was spiritually hungry for Him, unlike the rich ruler. Jesus responded to Zacchaeus with grace rather than the law. Zacchaeus knew he was a sinner where the rich ruler walked in self-righteousness. When Jesus showed Zacchaeus grace, he repented of his sins by wanting to give to the poor (unlike the rich ruler) and to pay back four times what he had stolen from people. Zacchaeus was a wealthy man just like the rich ruler but he responded to Jesus totally different than the rich ruler. He freely gave of his riches because Jesus had made such a great impact on him by extending grace to him, a sinner. Zacchaeus received salvation because he believed in Jesus (not because he gave half of his possessions to the poor) but the rich ruler did not receive salvation because he did not believe in Jesus as his Messiah. Zacchaeus knew he was lost and needed a Savior but the rich ruler did not think he needed a Savior because he had the law. The law was his savior and he thought that he could fully obey the law and by fully obeying the law he could save himself. Even though Jesus **responded** to the rich ruler with the law, He was actually **extending** His grace to him so that he could see that he could not save himself, repent and turn to Jesus.

These two very different stories are a comparison between grace and law and they had two very different outcomes. Jesus **extended** grace to each one but only one received His grace.

Now I want to take you to another scripture reference regarding the parable of a Pharisee and a Tax Collector.

> *"To some who were* ***confident of their own righteousness*** *and looked down on everybody else, Jesus told this parable: Two men went up to the temple to pray, one a Pharisee and the other a tax collector. The Pharisee stood up and prayed about himself: "God, I thank you that I am not like other men – robbers, evildoers, adulterers – or even like this tax collector. I fast twice a week and give a tenth of all I get." But the tax collector stood at a distance. He would not even look up to heaven, but beat his breast and said, "****God have mercy on me, a sinner****." I tell you that this man, rather than the other, went home justified before God. For everyone who exalts himself will be humbled, and he who humbles himself will be exalted" (Luke 18:9-14, emphasis added).*

Do you see the similarity in this parable with the scriptures regarding the rich ruler and Zacchaeus, the tax collector?

Jesus told this parable to those who were walking in self-righteousness, who were confident of their own righteousness. He said that the Pharisee, who thought he was spiritually rich, was full of self-righteousness, self-exaltation and pride. The tax collector, who knew he was spiritually poor, humbled himself before God and asked for mercy. Jesus concludes this parable by saying that the tax collector was justified (made right with God) but not the Pharisee. Jesus saw their hearts.

Let's look at another situation in the Bible. When Paul and Silas were in jail praying and singing hymns, suddenly there was a violent earthquake and the prison doors flew open and everybody's chains came loose. The jailer had been woken up from his sleep and when he saw all the doors open, he assumed

that the prisoners had all escaped and he drew his sword to kill himself but Paul reassured him that they were all there.

> *"The jailer called for lights, rushed in and fell trembling before Paul and Silas. He then brought them out and asked, "Sirs,* ***what must I do to be saved****?" (Acts 16:29-30, emphasis added).*

Remember the rich ruler asked Jesus "What must I do to inherit eternal life?" and Jesus responded by giving him the law. Well this jailer, in essence, is asking the same thing. He said, "What must I do to be saved?". How did Paul and Silas respond to this jailer?

> *"They replied, "****Believe*** *in the Lord Jesus, and you will be saved – you and your household." Then they spoke the word of the Lord to him and to all the others in his house. At that hour of the night the jailer took them and washed their wounds; then immediately he and his family were baptized. The jailer brought them into his house and set a meal before them; he was filled with joy because he had come to believe in God – he and his whole family" (Acts 16:31-34, emphasis added).*

The jailer's heart was ready to believe. The jailer responded to Paul's and Silas' message of grace to believe in Jesus. They did not give the jailer a sermon on the law or list his sins. They did not tell him to obey the commandments. They simply told him to believe in the Lord Jesus and he would be saved. The jailer was so appreciative for this message of grace and he was filled with joy because he had come to believe in Jesus.

The message of grace brings life to a responsive heart. The hearts of Zacchaeus, the tax collector and the jailer were humble but the hearts of the rich ruler and the Pharisee were full of pride (self-righteousness).

Let's look at how Jesus responded to the teachers of the law and Pharisees.

"Woe to you, teachers of the law and Pharisees, you hypocrites! You are like whitewashed tombs, which look beautiful on the outside, ***but on the inside are full of dead men's bones and everything unclean****. In the same way, on the outside you appear to people as* ***righteous*** *but* ***on the inside you are full of hypocrisy and wickedness****" (Matthew 23:27-28, emphasis added).*

Wow! Jesus was not pleased with them. He told them straight up. He did not beat around the bush. Although they looked beautiful and righteous on the outside to man, **Jesus saw their hearts** and said they were hypocrites and wicked, full of dead men's bones. He responded to their self-righteousness very harshly. When Jesus said they were wicked, He was referring to their unbelieving heart.

"Woe to you, teachers of the law and Pharisees, you hypocrites! You travel over land and sea to win a single convert, and when he becomes one, you make him twice as much a son of hell as you are" (Matthew 23:15).

The teachers of the law and Pharisees told people how to live right but they themselves did not do what they told others to do. They put heavy burdens on people that they themselves could not do. Yet they walked around as if they were able to do everything written in the law. Jesus was calling them to account. They may have fooled man but not Jesus.

Jesus was responding to them very harshly as their hearts were not responsive to Him. In Matthew 23:24 Jesus called them blind guides. They were spiritually blind. Their spiritual eyes were not opened. They thought they were spiritually rich but they were spiritually poor. They were full of pride and self-righteousness. They were like the rich ruler and the Pharisee in the scriptures you read earlier in this Chapter and they did not humble themselves before Jesus to be justified and made right with God.

If you want God to respond to you with grace rather than the law, then humble yourself before Him. Ask the Holy Spirit to help you walk humbly before God and receive His grace.

We need to admit we are sinners in need of a Savior but once we come to Jesus and receive Him as our Lord and Savior, we are no longer identified as a sinner and shouldn't refer to ourselves as a sinner although sometimes we still sin. The Bible says we are now saints (see Romans 16:15). We are now the righteousness of God in Christ Jesus. This is our new identity. Jesus, at the point of salvation, gives us His very own righteousness. We no longer walk in self-righteousness but rather we walk in His righteousness.

Let's look at the book of James. We established earlier that James is talking predominantly to the twelve tribes of Israel. James concentrates his efforts on leading his Jewish brethren to Christ.

In Chapters 3 and 4, James is talking about two kinds of wisdom.

> *"Who is wise and understanding among you? Let him show it by his good life, by deeds done* ***in the humility that comes from wisdom****. But if you harbor bitter envy and selfish ambition* ***in your hearts****, do not boast about it or deny the truth. Such "****wisdom****"* ***does not come down from heaven*** *but is* ***earthly****, unspiritual, of the devil. For where you have envy and selfish ambition, there you find disorder and every evil practice. But the* ***wisdom that comes from heaven*** *is first of all pure, then peace-loving, considerate, submissive, full of mercy and good fruit, impartial and sincere. Peacemakers who sow in peace raise a harvest of righteousness" (James 3:13-18, emphasis added).*

God looks at the heart regarding these two kinds of wisdom. It says that those who have heavenly wisdom walk in humility and do deeds from **a humble heart**. But those who harbor bitter envy and selfish ambition **in their hearts**, who are boastful and deny the truth are walking in a wisdom that is earthly, unspiritual

and of the devil. They are walking in pride. James is talking about two kinds of wisdom. One is heavenly and the other one is earthly. One is spiritual and the other one is unspiritual. One is from God and the other one is from the devil. The heavenly wisdom will bear good fruit and produce a harvest of righteousness. Those who are walking in **heavenly wisdom** have a **humble heart** but those who are walking in **worldly wisdom** have a **prideful self-righteous heart**.

It reminds me of the wise man and the foolish man (see Matthew 7:24-27). The wise man built his house on the Rock (heavenly). He had a revelation that Jesus is the Christ. He humbly responded to Jesus (the grace of God). When the winds and storms came, the house stood firm because of its foundation. However, the foolish man built his house on the sand. He did not have a revelation that Jesus is the Christ. He was full of pride and did not respond to Jesus (the grace of God). When the winds and storms came, the house fell because the foundation was only sand (earthly).

James goes on to say that those who are walking in the wrong kind of wisdom quarrel and fight just like the world does; just like those who are living without Christ in their lives (see James 4:1-5). Remember James is talking to unbelieving Jews in the hope to lead them to Jesus. He says that their heart motives are wrong. They desire **earthy things** rather than **heavenly things**. **Their attention is on themselves rather than on God**. They do not talk to God but even if they do talk to Him, they ask amiss. (Sometimes, as believers, we do this too and that is why it is so important to receive God's grace continually.)

> *"But He gives us more and more grace [power of the Holy Spirit, **to meet this evil tendency** and all others fully]. That is why He says, God sets Himself against the **proud** and haughty, **but gives grace [continually] to the lowly – those who are humble-minded [enough to receive it]**" (James 4:6, Amplified, emphasis added).*

The New International version says "God opposes the proud but gives grace to the humble".

James is saying that God will extend His grace to them to help them overcome this evil tendency (the pride in their hearts; the self-righteous lifestyle that is worldly). He says that **if they will humble themselves before God and receive His grace, they will be able to walk in the wisdom that comes from heaven**. But if their hearts are hard and full of pride, God will set Himself against them because they have rejected His grace. (Sometimes, as believers, we unknowingly reject God's grace in certain areas of our life and our hearts become proud and self-righteous just like me until I understood God's grace more fully.)

God pours out His grace to all men but only those who are humbly seeking Him will receive it. Those who are worldly, full of pride and self-righteousness will not.

"He mocks proud mockers but gives grace to the humble" (Proverbs 3:34).

God never opposes His children **who walk in His grace**; who walk humbly before Him. He will correct us and discipline us but He never opposes us. His discipline is always for our good. He will, however, oppose those who walk in self-righteousness. So when we see in scripture that God opposes the proud, He is talking to those who are walking in pride (self-righteousness) and refuse to receive His grace.

When we accept Jesus into our hearts as our personal Savior and Lord, we are humbling ourselves before Him. Our hearts are softened and we recognize our need for Him in our lives. This doesn't mean that we will do everything right the moment we are born again. However, it does mean that we are in a right position with God and our identity is changed from being a sinner to being the righteousness of God in Christ Jesus. Our spirit is completely transformed and made perfect before God. Our spirit is made completely holy. **Holy enough to house a holy God**. Our soul (our mind, will and emotions which flow out of our heart) still needs to be transformed. Our soul will be

transformed little by little for the rest of our lives as we get our minds renewed with the Word of God and begin to act more and more like Him, taking on His character, His actions, His emotions and His will.

When we are first saved we are born into the Kingdom of God as a baby. Just like a baby in the natural is fed and taken care of so that they will grow, a spiritual baby also needs to feed on the Word of God so that they will grow spiritually, now that they have tasted that the Lord is good (see 1 Peter 2:2-3).

In the scriptures, the words: prideful, self-righteous, wicked and adulterer are all referring to the unbeliever. However, the words: humble, righteous, holy and saints are all referring to the believer. It is good to know this so that when we read the scriptures, we will know when they are referring to the believer or the unbeliever.

God looks at our hearts and knows those who believe in Him and He responds to us accordingly. If you want God to respond to you with grace rather than the law, then humble yourself before Him and believe in Him. Receive His grace and His gift of righteousness and ask the Holy Spirit, who lives in you, to guide you, help you, counsel you, teach you, encourage you, etc.

Even as a Christian, we can be mixing grace and law together. Ask God to show you where you are still walking under the law so that you can **humble yourself** before Him and receive His grace and walk in His grace alone.

➢ *The Lost Son and the Self-Righteous Older Brother*

I would like to show you something in Luke Chapter 15 that you may never have seen before about the lost son and his older brother.

Let's start with verses 1–3.

*"Now the **tax collectors and sinners** were all gathering around to hear him." (We see here that the crowd that gathered around Jesus were tax collectors and sinners and they came to hear him speak.) But the **Pharisees and the teachers of the law** muttered, "This man welcomes **sinners** and eats with them". Then Jesus told **them** this parable" (Luke 15:1-3, emphasis and parenthesis added).*

First of all, before we delve any further into Chapter 15 of Luke, we need to establish who Jesus was talking to. Verse 3 says "Then Jesus told **them** this parable." Who's "them"? Verse 2 says that the Pharisees and the teachers of the law took a look at the crowd and realized that tax collectors and sinners had gathered around Jesus to hear him and they muttered and said: "This man (referring to Jesus) welcomes sinners and eats with them". In verse 3 Jesus **responds** to the muttering of the Pharisees and the teachers of the law. So we see here that Jesus is addressing the Pharisees and the teachers of the law because of their statement that Jesus welcomes sinners and eats with them.

Jesus then proceeds to give **them** (the Pharisees and the teachers of the law) three parables, all referring to something that was lost. The 1st parable refers to a lost sheep, the 2nd parable refers to a lost coin and the 3rd parable refers to a lost son.

Now, let's look at each one of these parables.

- **1st parable**

*"Suppose one of you (remember that Jesus is talking to the Pharisees and the teachers of the law) has a hundred sheep and loses one of them. Does he not leave the ninety-nine in the open country and go after the **lost sheep** until he finds it? And when he finds it, he joyfully puts it on his shoulders and goes home. Then he calls his friends and neighbors together and says, "Rejoice with me; I have found my lost sheep". I tell you that **in the same way** there will be more rejoicing in heaven over **one sinner** who repents than over ninety-nine*

righteous persons *who do not need to repent" (Luke 15:4-7, emphasis and parenthesis added).*

Who was the sinner Jesus was referring to here? Jesus tells a parable of a lost sheep but He was really referring to the tax collectors and sinners who had gathered around Him. Jesus was responding to the statement of the Pharisees and the teachers of the law: "He welcomes sinners and eats with them." Jesus was excited about the fact that the tax collectors and sinners had come to listen to Him. The Pharisees and the teachers of the law were not.

A sinner in those days (whether Jew or Gentile) was one who did not believe in God and was not following God's laws or sacrifices. However, I believe that the sinners in this scripture were Jews because Jesus was sent only to the lost sheep of Israel (see Matthew 15:24).

In this parable of the lost sheep, Jesus is talking about salvation. It was His heart's desire to save the sinner (the lost sheep). He welcomed the sinners to come to Him so that they might believe in Him.

In verse 7 he says there will be more rejoicing in heaven over one sinner who repents. The lost sheep that he is referring to here is an unsaved person. The Amplified Bible says "I tell you, there will be more joy in heaven over one (especially) **wicked person** who repents – [that is] changes his mind, abhorring his errors and misdeeds and determines to enter upon a better course of life."

Throughout the Bible, a wicked person is referred to many times and is always referring to a person who is not saved. So we understand then that a wicked person is a sinner and is opposite to a righteous person. When we believe in Jesus, we are no longer identified as a sinner even though we sometimes sin. As a believer, we are identified as the righteousness of God in Christ Jesus.

Under the New Covenant of grace, a righteous person is one who **believes** in Jesus and **receives** salvation by grace through faith and has been made righteous by the blood of the lamb. However, at the time of these parables, a righteous person was mainly a Jewish person (there may have been some non-Jews who chose to adopt Jewish customs) who had righteousness imputed or transferred to them by obeying the law and offering sacrifices to God. Jesus said in verse 7 that a righteous person does not need to repent because that person is already in right standing with God. Jesus had not yet established the New Covenant of grace. These people were still living under the Old Covenant law.

Under the Old Covenant law, the Jewish people were temporarily made righteous by the blood of the lamb that was offered up by the High Priest once a year.

In order to offer up a **sin offering**, a man (who had sinned) brought an innocent perfect spotless lamb to the priest. The priest examined the lamb (not the man) to make sure the lamb was perfect in every way. The man laid his hands on the lamb and the man's sins (did not include future sins) were imputed or transferred to the lamb.

Today, the sin offering speaks of Jesus taking our sins on His own body on the cross. He became our perfect lamb; our perfect sacrifice. Jesus became sin so that we could be free from sin in our lives (which includes future sins). Jesus took the full punishment of our sins (past, present and future sins) on the cross and He took the whole wrath of God upon Himself so that we, as believers in Jesus, will never have to experience punishment or the wrath of God for our sins

The **burnt offering** in the Old Covenant law was when the innocent perfect spotless lamb imputed or transferred its righteousness to the man.

Today, the burnt offering speaks of Jesus transferring His very own righteousness to us, as believers. He gives us the gift of righteousness and when we receive this gift we are **made**

righteous in God's eyes forever as long as we remain in the faith. The moment we believe in Jesus and invite him into our lives as our personal Savior and Lord this is what takes place. He takes away our sins and gives us His righteousness.

Under the Old Covenant law, this happened many times in the life of a man. Once a year the high priest would offer up sacrifices to God on behalf of the people and the High Priest would take the blood into the Holy of Holies and sprinkle it on the mercy seat to cover the sins of the people that had been committed over the previous year. This was done every year because of the new sins the people committed. Each year it was to cover only the sins that had been committed for the previous year, not any future sins. However, Jesus was offered up, once for all, for all our sins (past, present and future sins). So when we come to Jesus, all of our sins are cleansed and forgiven. We are made right with God once and for all time.

When Jesus spoke this parable to the Pharisees and the teachers of the law, He had not yet died for their sins. The Pharisees and the teachers of the law were made righteous by offering up sin and burnt offerings. It was the innocence or righteousness of the perfect lamb that they presented to the High Priest that was transferred to them making them righteous but that was soon going to change.

So when Jesus gave this parable, the righteous persons were people who were under the dispensation of the law, who believed in God and who had righteousness transferred to them, at that time in history, because of their many sacrifices. The lost sheep was referring to those in Israel who did not believe in God and who were not obeying the Jewish traditions, customs and laws.

- **2nd parable**

*"**Or** suppose a woman has ten silver coins and loses one. Does she not light a lamp, sweep the house and search carefully until she finds it? And when she finds it, she calls her friends and neighbors together and says, "Rejoice with me: I have found my **lost coin**." **In the same way**, I tell*

you, there is rejoicing in the presence of the angels of God over one sinner who repents" (Luke 15:8-10, emphasis added).

When he starts this 2nd parable, Jesus is giving another illustration of something that was lost by using the word "Or".

Again, Jesus is talking here about salvation. He came to save the lost sheep of Israel. This woman looked high and low for her lost coin which illustrates how exceedingly watchful and desirous God is for the lost or sinner to be saved.

There is rejoicing in heaven when a sinner repents. In both these parables, Jesus says "Rejoice with me".

Jesus was preparing them for the new Covenant He was about to establish, being the new Covenant of grace or the dispensation of grace. Once the New Covenant of grace was established, people would no longer be saved under the Old Covenant law. Jesus was bridging the way for them to move from the Old Covenant of law to the New Covenant of grace that He was about to establish.

- **3rd parable**

In this 3rd parable the father had two sons. The younger son who squandered his inheritance is like the tax collectors and the sinners who had gathered around Jesus and who were lost. He is like people today (whether Jew or Gentile) who recognize that they are sinners in need of a Savior and who humbly believe in Jesus. The older son, who is called the older brother, is like the Pharisees and the teachers of the law who Jesus was talking to **or today it could be any self-righteous religious person**.

*"**Jesus continued**: "There was a man who had two sons. The younger one said to his father, 'Father, give me my share of the estate.' So he divided his property between them. Not long after that, the younger son got together all he had, set off for a **distant country** and there squandered his wealth in wild living. After he had spent everything,*

there was a severe famine in that whole country, and he began to be in need. So he went and hired himself out to a citizen of that country, who sent him to his fields to feed pigs. He longed to fill his stomach with the pods that the pigs were eating, but no one gave him anything. ***When he came to his senses****, he said, 'How many of my father's hired men have food to spare, and here I am starving to death! I will set out and go back to my father and say to him:* ***Father, I have sinned against heaven and against you.*** *I am no longer worthy to be called your son: make me like one of your hired men.' So he got up and went to his father. But while he was still a long way off, his father saw him and was filled with compassion for him; he ran to his son, threw his arms around him and kissed him. The son said to him, 'Father, I have sinned against heaven and against you. I am no longer worthy to be called your son'. But the father said to his servants, 'Quick! Bring the* ***best robe*** *and put it on him. Put* ***a ring*** *on his finger and* ***sandals*** *on his feet. Bring the* ***fattened calf*** *and kill it.* ***Let's have a feast and celebrate, for this son of mine was dead and is alive again; he was lost and is found'****. So they began to celebrate. (Luke 15:11-24, emphasis added).*

The younger son who was living as a sinner in the world (actually living with the pigs), realized one day when all the money had run out that it was no longer desirable to live in the world. He found living in the world fruitless and unsatisfying. **He also realized that he was a sinner.** He realized his end result was death if he continued going the way he was going. He decided to return to his father. He was willing to humble himself and take the lowest place in the household just to be home with his father. This is true repentance. The above scripture says "he came to his senses". **He recognized that he was a sinner**. The father who had been waiting patiently for his son's return, when he saw him was filled with compassion and ran to his son, threw his arms around him and kissed him. What a display of grace, love and acceptance. The father is a type of our heavenly Father who will run to us with open arms when he sees our repentant heart. The son confesses his sin but the father

does not respond to his confession at all. However, the father did respond to the son when he saw the son returning home. He saw the son's repentant heart from a long way off and he ran to embrace him.

According to Jewish law, the father had the right to take his son before the Sanhedrin and have him stoned to death. However, his father, who is a type of our heavenly Father, was quick to respond to the son's returning with grace (not the law) by putting a ring on his finger, the best robe on him and sandals on his feet. He kills the fattened calf and calls for a party to celebrate his return with a feast.

He put the best robe on him. Today the robe speaks of the robe of righteousness that Jesus clothes a sinner with when he comes to Him by grace through faith.

The younger son was barefoot when he returned home because the father put sandals on his feet. Under the Old Covenant, being barefoot is symbolic of one being held in captivity. When his father put sandals on his feet it was a symbol that his younger son had been freed from captivity. Before we come to Jesus and get saved, we are held in captivity by Satan who is the god of this world. Before we are saved, Satan rules over us and is our master because Adam gave Satan dominion over him when he sinned in the Garden of Eden. When we are born into this world, we are under Satan's dominion because of Adam's sin until we come to Jesus at which time we are set free from Satan's dominion and are translated into the Kingdom of God.

In Genesis 41:41-42 when Pharaoh put Joseph in charge of the whole land of Egypt, he put a ring on his finger and dressed him in robes of fine linen (royal robes). The ring and the robe represented royalty, honor, authority and respect. Joseph was now royalty, highly honored and respected as he was second-in-command in all Egypt. He had authority over all Egypt, except for Pharaoh himself. The Bible says that, as children of God, we are kings and priests (see Revelation 1:6) and we are seated with

Jesus at the right hand of God the Father far above all rule and authority, power and dominion of the enemy (see Ephesians 1:20-21 and 2:6). We are royalty. As children of God, we have also been given authority over everything except God Himself.

The father having the fattened calf killed to feed his younger son speaks of our heavenly Father's provision of all that we need.

Let's continue on in Chapter 15.

> *Meanwhile, the older son was in the field. When he came near the house, he heard music and dancing. So* ***he called one of the servants*** *and asked him what was going on. 'Your brother has come', he replied, 'and your father has killed the fattened calf because he has him back safe and sound'. The older brother became angry and refused to go in. So his father went out and pleaded with him. But he answered his father, 'Look!* ***All these years I've been slaving for you and never disobeyed your orders****. Yet you never gave me even a young goat so I could celebrate with my friends. But when this son of yours who has squandered your property with prostitutes comes home, you kill the fattened calf for him'. 'My son', the father said, 'you are always with me, and everything I have is yours. But we had to celebrate and be glad, because this brother of yours was dead and is alive again:* ***he was lost and is found****' " (Luke 15:25-32, emphasis added).*

We see a complete contrast on how the father responded to his younger son's returning and how the older brother responded to his brother's returning. Remember I said that the older brother is like the self-righteous religious Pharisees and teachers of the law who were bound in legalism. The older brother, when talking with the father, points out the sins of his brother in verse 30, even though his brother had repented of his sins. The father never pointed out his son's sins, only the older brother, who is like someone living under the law (a religious/self-righteous person). The father says to the older brother when the older

brother points out the sins, that he could not contain himself; that he had to celebrate and be glad because his son had come home. His son's sins were not a concern to the father any longer as he had returned home. **The father was looking at the son's repentant heart, not at his sins.**

In Christ Jesus, all our sins are forgiven so our heavenly Father looks not at our sins, but at our repentant heart. In fact, when He looks at us, He sees Jesus. He sees us clothed in His robe of righteousness. He sees us seated in a place of authority with Jesus as a co-heir at His right hand. He sees us as kings and priests of the Most High God.

Repentance is not a confession of sins, rather it is when we see that we have sinned and turn to Jesus with all our heart. Many people have confessed their sins and go right back into the world and live in sin. There is no true repentance. It is not a confession of sins that changes or saves a person. It is their repentant heart.

Today, God does not want us to be like the older brother and point out other's sins. He wants us to see people through His eyes of love. Instead of pointing out their sins, pray for them.

The older brother was so focused on serving and slaving for his father that he never even had a relationship with his father. When he heard the music and dancing he didn't ask his father what the celebration was all about. Instead, he asked the servants of his father. Again, we see no relationship with his father. When he found out the reason his father was celebrating, he responded with anger and jealousy. He did not go to his father, but rather his father came to him to plead with him. When he said his father had not even given him a young goat, it was to celebrate with his friends, not with his father. He did not have a living, loving, intimate relationship with his father, only a working one. He was angry that his brother had returned home. He was full of jealousy. This sounds like someone living under the law or a religious self-righteous person just like the Pharisees and teachers of the law who Jesus spoke this parable to.

When the lost come to Jesus and we see God blessing them even though we, as believers in Jesus, are still trusting God for the manifestation of our blessings, I pray that we will not be like the older brother and respond in jealousy and anger towards God; that we would not point out their sins but rather join our Heavenly Father and **celebrate their salvation**; that we would not say "Lord, look what they have done and here I am serving you". This older son was trying to get his father's approval, acceptance and blessings by serving Him and slaving for Him. He was trying to earn his father's approval by what he did instead of simply having an intimate relationship with his father and receiving His blessings which is what his father so longed for. He thought he had earned the celebration that his younger brother was getting and that his younger brother did not deserve it. Such a person is still living under the law.

God the Father longs for intimacy with His children. He is like the lost son's father who was expectantly waiting for his son to repent and return home and who lovingly welcomed him with open arms, extended His grace to him and who blessed him with every good thing.

In this 3rd parable in verses 24 and 32 we see that the younger son was lost and found; he was dead and is alive again. The Bible says we must be born again (see John 3:1-7). Prior to the lost son's return, he is like one who is lost and needs to be born again. Sinners are people who do not believe in God. It was sinners who had gathered around Jesus. These sinners had never been born again. Jesus had not died yet so they could not have been born again. Jesus was telling the Pharisees and the teachers of the law that the reason he welcomed sinners and ate with them was that they were lost and needed salvation. He was setting the stage for the New Covenant of grace. After the lost son repented and returned home he is like one who is born again (one who was dead spiritually and who was made alive spiritually).

By giving this 3rd parable Jesus rebuked the Pharisees and the teachers of the law as he was saying that they were like the

older brother who despised sinners and who were trying to earn their salvation through the law and good works. They did not see their own sins because of their self-righteousness.

In some respects, I was like the older brother (even as a believer) because I did not understand the grace of God. I was working to earn God's love, acceptance and approval by trying to do all the right things instead of simply believing that by the blood of Jesus I was made right with God. I was trying to **develop** righteousness by doing all the right things as I did not understand that I was **made** righteous by Jesus when I first believed in Him. I was walking in a level of self-righteousness that I wasn't even aware of by trying to earn the salvation of my soul. I am so thankful that through reading a book on the grace of God I discovered that my soul is saved the same way my spirit was saved: by grace through faith in Jesus Christ (see Ephesians 2:8-9). This understanding has set me free to walk closer with Jesus, my heavenly Father and Holy Spirit than I ever did before.

If you are like the older brother, don't condemn yourself but come out from under the law and **receive** God's grace, for your righteousness comes not from slaving for Jesus but is, in fact, a free gift. Does God want us to do good works? Absolutely, but not to be made righteous or acceptable to Him. If it is good works that save us, then Jesus died for nothing. When we believe right like Abraham and Rahab, good works will automatically follow.

Many Christians today, as well as non-Christians, are trying to **earn** salvation and blessings by their own efforts (by the law) rather than simply **receiving** by grace through faith all that Jesus has done for them. We, as believers, need to come out from living under the law and receive freely all that Jesus died to give us. Let us focus on Jesus' goodness, not on our goodness for salvation.

> *"For it is by grace you have been saved, through faith – and this is **not from yourselves**, it is the **gift** of God – **not by works** so that no one can boast. For we are God's*

workmanship created in Christ Jesus ***to do good works****, which God prepared in advance for us to do." (Ephesians 2:8-9, emphasis added).*

We are saved by grace through faith. It is not our righteousness (good works) that saves us. It is by grace through faith in Jesus Christ. However, although good works do not save us, they will follow our right believing. When we try to earn salvation by our good works, we are putting the cart before the horse. We all know that the horse pulls the cart. The horse is in front and the cart behind. The horse is like salvation by grace through faith. Good works are like the cart that follows the horse. A cart cannot move without a horse to pull it.

Our problem is that we still think that in order to receive God's promises and blessings we have to do everything right. If we feel we have been doing a good job of doing everything right, we feel close to God and we feel deserving of His blessings. But when we mess up, we feel that we are undeserving of God's favor. This is still living under the law.

People will sometimes say "oh, you deserve it" because they are looking at what you are doing. No, I don't deserve it BUT because of the grace of God, He gives it to me anyway. He is not looking at my righteousness (my good works) but the righteousness that comes by grace through faith in Jesus Christ. My part is to run to Him, repent and dwell in His Presence even when I have messed up. It's not about me. It is all about Him. It's all about what Jesus has accomplished for us in His redemptive work on Calvary.

God says in His Word that our self-righteousness is like filthy rags to him (see Isaiah 64:6). It does not please him when we think we can **earn** His grace because this would mean that Jesus died on the cross for nothing. It pleases Him when, even though we have messed up, we come to Him based on the finished work of Christ on the cross, repent of our sins and accept and **receive** His grace and promises for our lives.

When our believing is right, when we know we are made right with God through the redemptive work of Christ, our living will also be right. Instead of running away from God, we will be quick to repent and run to God because we know He has already forgiven us.

We beat ourselves up because we sometimes make wrong choices. We think we are unworthy of His promises and His Presence because we have messed up. We need to get rid of the mentality and the lies of the enemy that says we have to do everything right all the time in order to receive God's promises. Remember we are a work in progress. Although we are made righteous by the blood of the Lamb our minds are in the process of being renewed with God's Word. We are born into the Kingdom of God as a spiritual baby. As we grow in Christ and get to know Him, our Heavenly Father and the Holy Spirit, we will walk in more and more freedom and victory.

When we know that we are made right with God by grace through faith, this right believing will empower and propel us forward in the plans and purposes of God because we will no longer be weighed down with thoughts of condemnation and guilt. My friends do not focus on yourself and your shortcomings. Instead, focus on Jesus and on all that He did for you. Receive His love, know that all your sins are forgiven and receive His grace that cost Him His life so that you **may live** in Him.

If you are a believer and recognize that you have been like the older brother or perhaps living under a mixture of law and grace, would you please pray the following prayer:

Prayer: Father, I realize I have been living under a mixture of law and grace. Thank You for giving me this understanding. Help me to believe right and to live by grace alone. I receive Your abundant provision of grace, and Your free gift of righteousness, to reign in life through Jesus Christ. Father, please teach me more about grace, and help me to receive all that Jesus died to give me, in Jesus' Name.

If you are like the sinner that is lost and has never been born again and would like to come to Jesus today, please pray the following prayer:

Prayer: Thank You, Jesus, that You have been waiting and longing for me to come to You. I believe that through Your one sacrifice on the cross, You bore for me all my sins and You took the full punishment for my sins upon Your body. I receive You, Jesus, into my life. I believe that You are my Savior. I make You the Lord of my life. I receive forgiveness for all of my sins. I receive Your grace (unmerited favor) in my life. I receive Your robe of righteousness. I am free from Satan's dominion over me. I am Your child and I belong to You. I receive Your continual unconditional love for me, personally. Please help me to renew my mind with Your Word. Give me revelation knowledge of truth every time I read Your Word or hear it taught or preached. I thank You, Jesus, that I am in the palm of Your hand which is a safe and secure place to be and I thank You for saving me.

If you said that prayer for the first time, there is a party going on in heaven right now for God just has to rejoice and celebrate for His child has come home.

I want to end this Chapter with the prayer that Paul prayed for the Philippian Church. You can pray this prayer over yourself and your loved ones.

> *"And this is my prayer: that* ***your love*** *may abound more and more* ***in knowledge and depth of insight****, so that you may be able to discern what is best and may be pure and blameless until the day of Christ,* ***filled with the fruit of righteousness that comes through Jesus Christ*** *– to the glory and praise of God" (Philippians 1:9-11, emphasis added).*

Freedom to Mature in Christ

*"Therefore let us leave the elementary teachings about Christ and **go on to maturity**, not laying again the foundation of repentance from acts that lead to death and of faith in God, instruction about baptisms, the laying on of hands, the resurrection of the dead, and eternal judgment" (Hebrews 6:1-2, emphasis added).*

It is essential that every believer has a proper understanding of the elementary teachings listed in the above scripture. These teachings are foundational to a believer and need to be understood so that we can apply them to our everyday living. **We cannot go onto maturity in Christ until we are firmly planted in these foundational truths.**

Let's look at the Word of God concerning these teachings listed in the above scripture.

> *"Like new born babies crave **pure spiritual milk** so that **by it** (pure spiritual milk) you may **grow up in your salvation** now that you have tasted that the Lord is good" 1 Peter 2:2-3, emphasis and parenthesis added.*

1) REPENTANCE FROM ACTS THAT LEAD TO DEATH, AND OF FAITH IN GOD

Repentance and faith in God go hand in hand. Before salvation, every person must understand that they are a sinner in

need of a Savior and that Savior is Jesus Christ. When they repent of their sins and put their faith in Jesus, they are saved.

a) Repentance from acts that lead to death

Repentance means to think differently, reconsider, change of mind with regards to sin, change of soul, turning away from sin **and turning to God**.

Notice in the following three scriptures that John the Baptist, Jesus and Peter all preached repentance. John the Baptist is speaking in the first scripture.

> *"Repent, for the kingdom of heaven is near" (Matthew 3:2).*

> *"From that time on **Jesus** began to preach, "Repent, for the kingdom of heaven is near" (Matthew 4:17, emphasis added).*

> *"**Peter** replied, "Repent and be baptized, every one of you, in the name of Jesus Christ so that your sins may be forgiven. And you will receive the gift of the Holy Spirit" (Acts 2:38, emphasis added).*

Notice in the following scripture that God's kindness leads us to repentance.

> *Or do you show contempt for the **riches of his kindness**, tolerance and patience, not realizing that **God's kindness leads you toward repentance**? (Romans 2:4, emphasis added).*

Notice in the following scripture that godly sorrow brings repentance **and leads us to salvation**.

> *"Godly sorrow brings repentance **that leads to salvation** and leaves no regret, but worldly sorrow brings death" (2 Corinthians 7:10).*

Notice in the following scripture that repentance **brings life**.

"When they heard this, they had no further objection and praised God, saying, "So then, God has even granted the Gentiles ***repentance unto life****" (Acts 11:18, emphasis added).*

Once we see our need to repent and get saved, we will have to use our faith to act on that repentance. Repentance is recognizing that we are going the wrong way and seeing our need for Jesus in our lives. It is a choice to turn from that wrong lifestyle and run into the open loving arms of Jesus Christ and receive His forgiveness and His grace to walk in the Kingdom of God. We come out of worldly living into Kingdom living. Does that mean we will do everything perfectly and never sin again? No. We are all growing in the Lord day by day and as we get our minds renewed with the Word of God and apply it to our everyday living, we will walk in more and more freedom and more and more victory. Don't let the enemy condemn you because you have not arrived. None of us has arrived. We are all on a journey in this life.

Even as a Christian, we need the help of the Holy Spirit to turn away from sin and live for God. It is only in His power that we will be able to do this. If we try to do it in our own power, we will fail. However, when we rely on God's power and grace to free us from sin, we will be victorious. Sometimes people are miraculously set free from sin but most of the time we walk out our salvation one day at a time by setting our eyes on things above and not on earthy things.

Perhaps, right now, you could take some time to talk with God in prayer about some areas in your life that you are struggling in and that you want to be free from.

Prayer of Repentance: Heavenly Father I repent of (name your sin). I ask You, Holy Spirit, to help me to overcome this sin. I ask You, Holy Spirit, to encourage me, build me up in the most holy faith, counsel me and lead me into truths that set me free. I want to walk in freedom. I can't free myself but You can and You have already made a way for me to be free. I depend on

and rely on You Lord to set me free. It is Your power working in me that gives me the victory over this sin. I receive Your forgiveness for this sin. I receive Your power, Your righteousness and Your grace to walk victoriously over this sin right now. Help me to focus on Jesus and to be righteous conscience and not sin conscience, in the mighty Name of Jesus.

If you have a major problem (stronghold) in your life, you may get the victory a little at a time as you continue to declare God's Word and the victory you have in Him. Do not give up and condemn yourself if you should fall back temporarily into that same sin again. Keep turning to God and declaring His Word, relying on His power, not your own power, and the Truth shall set you free. Receive His grace and His gift of righteousness to reign over that sin. Thank and praise God for the victory. You will begin to notice a difference and eventually have complete victory. Jesus bore this sin on the cross of Calvary for you so that you could enjoy complete freedom. Don't focus on the sin. Focus on Jesus who sets you free.

b) Faith in God

"Listen to me, Judah and people of Jerusalem! Have faith in the Lord your God and you will be upheld" (2 Chronicles 20:20b).

"Have faith in God", Jesus answered" (Mark 11:22).

"This righteousness from God comes through faith in Jesus Christ to all who believe" (Romans 3:22).

"We live by faith, not by sight" (2 Corinthians 5:7).

"Clearly no one is justified before God by the law, because, "The righteous will live by faith" (Galatians 3:11).

"Fight the good fight of the faith" (1 Timothy 6:12a).

"But my righteous one will live by faith. And if he shrinks back (to live under the law), I will not be pleased with him" (Hebrews 10:38, parenthesis added).

"And without faith it is impossible to please God, because anyone who comes to him must believe that he exists and that he rewards those who earnestly seek him" (Hebrews 11:6).

We are saved by grace through faith in Jesus Christ (see Ephesians 2:8-9). It is grace and faith together that saves us. We have faith in what grace has already made available to us. We receive God's gift of grace (Jesus) by faith. It is not by our own works or self-efforts. We cannot save ourselves. If we could save ourselves we would boast about ourselves. We would boast about how deserving we are and how we have earned our right to go to heaven. Salvation is free and comes through believing in Jesus Christ and what He did for us.

Faith is ongoing. We need faith not only for salvation but for every circumstance that we find ourselves in. **Faith is the key that unlocks everything.**

We don't always understand what God is doing in our life. This is when we will need to have faith in Him no matter what happens. The bible says that God's thoughts are higher than our thoughts and His ways are higher than our ways. God sees the whole picture and we only see a little piece at a time. God will always be with us as we go through trials and sufferings. We are not alone. He will never leave us nor forsake us. He doesn't promise us that He will remove the trial but He does promise us that He will walk through it with us. It is always His Will that we overcome the trial.

Always remember that no matter what happens in your life, God is good all the time. Every good and perfect gift comes down from God the Father who does not change like shifting shadows (see James 1:17). The devil is the one who is the thief who comes to rob, steal, kill and destroy but Jesus came to give us life to the full (see John 10:10). The devil is the one who tries to destroy us and get us to blame God for what he (the devil) is doing. I have made a choice **by faith** in my life to walk with God, to trust Him and to know that He is good all the time even

when I don't understand why I am going through tough times and even when I don't see answers to my prayers. I have made this choice by faith. **One choice that everyone can make no matter what age or what level of maturity we are at, is the choice to believe in Jesus.** The devil hates us and he hates Jesus. He is constantly roaming the earth looking for those he can devour. He wants to lie to us and deceive us so that he can rob us of our faith and get us to stop believing in Jesus. Resist him by submitting yourself to God and deciding in your heart to believe in Jesus and follow Him no matter what (see James 4:7). Of course, we always need the Holy Spirit to help us, to encourage us, to counsel us and to build us up in the most holy faith. We are not alone. God is with us. It is so important that we spend time meditating on the Word of God and getting to know how awesome our God is and that He is for us and not against us so that when the enemy tries to lie to us we will **believe** the Word of God and not his lies.

Prayer of Faith: Father God, I see in Your Word that I am to walk by faith and not by sight and that faith pleases You. Father, with the Holy Spirit's help, I choose by faith to walk with You and **believe in Jesus** all the days of my life no matter what I am going through. You will bring me through to victory. My part is to believe it. Your Word says that You are with me and even in the storms of life I can have peace, in Jesus' Name.

2) INSTRUCTION ABOUT BAPTISMS

Did you notice that the word "baptisms" in Hebrew 6:2 at the beginning of this Chapter is plural? In other words, there is more than one baptism.

Baptism means to immerse. When we immerse a piece of clothing in water, that piece of clothing becomes completely full of water and when it is taken out of the water, the water runs off of it because it cannot hold any more water.

Let's look at the different baptisms a Christian can experience.

a) Baptism into Christ Jesus

This baptism takes place **at** the new birth.

When we accept Jesus as our personal Savior and make Him the Lord of our life, we are immersed (baptized) **into** Him and **into** His Body. We are **in** Him. We are so immersed **into** Him that we become part of His body. As believers, we are clothed with His righteousness. He is **in us** and we are also **in Him**. We are one. When God the Father looks at us, He sees Jesus. We are hidden with God **in Christ Jesus**.

> *"For all of you who were baptized **into Christ** have clothed yourselves with Christ" (Galatians 3:27, emphasis added).*

When we are baptized into Christ Jesus at salvation, we are so completely filled up with Jesus that He spills out of us and overflows from us. When Jesus spills out of us, we are actually being clothed with Him. He is not only on the inside of us but He is also on the outside of us for others to see and desire what we have.

> *"The body is a unit, though it is made up of many parts; and though all its parts are many, they form one body. So it is with Christ. For we were **all baptized by one Spirit into one bod**y—whether Jews or Greeks, slave or free—and we were all given the one Spirit to drink" (1 Corinthians 12:12-13, emphasis added).*

The above scripture is talking about being baptized into the body, which is Christ. The agent who baptizes us into Christ is the Holy Spirit. He is the One who convicts us that we are sinners who need a Savior and He is the One who leads us to believe in Jesus Christ.

> *"He said to them, "Go into all the world and preach the good news to all creation. Whoever believes **and is baptized will be saved**, but whoever does not believe will be condemned" (Mark 16:15-16, emphasis added).*

Jesus was speaking in this scripture and He was giving some final instructions before He ascended into Heaven. He said go

and preach the good news, the gospel. He said whoever believes this gospel **and is baptized will be saved. When Jesus said "and is baptized" He was simply expounding on what happens when we believe.** When we believe, we are baptized into Christ Jesus. So the baptism that Jesus was talking about here is the baptism that takes place when we believe; the baptism that saves us; the baptism into Christ Jesus. The baptism into Christ Jesus is the only baptism that saves us.

The following scripture is Jesus' final words in Luke's gospel.

> *"He (Jesus) told them, "This is what is written: The Christ will suffer and rise from the dead on the third day, and repentance* ***and forgiveness of sins*** *will be preached in his name to all nations, beginning at Jerusalem. You are witnesses of these things" (Luke 24:46-48, emphasis and parenthesis added).*

Unlike Mark, Luke does not add "and be baptized". Rather, he adds "and forgiveness of sins" which also expounds on what takes place when we repent at the point of salvation. When we truly repent, Jesus forgives us of all our sins.

> *"Peter replied, "Repent and be* ***baptized****, every one of you, in the name of Jesus Christ so that your sins may be forgiven. And you will receive the gift of the Holy Spirit" (Acts 2:38, emphasis added).*

In leading up to this scripture, Peter was speaking to the crowd of people who had come into the City on the day of Pentecost and were wondering what the commotion was all about. So Peter stood up and spoke to them about Jesus' death and resurrection; that Jesus is the Christ and is now seated at the right hand of God in heaven. He spoke to them about the gospel of grace. The people were cut to the heart and **wanted to know what they needed to do to be saved**. Peter replied, "Repent **and be baptized,** every one of you, in the Name of Jesus Christ **so that your sins may be forgiven**".

Again, Peter is simply expounding on what it means to repent by saying "and be baptized". This scripture is referring to the baptism into Christ Jesus that takes place at salvation. Peter was speaking to the lost about getting saved.

Further down in verses 40-41 it says "With many other words he warned them; and he pleaded with them. Save yourselves from this corrupt generation. **Those who accepted his message were baptized**, and about three thousand were added to their number that day."

Those who believed **were baptized into Christ Jesus** and into the Kingdom of God.

The message that Peter was delivering to the people was clearly a message of salvation and the baptism here is the **baptism into Christ Jesus** for the forgiveness of their sins that takes place at the new birth.

A little further on in Acts we see the following scripture.

> *"Repent, then, **and turn to God**, so that your sins may be wiped out, that times of refreshing may come from the Lord" (Acts 3:19, emphasis added).*

Peter is speaking to the men of Israel (see Acts 3:12) and he is telling them to repent and turn to God. We have already established earlier that repentance means to think differently, reconsider, change of mind with regards to sin, change of soul, turning away from sin **and turning to God**. Repentance already includes turning to God, yet Peter says to repent and turn to God. Therefore, when Peter adds the words "and turn to God" he is simply expounding on what it means to repent. He is talking about salvation.

Here are some more scriptures that simply **expound on what it means to repent**.

> *"For John came to you to show you the way of righteousness, and you did not believe him, but the tax collectors and the prostitutes did. And even after you saw*

this, you did not ***repent and believe him****" (Matthew 21:32, emphasis added).*

"After John was put in prison, Jesus went into Galilee, proclaiming the good news of God. 'The time has come,' he said. 'The kingdom of God is near. ***Repent and believe*** *the good news!'" (Mark 1:14-5).*

"God exalted him to his own right hand as Prince and Savior that he might give ***repentance and forgiveness of sins*** *to Israel" (Acts 5:31).*

"I have declared to both Jews and Greeks that they must turn to God in ***repentance and have faith in our Lord Jesus****" (Acts 20:21).*

"I preached that they should ***repent and turn to God*** *and prove their repentance by their deeds" (Acts 26:20b).*

One further thing I would like to mention here. John's baptism was a baptism when people came confessing their sins (see Matthew 3:6 and Mark 1:5). They only confessed their sins. John told the people to believe in the one coming after him, that is, in Jesus, their Messiah. Even though many were baptized by John and confessed their sins, they were not yet baptized into Christ Jesus as their personal Savior and Lord because Jesus had not yet gone to the cross. The New Covenant of grace had not yet been established. They were still living under the Old Covenant Law. Let's look at the following scripture that says this.

*"While Apollos was at Corinth, Paul took the road through the interior and arrived at Ephesus. There he found some disciples and asked them, "Did you receive the Holy Spirit when you believed?" They answered, "No, we have not even heard that there is a Holy Spirit." So Paul asked, "Then what baptism did you receive?" "John's baptism," they replied. Paul said, "****John's baptism was a baptism of repentance****. He told the people to believe in the one coming after him, that is, in Jesus." On hearing this, they were*

baptized into the name of the Lord Jesus*" (Acts 19:1-5, emphasis added).*

In hearing Paul speak, these disciples realized that there was more than just John's baptism. Paul would have told them about Jesus, the One John said would come after him. Upon hearing the gospel, they believed and were **baptized into the Name of the Lord Jesus**. In other words, they received salvation. John's baptism did not save them. John's baptism was a confession of sins and was pointing Jews to Jesus, their Messiah, who would soon die on a cross and establish the New Covenant of grace. It was a baptism of repentance (confession of sins) and turning to God under the Old Covenant.

The water baptism we receive today is different from John's baptism. Water baptism today is a public statement or declaration of the decision we have already made to believe in Jesus as our personal Savior and Lord. I will expound more on water baptism a little later in this Chapter.

When we are baptized into Christ Jesus, He gives us His Spirit. Even though we have Jesus' Spirit living in us, this is not the baptism of the Holy Spirit. I will elaborate more on this later on in this Chapter.

There is only one baptism into Christ Jesus but it has a couple of elements or components that I would like to point out here.

i) Baptism into His Death

Now, as you read the next scripture reference, please pay close attention to the words "**being baptized into His death**". This is what happens when we are baptized into Christ Jesus at salvation.

"What shall we say, then? Shall we go on sinning so that grace may increase? By no means! We died to sin; how can we live it any longer? Or don't you know that all of us who were baptized into Christ Jesus were ***baptized into his***

__death__? We were therefore buried with him through __baptism into death__ in order that, just as Christ was raised from the dead through the glory of the Father, we too may live a new life. If we have been united with him in __his death__, we will certainly also be united with him in his resurrection. For we know that our old self was crucified with him __so that__ the body of sin might be rendered powerless, that we should no longer be slaves to sin—because __anyone who has died__ has been freed from it" (Romans 6: 1-7, emphasis added).

Did you notice in this scripture reference that we who were baptized into Christ Jesus were also **baptized into His death**? This is another element of the baptism that took place at salvation. We were baptized into Christ Jesus **and into His death**. In other words, when we were immersed, filled and clothed with Christ Jesus at salvation, we were also immersed into His death at the same time. Why? The scripture you just read says, **so that** the body of sin might be rendered powerless and **so that** we would be freed from slavery to sin (the old man/sinful nature/flesh). Being baptized into **Jesus' death** means that our old sinful fleshly nature died so that sin might be rendered powerless in our lives. Just as Jesus died to sin once for all, we are to count ourselves dead to sin (the old sinful fleshly nature) once for all. Our old sinful fleshly nature was completely immersed or baptized into **His death** at salvation. If we are having a problem overcoming sin in our life, don't let the enemy condemn you. Remind yourself that the old sinful fleshly nature is dead because we have been baptized into **Jesus' death**. Our old sinful fleshly nature died with Christ Jesus and is no longer alive. As you continue to think along these lines, sin will lose its power over you.

ii) Baptism into His Life

This next scripture reference implies that we are **baptized into Jesus' life** when it says "count yourselves dead to sin but

alive to God in Christ Jesus". This is also what happens when we are baptized into Christ Jesus at salvation.

> *"Now if we died with Christ, we believe that we will also* ***live with him****. For we know that since Christ was raised from the dead, he cannot die again; death no longer has mastery over him. The death he died, he died to sin once for all; but the life he lives, he lives to God. In the same way, count yourselves dead to sin but* ***alive to God in Christ Jesus****. Therefore, do not let sin reign in your mortal body so that you obey its evil desires. Do not offer the parts of your body to sin, as instruments of wickedness, but rather offer yourselves to God, as those who have been brought from death* ***to life****; and offer the parts of your body to him as instruments of righteousness. For sin shall not be your master, because you are not under law, but under grace" (Romans 6:8-14, emphasis added).*

Did you notice that because we died with Christ (baptized into His death) we are also **raised from the dead with Jesus to live a new life with Him**? Since we have been made alive with Christ we now have His nature (the divine nature) on the inside of us. Just as Jesus lives His life to God, we are to count ourselves alive to God in Christ Jesus, having the divine nature, once for all. We need to remind ourselves that we were resurrected with Christ and made alive with Him receiving the divine nature. This implies that we were **baptized into His life**. We are a new creature in Christ Jesus.

> *"For Christ's love compels us, because we are convinced that one died for all, and therefore all died. And he died for all, that those who live should no longer live for themselves but for him who died for them and was raised again. So from now on we regard no one from a worldly point of view. Though we once regarded Christ in this way, we do so no longer. Therefore, if anyone is in Christ, he is a new creation; the old has gone, the new has come!" (2 Corinthians 5:14-17).*

Because we believe that Jesus died for us His love now compels us to no longer look at other believers or even our self, through the eyes of our flesh but to see our self and others as we really are: a new creation in Christ even in our imperfect state. For God's Word says that the old has gone and the new has come. Paul once regarded Christ in this way. Just as he now sees Christ for who He really is, we are to see our self and other believers for who we really are. We are to see the God-given potential in our self and other believers. We are to look at our potential in Christ and not at our shortcomings for the old man is gone. We are to focus on the new creation that we really are. When we believe that our old man is dead and that we are a new creation, then and only then will we truly live for Christ.

> *"I have been crucified with Christ and I no longer live, but Christ lives in me. The life I live in the body, I live* ***by faith*** *in the Son of God, who loved me and gave himself for me" (Galatians 2:20, emphasis added).*

This scripture says: "I have been crucified…." This is past tense. This took place when I was baptized into Christ Jesus and into His death. This all happened in the spiritual realm when I believed in Jesus. Does this mean we are perfect and completely without sin in our life? No. It means **the old sinful fleshly nature has been crucified with Christ and baptized into His death**. We are no longer a sinner. This is no longer our identity. Some believers still refer to themselves as sinners. They are still identifying themselves with the sinful nature when, in fact, that sinful nature was baptized into Jesus' death at salvation. We are now to identify ourselves with Jesus' life and with who we are in Him (having the divine nature). I never refer to myself as a sinner even though I sometimes sin. I am the righteousness of God in Christ Jesus. I have His **divine nature**. This is my new identity in Christ. **I have been baptized into His resurrected life**. I have been resurrected with Him. I am a new creation in Jesus. The old has gone and the new has come. This is how we are to see ourselves. A new man/woman alive onto God and resurrected from the dead with His divine nature to live this glorious abundant new life that Jesus died to give us.

We live this new life by faith in Jesus Christ and what He has done for us.

> *"There is one body and one spirit—just as you were called to one hope when you were called—one Lord, one faith,* ***one baptism****; one God and Father of all, who is over all and through all and in all" (Ephesians 4:4-5, emphasis added).*

Notice that the above scripture refers to there being **one baptism**. Paul, in this scripture reference, is referring to the baptism into Christ Jesus, into His death and into His life which is the **only baptism that saves us** and brings us into the Family of God (the body of Christ).

If you have not yet received Jesus into your heart as your personal Savior and asked Jesus to be Lord of your life and if you would like to do that now, please pray the following prayer. When you do this and mean it with your whole heart, you become a child of God and a part of the body of Christ (the Family of God).

> *"That if you confess with your mouth, "Jesus is Lord", and believe in your heart that God raised him from the dead, you will be saved. For it is with your heart that you believe and are justified, and it is with your mouth that you confess and are saved" (Romans 10: 9-10).*

Notice that it is with your heart (not your head) that you confess and believe and are saved.

Prayer for Salvation and Baptism into Christ Jesus

Father God, I believe with my heart that Jesus died for my sins on the cross of Calvary and that He rose from the dead and is now seated in Heaven with You. I receive forgiveness for all my sins and cleansing from everything that is not of You. I receive Jesus Christ as my personal Savior and I declare that He is my Lord. Breathe Your breath of life into me. I thank You,

Jesus, with my whole heart for all that You have done for me and for saving me.

If you have said this prayer, you have been baptized into the Lord Jesus Christ, into His death and into His life. He now lives in you.

b) Water Baptism

This Baptism takes place **after** the new birth. It can take place immediately after the new birth or sometime later.

Water Baptism is not a sprinkling of water on one's forehead, but rather it is the dunking or immersing of a person in water until one is completely soaked. Remember that baptism means to immerse. In the scripture below you will notice that Jesus was baptized in the Jordan River. He was not sprinkled with water but He was fully immersed in the water.

Water Baptism does **not** save us, but rather it is a public act and declaration of the commitment we already made in our hearts when we were baptized into Christ Jesus, into His death and into His life. It is an outward sign or testimony of what Jesus has already done on the inside of us and of the commitment we made to Jesus at salvation.

As we are immersed in the waters of baptism, we are declaring and making it public that by faith our sinful nature, the old self, the old fleshly man is dead and when we are raised up out of the water, we are declaring publicly by faith that we are raised a new creature in Christ Jesus with His divine nature. By faith, the old sinful fleshly man stays dead in the water and the new man rises up out of the water to live the abundant life that Jesus gave us. **This is a public act of an inward decision made by the person who already believes in Jesus.**

Don't let the enemy lie to you and tell you that you can't be water baptized because you still sin. At salvation, our spirit is made perfect before God but our soul (which consists of our mind, will and emotions that flow out of our heart) is still in the process of being renewed with the Word of God and this will

take place for the rest of our life. As our minds are renewed with God's Word and we see ourselves through His eyes of love, we become more and more free in Jesus to do what He has called us to do.

> *"Then Jesus came from Galilee to the Jordan to be* ***baptized*** *by John. But John tried to deter him, saying, "I need to be baptized by you, and do you come to me?" Jesus replied, "Let it be so now; it is proper for us to do this to fulfill all righteousness. Then John consented" (Matthew 3:13-15, emphasis added).*

Did you notice that John tried to deter Jesus from being baptized in water (verse 13) because he did not feel worthy to baptize Him? Are there people in your life who are trying to deter you from being baptized in water for whatever reason? Is the enemy trying to deter you from being baptized in water? Don't listen to his lies. Listen to what the Word of God says about who you are in Christ Jesus. You are the righteousness of God in Christ Jesus because He gave you His righteousness. If you believe in Jesus, you are righteous even though you still sin and are not perfect. None of us is perfect. If you believe you are a sinner, you will go out and sin. If you believe that you are righteous, sin will lose its power over you and you will be free **to live** a righteous life in Christ Jesus. Keep your eyes on Jesus and keep running to Him even when you sin. The enemy wants to condemn you of your sin, but Jesus will not condemn you (see Romans 8:1). The enemy condemns you to get you to give up and turn away from Jesus. Jesus offers you the gift of no condemnation (just like the woman caught in adultery) which will empower you to go and sin no more. We need to know God's love and forgiveness personally. So listen to God and what He says about you and not to the lies of the enemy. Take a step of faith and take the plunge into water baptism.

> *"Then Jesus came to them and said, 'All authority in heaven and on earth has been given to me. Therefore, go and make disciples of all nations,* ***baptizing*** *them in the name of the Father and of the Son and of the Holy Spirit and teaching*

them to obey everything I have commanded you. And surely I am with you always to the very end of the age'" (Matthew 28:18-20).

The above scripture reference is Matthew's account of Jesus' final words. First of all, Jesus says to go and make disciples. Secondly, He says to baptize them (referring to water baptism). And thirdly, He says to teach them to obey. Matthew's account is a little different from Mark's and Luke's account on Jesus' final words. Each one recounts something of what Jesus said. The point I want to make here is that in the above scripture, Jesus instructed the disciples to baptize with water those who believe in Him. It is God's Will that all believers be baptized with water.

"Can anyone keep these people from being ***baptized with water****? They have received the Holy Spirit just as we have. So he ordered that they be baptized in the name of Jesus Christ" (Acts 10:47-48a, emphasis added).*

Peter had gone to Cornelius' house where he and his household were waiting to hear the message that Peter would bring them. In the preceding verses, Peter told Cornelius and his household about the gospel message of Jesus Christ and they believed and were baptized into Christ Jesus and at the same time were baptized with the Holy Spirit and spoke in tongues (see Acts 10:34-46). When Peter said in the above scripture "Can anyone keep these people from being baptized with water?" they were already saved.

Peter ordered them to be baptized in the Name of Jesus Christ. He was not referring to salvation because they were already saved.

The only prerequisite for water baptism is that the person must be saved.

I would like to mention here that there is no reference to infant baptism in the Bible. Jesus was not baptized as an infant.

According to the Jewish customs, Joseph and Mary took Jesus to Jerusalem to **consecrate** him to the Lord (see Luke 2:22-24).

> *"And as they went on their way, they came unto a certain water; and the eunuch said, See, here is water; what doth hinder me to be baptized? And Philip said, If thou believest with all thine heart, thou mayest. And he answered and said, "I believe that Jesus Christ is the Son of God. And he commanded the chariot to stand still: and they went down both into the water, both Philip and the eunuch; and he baptized him" (Acts 8:36-38, KJV).*

So the eunuch believed in Jesus Christ as his personal Savior and Lord first and then he was water baptized.

c) Baptism of the Holy Spirit

Another Baptism that the Bible refers to is the Baptism of the Holy Spirit which also takes place after we are saved, but can take place before or after Water Baptism. In some cases, it may take place immediately after we are saved (or born again).

The Baptism of the Holy Spirit is for all believers and takes place when we ask our Heavenly Father, in the Name of Jesus, to baptize (or immerse) us with His Spirit. The Bible says that this Baptism is a gift from God. The only prerequisite for this gift other than being saved is to desire it. When we ask for this Baptism and truly want it, Jesus immerses us with the Holy Spirit who completely fills us to overflowing with Himself. He fills us with His Spirit. The Holy Spirit is the third person of the Godhead. We need the Baptism of the Holy Spirit. Why? We will get to that.

As you read this next scripture reference please notice that Jesus was baptized with the Holy Spirit when the Holy Spirit descended from heaven and came upon Him. This was right after Jesus was water baptized.

> *"As soon as Jesus was baptized, he went up out of the water. At that moment heaven was opened, and he saw the **Spirit of God** descending like a dove and lighting on him. And a*

voice from heaven said, "This is my Son, whom I love; with him I am well pleased" (Matthew 3:16-17, emphasis added).

This happened at the very beginning of Jesus' ministry.

Notice in the following scriptures that Jesus is the agent who baptizes us with the Holy Spirit. John the Baptist is speaking in these scriptures and John was referring to Jesus when he said: "He will baptize you with the Holy Spirit".

"I baptize you with water but he will baptize you with the Holy Spirit" (Mark 1:8).

"I would not have known him, except that the one who sent me to baptize with water told me, "The man on whom you see the Spirit come down and remain is he who will baptize with the Holy Spirit" (John 1:33).

Jesus will baptize us with His Spirit. All we need to do is ask Him.

"Which of you fathers, if your son asks for a fish, will give him a snake instead? Or if he asks for an egg, will give him a scorpion? If you then, though you are evil, know how to give good gifts to your children, ***how much more will your Father in heaven give the Holy Spirit to those who ask him!****" (Luke 11:11-13, emphasis added).*

Exclamation mark. There is a great emphasis put on this statement in scripture. When we ask to be baptized with the Holy Spirit, we will be given the Holy Spirit, not something evil.

"When the apostles in Jerusalem heard that Samaria had accepted the word of God, they sent Peter and John to them. When they arrived, they prayed for them that they might receive the Holy Spirit, because the Holy Spirit ***had not*** *yet come upon any of them;* ***they had simply been baptized into the name of the Lord Jesus****. Then Peter and John placed their hands on them and they received the Holy Spirit" (Acts 8:14-17, emphasis added).*

The people had already been baptized into Christ Jesus (saved). Peter and John felt that it was necessary for them to be baptized with the Holy Spirit as well and, therefore, prayed for them by laying their hands on them so that they would be baptized with the Holy Spirit.

> *"On one occasion, while he was eating with them, he gave them this command: "Do not leave Jerusalem, but wait for* ***the gift*** *my Father promised, which you have heard me speak about. For John baptized with water, but in a few days you will be baptized with the Holy Spirit" (Acts 1:4-5, emphasis added).*

The baptism of the Holy Spirit is a gift that God wants to give to every believer. It is not just for a few but for all.

> *"While Peter was still speaking these words, the Holy Spirit came on all who heard the message. The circumcised believers who had come with Peter were astonished that the gift of the Holy Spirit had been poured out even on the Gentiles. For they heard them speaking in tongues and praising God. Then Peter said, "Can anyone keep these people from being baptized with water? They have received the Holy Spirit just as we have." So he ordered that they be baptized* ***in*** *the name of Jesus Christ" (Acts 10:44-48a).*

Cornelius and his household were baptized into Christ Jesus (saved) and immediately after were baptized with the Holy Spirit with the evidence of speaking in tongues.

I mentioned earlier about the disciples who had only received John's baptism and upon hearing Paul speak about Jesus they were baptized into the Lord Jesus Christ and were saved (see Acts 19:1-5). The following scripture reference now shows these same disciples being baptized with the Holy Spirit. This took place in their lives immediately after being saved.

> *"When Paul placed his hands on them, the Holy Spirit came on them, and they spoke in tongues and prophesied" (Acts 19:6).*

Notice in the following scripture that the Baptism of the Holy Spirit is for all believers.

> *"When the day of Pentecost came, they were all together in one place. Suddenly a sound like the blowing of a violent wind came from heaven and filled the whole house where they were sitting. They saw what seemed to be tongues of fire that separated and came to rest on each of them.* ***All of them*** *were filled with the Holy Spirit and began to speak in other tongues as the Spirit enabled them" (Acts 2:1-4, emphasis added).*

Some people have misunderstood the following verses and think that the baptism of the Holy Spirit is no longer for us today; that it has passed away. Let's read these verses.

> *"Love never fails. But where there are* ***prophecies****, they will cease; where there are* ***tongues****, they will be stilled; where there is* ***knowledge****, it will pass away. For we know in part and we prophesy in part,* ***but when perfection comes****, the imperfect disappears. When I was a child, I talked like a child, I thought like a child, I reasoned like a child. When I became a man, I put childish ways behind me. Now we see but a poor reflection as in a minor; then we shall see face to face. Now I know in part; then I shall know fully, even as I am fully known" (1 Corinthians 13:8-12, emphasis added),*

Paul was talking about love in the preceding verses and then concludes with "Love never fails". The Passion Translation says "Love never stops loving". In fact, love will always be **even in eternity** because God is love. Love will never cease. It will never pass away. Then he says "but" and he goes on to refer to prophecy, tongues and knowledge which are gifts of the Holy Spirit. He says they will pass away but not until perfection (who is Jesus) comes. When Jesus comes, love will still remain but we will no longer need the gifts of the Holy Spirit because we will be with the Lord. On this earth, we need the gifts of the Holy Spirit. On this earth, we will only know in part but when we are with the Lord we will know fully.

Is the Baptism of the Holy Spirit a one-time experience?

The scriptures point to a specific time in a believer's life when the Baptism of the Holy Spirit takes place. However, please notice that the following scripture tells us to keep getting filled and stimulated with the Holy Spirit.

> *"And do not get drunk with wine, for that is debauchery, but ever be filled and stimulated with the (Holy) Spirit" (Ephesians 5:18, Amplified).*

Importance of the Baptism of the Holy Spirit

I want to take a few minutes to tell you about why it is so important for us to be baptized with the Holy Spirit.

First of all, **Jesus said** to wait for the gift my Father promised and He goes on to say that they would be baptized with the Holy Spirit. Jesus specifically told them to wait. Why? So that He could baptize them with His Spirit. Jesus never did anything without a purpose.

Let's look at some scriptures that show Jesus' purpose in baptizing His children with His Spirit.

> *"But you will **receive power** when the Holy Spirit comes on you; and you will **be my witnesses** in Jerusalem, and in all Judea and Samaria, and to the ends of the earth" (Acts 1:8, emphasis added).*

When the 120 in the upper room were baptized with the Holy Spirit, they received **power** from God, the Holy Spirit (the 3rd person of the Trinity) and they were able to go out into all the world and be **witnesses for God**. Do you remember how Peter was so afraid when Jesus was arrested and out of fear he denied knowing Jesus three times? But after he was baptized with the Holy Spirit, He **boldly proclaimed** the good news about Jesus. He gave his first sermon starting in Acts 2:14 and three thousand people were added to the Kingdom of God that day. He had a boldness, an anointing and a power on his life that he had never experienced before.

We, too, will receive power from the Holy Spirit and be bold witnesses for God as we allow His Spirit to move in and through us.

In this next scripture, notice that the Holy Spirit gives gifts to believers.

> *"Now to each one the manifestation of the Spirit is given for the common good. To one there is given through the Spirit the message of* ***wisdom****, to another the message of* ***knowledge*** *by means of the same Spirit, to another* ***faith*** *by the same Spirit, to another gifts of* ***healing*** *by that one Spirit, to another* ***miraculous powers****, to another* ***prophecy****, to another the ability to* ***distinguish between spirits****, to another the ability* ***to speak in different kinds of tongues****, and to still another the* ***interpretation of tongues****. All these are the* ***work*** *of one and the same Spirit, and he gives them to each one, just as he determines" (1 Corinthians 12:7–11, emphasis added).*

I just listed the nine gifts given, as the Spirit determines, to those who are baptized with God's Spirit. The scripture says that these gifts are the **work** of the Holy Spirit. When we are baptized with the Holy Spirit, we are filled with the Holy Spirit and **He works through us** by giving us supernatural gifts that will bring about supernatural manifestations of God. These gifts are given to us to reveal the Holy Spirit to others.

In this next scripture, notice that the 120 in the upper room began to speak in other tongues (other languages) when they were baptized with the Holy Spirit.

> *"All of them were* ***filled*** *with the Holy Spirit and* ***began to speak in other tongues as the Spirit enabled them****" (Acts 2:4, emphasis added).*

Speaking in tongues is speaking in a language that we do not know, but somewhere in the world, there are people who actually speak that language. We call this our prayer language (or tongues).

In Acts 2:11 it says that those who were speaking in tongues were declaring the wonders of God.

Now the word "filled" in the above scripture means to imbue, influence, supply and furnish. I looked up the word "imbue" in the Webster's dictionary and it says to wet, to permeate (with ideas, emotions, etc.)

I thought this was very interesting. The Holy Spirit permeates us with His ideas, with His emotions and with His thoughts. He enlightens our minds, etc. **We need to stop and think about this. We need to allow this revelation to sink into our hearts.**

> *"In the same way, the Spirit* ***helps us*** *in our weakness. We do not know what we ought to pray, but the* ***Spirit himself intercedes for us*** *with groans that words cannot express. And he who searches our hearts knows the mind of the Spirit, because the Spirit intercedes for the saints in accordance with God's Will" (Romans 8:26-27, emphasis added).*

When we don't know how to pray in our native tongue, we can pray with our heavenly tongue. Praying in the Spirit helps our spirit to communicate with the Holy Spirit and our spirit becomes sensitive to God's Spirit. We begin to hear more clearly what God is saying to us. We begin to understand how He is guiding us in life. We receive wisdom from above. The gifts of the Holy Spirit that I just mentioned begin to flow **from us** as we align our spirit with His Spirit by praying in tongues.

"He who speaks in a tongue edifies himself" (1 Corinthians 14:4a).

This scripture says that when we speak in tongues, we are edified which means built up, strengthened, encouraged and comforted.

Do you need God to build you up, to strengthen you, to encourage you and to comfort you? I know I do. When we pray in tongues, this is what happens.

In the next scripture, notice that they not only spoke in tongues **but they prophesied** when they were baptized in the Holy Spirit.

> *"When Paul placed his hands on them, the Holy Spirit came on them, and they spoke in tongues* ***and prophesied****" (Acts 19:6, emphasis added).*

When I pray in the Spirit, I am edified, strengthened, built up, encouraged and comforted so that I can now go forth in the power of the Holy Spirit and prophesy over others for their encouragement, strengthening and comfort.

> *"Follow the way of love and eagerly desire spiritual gifts* ***especially the gift of prophecy****. But everyone who* ***prophesies*** *speaks to men for their strengthening, encouragement and comfort" (1 Corinthians 14:1, 3, emphasis added).*

These are just a few of the more obvious reasons why Jesus told His disciples to wait for the gift His father had promised which was the baptism of the Holy Spirit. Therefore, I urge you to be baptized with the Holy Spirit. Don't delay any longer. It is an essential step in a believer's life and part of the elementary teachings set out in Hebrews 6:1-2. Remember it says in Hebrews 6:1 that we cannot go on to maturity in Christ until we have been established in the elementary teachings of Christ.

I would encourage you to find a full gospel teaching Church who believes in water baptism by immersion and get water baptized and receive the baptism of the Holy Spirit. These are awesome experiences that you don't want to miss.

In fact, if you are saved and have never been baptized with the Holy Spirit and would like to receive this baptism today, you can pray this prayer.

Prayer for the Baptism of the Holy Spirit: Father God, in the Name of Jesus, I desire to be baptized with Your Holy Spirit just as Your disciples were on the Day of Pentecost. Jesus, I ask You now to completely immerse me with Your Spirit. Father God, in Jesus Name, just as Your disciples began to speak in tongues when they were filled with Your Spirit, I desire to speak in tongues. Holy Spirit I ask that You would enable me to speak in tongues and give me utterance for the glory of God. I receive this free gift from You Jesus. I receive my prayer language. I receive the gifts the Holy Spirit determines to give me. Thank You Jesus for baptizing me with Your Spirit with the evidence of speaking in tongues.

Now just open your mouth and begin **by faith** to speak but not in any known language. Begin to utter syllables and expect **by faith** that the Holy Spirit will give you your prayer language. He will not hold this back from you. **By faith**, open your mouth and begin to speak. Everything we receive from God is **by faith**. It may sound like baby talk at the beginning but just keep on going and it will begin to flow. At first, you may only get a few syllables but God will add to your prayer language and give you more as you use what He gives you. If you get a whole lot right away, praise God.

Prayer to be re-filled and stimulated with the Holy Spirit: Father God, in the Name of Jesus, I ask You to fill me afresh and anew to overflowing with Your Spirit. I need You to stimulate me again by Your Spirit causing a new excitement to arise in me to do Your Will.

3) LAYING ON OF HANDS

In the laying on of hands, power is transferred from one person to the other. The intent is that the power of God is transferred from the person praying to the one being prayed for to bring healing, deliverance, the baptism of the Holy Spirit, an impartation of gifts, etc. It is always God's intent that good is transferred to the one being prayed for. You will notice in the scriptures below that hands were laid on people and good came

to them. Although this is biblical and beneficial, we need to be careful as to whom we let lay their hands on us. The Bible says in Matthew 7:15-16a "Watch out for false prophets. They come to you in sheep's clothing, but inwardly they are ferocious wolves. By their fruit you will recognize them." Before we let someone lay their hands on us, we need to pay attention to the type of fruit they are displaying in their lives because the wrong source of power can also be transferred from them to us. We need to ask ourselves: Is it good fruit or is it bad fruit that I see operating in that person's life? Do they believe in Jesus as God? Are they walking in love? Is their teaching in accordance with God's Word? Also, we need to pray and ask the Holy Spirit to guide us to the right people for prayer. We need to be led by the Holy Spirit. He knows everything. We are never to look to people but always be looking to God who is our Healer and everything we need. If we ask for God's protection and guidance as to when we are to have hands laid on us and by whom, we can have peace that we will receive only God's power.

Likewise, the Bible says in 1 Timothy 5:22a "Do not be hasty in the laying on of hands". The Bible says in Matthew 10:16 "I am sending you out like sheep among wolves. Therefore, be as shrewd as snakes and as innocent as doves."

In other words, use wisdom and discernment in whom you lay your hands on. We should be sensitive to the Holy Spirit as to whether or not we are to lay our hands on someone or just simply pray for them without touching them.

Notice in the following scriptures that Jesus and the apostles touched or laid their hands on people **for healing**.

> *"Jesus had compassion on them and* ***touched*** *their eyes. Immediately they received their sight and followed him" (Matthew 20:34, emphasis added).*

> *"Filled with compassion, Jesus reached out his hand and* ***touched*** *the man. "I am willing," he said. "Be clean!" (Mark 1:41, emphasis added).*

*"He took her **by the hand** and said to her, "Talitha Koum!" (which means, "Little girl, I say to you, get up!")" (Mark 5:41, emphasis added).*

*"They came to Bethsaida, and some people brought a blind man and begged Jesus to **touch** him. He took the blind man **by the hand** and led him outside the village. When he had spit on the man's eyes and **put his hands on him**, Jesus asked, "Do you see anything?" He looked up and said, "I see people; they look like trees walking around." Once more Jesus **put his hands on the man's eyes**. Then his eyes were opened, his sight was restored, and he saw everything clearly" (Mark 8:22-25, emphasis added).*

*"When the sun was setting, the people brought to Jesus all who had various kinds of sickness, and **laying his hands on each one**, he healed them" (Luke 4:40, emphasis added).*

*"They laughed at him, knowing that she was dead. But he took her **by the hand** and said, "My child, get up!" Her spirit returned, and at once she stood up" (Luke 8:53, 55a, emphasis added).*

*"When Jesus saw her, he called her forward and said to her, "Woman, you are set free from your infirmity." Then he **put his hands on her**, and immediately she straightened up and praised God" (Luke 13:12-13, emphasis added).*

*"When he saw Peter and John about to enter, he asked them for money. Peter looked straight at him, as did John. Then Peter said, "Look at us!" So the man gave them his attention, expecting to get something from them. Then Peter said, "Silver or gold I do not have, but what I have I give you. In the name of Jesus Christ of Nazareth, walk." **Taking him by the hand**, he helped him up, and instantly the man's feet and ankles became strong" (Acts 3:3-7, emphasis added).*

Notice in the following scriptures that hands were laid on people **for the Baptism of the Holy Spirit**.

"Then Peter and John placed ***their hands on them*** *and they received the Holy Spirit" (Acts 8:17, emphasis added).*

"Then Ananias went to the house and entered it. ***Placing his hands*** *on Saul, he said, "Brother Saul, the Lord – Jesus, who appeared to you on the road as you were coming here – has sent me so that you may see again and be filled with the Holy Spirit." Immediately, something like scales fell from Saul's eyes, and he could see again. He got up and was baptized" (Acts 9:17-18, emphasis added).*

"When Paul ***placed his hands on them****, the Holy Spirit came on them, and they spoke in tongues, and prophesied" (Acts 19:6, emphasis added).*

Notice in the following scriptures that hands were laid on people **to impart gifts to do works of service and to minister**.

"This proposal pleased the whole group. They chose Stephen, a man full of faith and of the Holy Spirit; also Philip, Procorus, Nicanor, Timon, Parmenas and Nicolas from Antioch, a convert to Judaism. They presented these men to the apostles, who prayed and ***laid their hands on them****" (Acts 6:5-6, emphasis added).*

"While they were worshiping the Lord and fasting, the Holy Spirit said, "Set apart for me Barnabas and Saul for the work to which I have called them." So after they had fasted and prayed, they ***placed their hands on them*** *and sent them off" (Acts 13:2-3, emphasis added).*

"Do not neglect your gift, which was given you through a prophetic message when the body of elders ***laid their hands on you****" (1 Timothy 4:14, emphasis added).*

4) THE RESURRECTION OF THE DEAD

Because of Adam's sin, when we are born into this world we are born spiritually dead. Being spiritually dead simply means that our spirit man is dead to God, resulting in us being separated from God, our Creator. In John 3:3 Jesus told Nicodemus, who

was a member of the Jewish ruling council, that he needed to be born again. Nicodemus thought Jesus was talking literally but Jesus explained to him that He was talking about a spiritual rebirth; a resurrection of Nicodemus' spirit. We need to be resurrected **spiritually** in order to come into a right relationship with God.

God had a plan for mankind to be born again and come back into a right relationship with Him. So Jesus agreed to come to earth in human form as a baby and sacrifice Himself on the cross as the perfect spotless sinless Lamb of God in order to forgive us for all our sins through the shedding of His blood. He gave His life so that we could live victoriously in Him. He won the victory for us on the cross at Calvary.

The following scriptures say that it was because of Jesus' shed blood, that our sins are forgiven.

> *"This is my blood of the covenant, which is poured out for many for the forgiveness of sins" (Matthew 26:28).*

> *"God presented him as a sacrifice of atonement, through faith in his blood. He did this to demonstrate his justice, because in his forbearance he had left the sins committed beforehand unpunished" (Romans 3:25).*

Jesus shed His blood so that our sins would all be forgiven and He took the full punishment, judgment and wrath of God that was due us for our sins and redeemed us. Jesus was the perfect sacrifice. Only God could redeem us.

Notice in the following scripture that Jesus finished His redemptive work on the cross.

> *"When he had received the drink, Jesus said, 'It is finished.' With that, he bowed his head and gave up his spirit" (John 19:30).*

When Jesus said "It is finished" He was saying that He did everything that was required of Him in order to restore mankind's relationship with God.

Since Jesus died for us, we can come into a right relationship with our Heavenly Father by believing in what Jesus did for us on the cross of Calvary and receiving Him into our heart as our personal Savior and Lord. When we believe in Jesus like this we are born again. Our spirit is resurrected. We are made spiritually right with God just as Adam was before he sinned.

Since Jesus died for us, it was necessary that He be resurrected from among the dead. Let's look at the following scriptures.

> *"Seeing what was ahead, he spoke of the resurrection of the Christ, that he was not abandoned to the grave, nor did his* ***body*** *see decay" (Acts 2:31, emphasis added).*

> *"But if it is preached that Christ has been raised from the dead, how can some of you say that there is no resurrection of the dead?" (1 Corinthians 15:12).*

> *"That power is like the working of his mighty strength, which he exerted in Christ when he raised him from the dead and seated him at his right hand in the heavenly realms, far above all rule and authority, power and dominion, and every title that can be given, not only in the present age but also in the one to come And God placed all things under his feet and appointed him to be head over everything for the church, which is his body, the fullness of him who fills everything in every way." (Ephesians 1:19b-23).*

Jesus was resurrected victorious over death, hell and the grave.

Because of the finished work of Jesus on the cross for us, we are victorious in Christ.

Notice in the following scripture that we, as believers, are **spiritually** raised with Christ and seated with Him as a co-heir in heavenly places right here and now. This took place the moment we became born again. We were resurrected and we are seated

in a place of authority and victory. We are not physically seated with Christ but spiritually speaking we are.

> *"But because of his great love for us, God, who is rich in mercy, made us alive with Christ even when we were dead in transgressions – it is by grace you have been saved. And God raised us up with Christ and seated us with him* ***in the heavenly realms*** *in Christ Jesus" (Ephesians 2:4-7, emphasis added).*

The following scripture tells us that Jesus holds the keys of death and Hades.

> *"I am the Living One; I was dead, and behold I am alive for ever and ever! And I hold the keys of death and Hades" (Revelation 1:18).*

When God created Adam He gave him dominion and authority (see Genesis 1:28) and when Adam sinned, he gave his dominion and authority to Satan. It was necessary for Jesus to enter the gates of hell in order to obtain the keys of death and Hades from Satan (dominion and authority) and give them back to the Church. When Christ was raised from the dead, we were raised with Him and we are once again seated in our place of dominion and authority. Satan is under our feet, not the other way around.

Notice in the following scriptures that there will be a **physical** resurrection of the righteous.

> *"But those who are considered worthy of taking part in that age and in the resurrection from the dead will neither marry nor be given in marriage, and they can no longer die; for they are like the angels. They are God's children, since they* ***are children of the resurrection****" (Luke 20:35-36, emphasis added).*

> *"Martha answered, "I know he will rise again in the resurrection at the last day" (John 11:24).*

Notice in the following scriptures that there will be a **physical** resurrection of both the righteous and the wicked.

> *"And I have the same hope in God as these men, that there will be a resurrection of both the righteous and the wicked" (Acts 24:15).*

> *"And I saw the dead, great and small,* ***standing*** *before the throne, and the books were opened" (Revelation 20:12, emphasis added).*

Notice in the following scripture that Jesus said: "I am the resurrection and the life". He is telling us to come to Him because He is life and He is the only One who can give us life.

> *"Jesus said to her, "I am the resurrection and the life. He who believes in me will live, even though he dies; and whoever lives and believes in me will never die. Do you believe this?" (John 11:25).*

> *"The thief comes only to steal and kill and destroy; I have come that they may have life, and have it to the full" (John 10:10).*

> *"Jesus answered, "I am the way and the truth and the life. No one comes to the Father except through me" (John 14:6).*

5) ETERNAL JUDGMENT

> *"For we must all appear before the* ***judgment seat of Christ****, that each one may receive what is due him for the things done while in the body,* ***whether good or bad****" (2 Corinthians 5:10, emphasis added).*

There will be a judgment day for both the righteous (believers) and the wicked (sinners). The judgment day for the wicked will be different from the judgment day of the righteous. The wicked will be judged for their sin of rejecting Jesus and will be thrown into the lake of fire. We, as believers, will be judged for the works that we did after salvation and rewards will

be given to us. We will not be judged for our sins as our sins are all forgiven in Christ Jesus and He took our punishment for us.

Let's look at the following scripture reference regarding our works.

> *I planted the seed, Apollos watered it, but God made it grow. So neither he who plants nor he who waters is anything, but only God, who makes things grow. The man who plants and the man who waters have one purpose, and* ***each will be rewarded according to his own labor****. For we are God's fellow workers; you are God's field. God's building. By the grace God has given me, I laid a foundation as an expert builder, and someone else is building on it.* ***But each one should be careful how he builds. For no one can lay any foundation other than the one already laid, which is Jesus Christ****. If any man builds on this foundation using gold, silver, costly stones, wood, hay or straw,* ***his work will be shown for what it is****, because the Day will bring it to light. It will be revealed with fire, and the fire will test the quality of each man's work.* ***If what he has built survives, he will receive his reward****. If it is burned up, he will suffer loss; he himself will be saved, but only as one escaping through the flames" (1 Corinthians 3:6-15, emphasis added).*

When we build with gold, silver and costly stones our work will be rewarded as it will withstand the fire of the Lord. But if we build with wood, hay or straw we will not be rewarded for these works as they will not withstand the fire of the Lord. Wood, hay and straw represent the works of the flesh. However gold, silver and costly stones represent the works of the Holy Spirit. We must be very careful how we build. When we decide what we will do for the Lord without waiting for God's leading, we are running ahead of the Lord and these works are works of the flesh, not the Spirit. Always remember that the works we do are to build on the foundation of Jesus Christ. Whatever we build we need to ensure that Jesus is glorified and not ourselves. What we build should not be about ourselves but about Jesus.

Are we building a name for ourselves or for the Lord? Are our motives right or wrong? When we build, it should not be about getting a pat on the back from man, earning brownie points with man, to be recognized by man or to please man. These are works that are done with wrong motives. They are of the flesh and will be burned up on the Day of Judgment. However, when we do works that the Holy Spirit initiates and we do them with right motives so that Jesus is exalted and lives are transformed, these are works that will be rewarded. Everything we do out of reverence for Christ will be rewarded. Wood, hay and straw can also be works of the law which are actions done to earn something from God. For example: If we give to be seen by man, that's giving with a wrong motive and is of the flesh. If we give to earn or deserve something from God, that's works of the law. However, if we give as we are led by the Spirit without looking for man's approval or trying to **earn** something from God, these works are works of the Spirit and will be rewarded on the Day of Judgment.

Notice in the following scriptures that those whose names are **not** written in the Book of Life **will be thrown into the lake of fire**. When we accept Jesus as our personal Savior and Lord, our names are written in the Book of Life. God's judgment for the believer is **life and rewards in heaven** but His judgment for the unbeliever is **condemnation and hell**. The choice is ours as we have been given a free will.

> *"Then I saw a great white throne and him who was seated on it. Earth and sky fled from his presence, and there was no place for them. And I saw the dead, great and small, standing before the throne, and* ***books were opened****. Another book was opened, which is the* ***book of life****.* ***The dead were judged according to what they had done as recorded in the books****. The sea gave up the dead that were in it, and death and Hades gave up the dead that were in them, and each person was judged according to what he had done. Then death and Hades were thrown into the lake of fire. The lake of fire is the second death.* ***If anyone's name was not found written in the book of life, he was thrown***

into the lake of fire*" (Revelation 20:11-15, emphasis added).*

Whoever believes and is baptized will be ***saved****, but whoever does not believe will be* ***condemned****" (Mark 16:16, emphasis added).*

"Do not be amazed at this, for a time is coming when all who are in their graves will hear his voice and come out - - those who have done good (received Jesus) ***will rise to live****, and those who have done evil (rejected Jesus)* ***will rise to be condemned****" (John 5:28-29, emphasis and parenthesis added).*

Once again, I would like to invite you to accept Jesus into your heart as your personal Savior and make Him the Lord of your life if you have not already done so. It is God's Will and desire that none should perish but that all should come to repentance (2 Peter 3:9). Revelation 3:20 says that Jesus is standing at the door of your heart and when we open that door, He will come in. Please notice that you must open that door. He will not come in unless you open the door. He has given you a free will. Right now you can either choose life or death. God is so longing for you to choose life. Please make the right choice - - choose life!!!

Prayer for Salvation: Father God, I believe with my heart that Jesus died for my sins on the cross of Calvary and that He rose from the dead and is now seated in Heaven with You. Father, in Jesus' Name, I ask You to forgive me for the sins I have committed and to cleanse me from everything that is not of You. Jesus, I ask You to come into my heart and my life and save me. Cause an awakening in my spirit to take place that I may be spiritually alive to You, my Creator, and have an intimate and personal relationship with You, my Heavenly Father and the Holy Spirit. Breathe Your breath of life into me and fill my whole being with Yourself and bring me into the Family of God. I surrender myself to Your Holy Spirit and I choose to die to my old way of living that is not pleasing to You

and to live my life in a way that is pleasing to You as Your Spirit leads me. I thank You, Jesus, with my whole heart for all that You have done for me and for saving me.

When we understand **and apply** these elementary teachings in our lives, we will have a firm foundation and WE WILL BE ABLE TO GO ON TO MATURITY.

Freedom to Know and Walk in God's Will

Prayer: Fill us with the knowledge of Your Will O Lord.

This is my prayer for you and me today. Father, in Jesus' Name, fill us with the knowledge of Your Will. In fact, Paul prayed this prayer for the Church at Colossae.

In this Chapter, we are going to look at the book of Colossians. The apostle Paul wrote this book as he was inspired by the Holy Spirit. In Colossians 1:2 it says he was writing this book to believers and he called them holy and faithful. Why did he call them holy and faithful? Because they were faithful to believe in Jesus and since they believed in Jesus, Jesus made them holy. He goes on in verse 4 to say that he had heard of their **faith** in Christ Jesus and of the **love** they had for all the saints.

> *"For this reason, since the day we heard about you, we have not stopped praying for you" (Colossians 1:9a).*

Paul said that he was always praying for the Colossians. Then Paul goes on and tells them what he was praying to God for them.

> *"Asking God to fill you with the* ***knowledge of his will*** *through all spiritual wisdom and understanding" (Colossians 1:9b, emphasis added).*

Now, remember that Paul is speaking to believers who are already walking in **faith and love** and he prays for them by asking God to fill them with the knowledge of His Will through all spiritual wisdom and understanding. The Passion Translation says "that you would receive the perfect knowledge of **God's pleasure** over your lives making you **reservoirs** of every kind of wisdom and spiritual understanding". The Passion Translation has a note stating that God's pleasure can also be translated "**God's will**". God's Will for our life is perfect and will bring pleasure to us as we walk in it. When we walk in God's Will for our lives we will be reservoirs of every kind of wisdom and spiritual understanding. This is a **powerful prayer** that Paul prayed for the Church of Colossae and one I have been praying regularly for myself and for many others. I pray that you will make it a prayer in your own life and for others as well.

Before I go on I would like you to look at the following scripture.

> *"Paul, an apostle of Christ Jesus* ***by the will of God****, and Timothy our brother" (Colossians 1:1, emphasis added).*

Paul is saying here that it was God's Will for him to be an apostle of Christ Jesus. This was his calling and destiny in Christ. Paul knew the call of God on his life. He knew what God's **specific Will** for his life was. Do you know what God's specific Will is for your life?

Did you know that you can be saved and be doing all kinds of things for God, displaying faith and love, without being filled with the knowledge of God's Will for your life personally? Many times we, as believers, will run ahead of God or lag behind Him instead of walking right with Him in what He is calling us **specifically** to do. We are the ones making the decisions on **what we will do for God** and then asking God to bless our doings. Did you know that God does not have to bless the doings that He has not asked us to do?

A number of years ago, I did a study on the book by Henry & Richard Blackaby and Claude King called "Experiencing God".

It was a life changer for me. There are so many good points that they brought forth in this book that they elaborated on. I would like to briefly mention three of these points as I believe it will help you to understand how God fills us with the knowledge of His Will.

1. God pursues a continuing love relationship with you that is real and personal. **God pursues**.
2. God invites you to become involved with Him in His work. **God invites**.
3. God speaks by the Holy Spirit through the Bible, prayer, circumstances and the church to reveal Himself, His purposes and His way. **God speaks**.

Let's look at the first point again. **God pursues** a continuing love relationship with you that is real and personal. **It is God's Will** to have a continuing love relationship **with you** that is real and personal. God wants you to know His love for you personally. He wants you to know that His love is real. He wants you to know His love by experience; not just to know about His love but to experience His love. **It is God's Will** for you to respond to His love by believing that He loves you.

Secondly, **God invites** you to become involved with Him in His work. It is God's invitation to you to become involved with Him in what He is already doing. It is God who takes the initiative, not you. It is God who calls you and reveals His **specific Will** to you. When God is involved in something and invites you to become involved with Him, much fruit will come forth because He is in it. **It is God's Will** for you to wait for His direction and to respond to Him when He invites you to join Him.

Thirdly, **God speaks** by the Holy Spirit through the Bible, prayer, circumstances and the church to reveal first of all Himself to you and then also His purposes and His way. These are the main ways that God will reveal **His Will** to you, as a believer. **It is God's Will** for you to respond to Him when He

speaks to you. Now when God speaks, it will always be in accordance with His Word. He will never contradict His Word.

I would encourage you to get this book, Experiencing God. There is also a study book that you can get and go through by yourself or with a small group. The website for ordering this book or study guide is Lifeway.com.

I am sure you have already read in the Bible that when the Israelites were in the desert, God led them by a pillar of fire through the night and a cloud through the day. They did not just decide when and where they would go. There would have been a great confusion in the camp if each one decided on their own what they would do for God. Each one of us is a part of His body and the body needs to flow together in unison. In the natural, if your leg decides it is going to go north and your arm decides it is going to go south, your body will not function right. It is the same with the Body of Christ. Each one needs to seek God and pray to be filled with the knowledge of His Will through all spiritual wisdom and understanding so that we can all be a functioning part of the Body of Christ.

There were times God told the Israelites to set up camp and stay where they were. When God wanted them to move out, he instructed them to get ready and once they got ready they were to wait until the cloud moved if it was during the day or to wait until the pillar of fire moved if it was during the night. It was God who took the initiative to inform the people of when they were to move out and where they were to go. When we ask God to fill us with the knowledge of His Will, we are saying God I don't want to do my will. I want Your **specific Will** for my life. I want to hear You telling me what I am to do to get ready and once I am ready help me to wait until I hear You tell me to move forward and where I am to go. I am putting You in charge of my life and submitting to Your Lordship.

Colossians says we will be filled with the knowledge of God's Will through all spiritual wisdom and understanding. As we pray this prayer, the onus is now on God to lead us and guide

us. We rest in Him and wait for Him to lead. When we rest, we are believing that God will lead us. We are walking by faith in God's faithfulness to lead. If we run ahead of God we are not believing that He will lead us. While the Israelites were waiting for God to lead them, they set up camp and went about their daily lives doing what God had already instructed them to do.

One thing that is true for all of our lives is that God is continually pursuing a love relationship with us that is real and personal. **While you are waiting for God's specific Will for your life, God's practical Will is for you to respond to His pursuit of you.** This is what we do while we are waiting for God to invite us to join Him in a particular situation He is already involved in. As we respond to His pursuit of us on a daily basis, we are learning to hear God's voice and to be led by His Spirit through the Bible, through prayer, through circumstances and through the Church (for there is wisdom in the counsel of many).

Paul continues his prayer for the Colossian Church.

> *"And we pray this* ***in order that*** *you may live a life worthy of the Lord and may* ***please him*** *in every way,* ***bearing fruit*** *in every good work,* ***growing in the knowledge of God****, being* ***strengthened*** *with all power according to his glorious might so that you may have* ***great endurance and patience****, and* ***joyfully giving thanks*** *to the Father, who has qualified you to share in the inheritance of the saints in the kingdom of light" (Colossians 1:10-12, emphasis added).*

Paul tells us the reason he prayed this prayer for the Colossian Church. He said, "And we pray this". What did he pray? That they would be filled with the knowledge of God's Will through all spiritual wisdom and understanding. Then he goes on to say "And we pray this **in order that**" and then he gives six things that will result from being filled with God's Will through all spiritual wisdom and understanding. Let's look at these six things.

1. In order that "you may live a life worthy of the Lord and **may please him in every way**".

We are already pleasing to God simply because we believe in Jesus. We are His child and He loves us unconditionally. However, what Paul is talking about is being filled with the knowledge of God's Will. Does God want us to know His Will and to walk in it? Absolutely, He does. It pleases God when we want His Will for our life. It pleases God when we are willing to surrender our will to His Will.

I looked up the word "pleasing" in the concordance and it means to be agreeable; complaisance. Complaisance means the inclination to comply willingly with the wishes of others; amiability and obliging. Amiability and obliging both mean agreeableness.

In other words, Paul is talking about being willing to be agreeable with God's Will for our life. So we can read this verse that we might live a life worthy of God **complying with His Will**, **being agreeable with His Will and willing to do His Will**. So when we know God's Will for our life, we will walk in it and be agreeable and willing to do it. This pleases God.

I want to point out something else here. It does not please God when He sees us making wrong decisions that bring destruction into our lives. Just like a good parent does not want to see their child make bad choices in life that will lead them down the road to destruction, God does not want His children making wrong choices that will lead them down the road to destruction either. Just like a good parent still loves that child who makes wrong choices, our Heavenly Daddy still loves us and accepts us even when we make wrong choices. We are still the righteousness of God in Christ Jesus as believers. However, what He does desire for our life is that we come into agreement with His Will for our life for this will bring about the abundant life that Jesus died to give us.

2. In order that "you would **bear fruit in every good work**".

Remember when God initiates or invites us to join Him in what He is already doing and blessing, we will bear much fruit. Knowing God's Will and walking in it with Him, as He leads, will produce much fruit for the Kingdom of God.

3. In order that "you may **grow in the knowledge of God**".

Knowing God's Will and walking in it will cause us to grow in our knowledge of God. We will get to know Him more and more, better and better.

4. In order that "you would be **strengthened with all power according to his glorious might**".

When we know we are walking in God's Will, we will depend on His strength and be confident in Him to bring about the desired results.

5. In order that "you would have **great endurance and patience**".

When we know we are in God's perfect Will, we will have a godly confidence and continue to do what He calls us to do even if we face opposition or obstacles. If we run ahead of God and then face opposition or obstacles we will not have the confidence to endure the trials.

6. In order that "you would **joyfully give thanks to the Father**, who qualified you to share in the inheritance of the saints in the kingdom of light".

When the victory comes, we will joyfully give thanks and glory to God knowing that it was Him who called us to join Him, and He was the One who blessed the work because it was His **specific Will** for our life.

Throughout the book of Colossians Paul tells us what God's **practical** Will is while we wait for His **specific** Will to be revealed to us. He is writing to believers and praying for them to be filled with the knowledge of the Will of God through all spiritual wisdom and understanding and then he goes on to tell us

what God's **practical** Will is for our lives in the rest of the Book. I would encourage you to read the whole book of Colossians as it is filled with truths that reveal God's Will. I will mention a few things that reveal God's Will but keep in mind that this is God's **practical Will** for your life, not His commands.

> *"For he has rescued us from the dominion of darkness and brought us into the kingdom of the Son he loves, in whom we have **redemption**, the forgiveness of sins" (Colossians 1:13-14, emphasis added).*

It is God's Will that we know and be established in what He has done for us: He rescued us from the dominion of Satan by redeeming us and forgiving us of all our sins. God wants us **to know**, understand and be established in this truth so that the enemy cannot steal the word of God from our heart. **This is God's Will for our life.**

> *"Once you were alienated from God and were enemies in your minds because of your evil behavior (past tense). But now he has reconciled you by Christ's physical body through death to **present you holy** in his sight, **without blemish** and **free from accusation--, if you continue in your faith, established and firm**, not moved from the hope held out in the gospel" (Colossians 1:21-23, emphasis and parenthesis added).*

It is God's Will that we know that Christ has made us holy without blemish (no spot or wrinkle). This is how He sees us and he has freed us from all accusations (condemnation). There is a condition here and it is that we **continue** to stand firm and be established in our faith, not going back to the law to earn salvation and not rejecting our belief in Jesus for humanistic worldly beliefs. We are to continue to believe in Jesus as our personal Savior and Lord. We are to continue to stay focused on Jesus and what He has done for us. This is our hope which is found in the gospel. **This is God's Will for our life.**

> *"My purpose is that they may **be encouraged** in heart and united in love, so that they may have the full riches of*

*complete understanding, in order that they may know the mystery of God, **namely Christ**, in whom are hidden all the treasures of wisdom and knowledge" (Colossians 2:2-3, emphasis added).*

It is God's Will that we know the mystery of God which Paul says is Christ. God's Will is that **we know** His Son, Jesus Christ intimately, personally and in reality. He says that in Jesus are hidden all the treasures of wisdom and knowledge. As we get **to know** Jesus more and more we will grow in wisdom and knowledge. **This is God's Will for our life**.

*"Since, then, you have been raised with Christ, **set your hearts on things above**, where Christ is seated at the right hand of God. Set your minds on things above, not on earthly things. For you died, and your life is now hidden with Christ in God. When Christ, who is your life, appears, then you also will appear with him in glory" (Colossians 3:1-4, emphasis added).*

It is God's Will that we set our heart and mind on heavenly things, not on earthly things. In other words, although we are in this world, we are not of this world. God wants us to be influenced by His Word and the fact that we are seated in heaven with Jesus as a co-heir at the right hand of God the Father so that we will not be influenced by the temptations of this world. He wants us to focus our thoughts on the fact that when we received Christ Jesus as our Savior and Lord, our old sinful nature/fleshly man died with Him and we are now hidden in Jesus.

*"Put to death, therefore, whatever belongs to your earthly nature: sexual immorality, impurity, lust, evil desires and greed, which is idolatry. Because of these, the wrath of God is coming. You used to walk in these ways, in the life you once lived (past tense). But **now** you must rid yourselves of all such things as these: anger, rage, malice, slander, and filthy language from your lips. Do not lie to each other, **since you have taken off your old self with its practices** and have **put on the new self**, **which is being renewed in***

knowledge *in the image of its Creator" (Colossians 3:5-10, emphasis and parenthesis added).*

God's Will is that we know and believe that we are no longer sinners but the righteousness of God in Christ Jesus. When we see ourselves as righteous rather than as a sinner, we will live a righteous life. The Bible says that we are the righteousness of God in Christ Jesus **by faith**. When we give into temptation, we will need to appropriate our faith that we are still righteous in Jesus. We need to **know** and understand that we have been grafted into the tree of life, who is Jesus Christ. He is our new life and the old life is dead and gone. He is our root that supplies us with righteousness. We need to trust **by faith** that this is a reality in our life so that we will walk in it. As our minds are renewed with the Word of God and we **know** that He sees us through eyes of love, we **know** what He has done for us, we **know** who we are in Christ, we **know** the grace and love of God for us, etc., these things such as filthy language will lose its power over us and we will no longer want to participate in such things as these. **It is God's Will for us to know this and believe it**.

*"**Therefore as God's chosen people, holy and dearly loved**, clothe yourselves with compassion, kindness, humility, gentleness and patience. Bear with each other and forgive whatever grievances you may have against one another. Forgive as the Lord forgave you. **And over all these virtues put on love, which binds them all together in perfect unity**. Let the peace of Christ rule in your hearts, since as members of one body you were called to peace. And be thankful. Let the word of Christ dwell in you richly as you teach and admonish one another with all wisdom and as you sing psalms, hymns and spiritual songs with gratitude in your hearts to God. And whatever you do, whether in word or deed, do it all in the name of the Lord Jesus, giving thanks to God the Father through him" (Colossians 3:12-17, emphasis added*).

Did you notice here that God chose you and that you are holy and dearly loved? God chose you and He made you holy. This is who you are in Jesus. You are holy and dearly loved. You are chosen by God to be His child. Wow! **It is God's Will that you know** this and apply it to your everyday thinking. When you really realize this, you will walk with His compassion, His kindness, His humility, His gentleness and His patience that is already inside of you because Jesus lives in you. When you really realize that you are chosen, holy and dearly loved, you will be able to forgive as He forgave you. When God forgives, He forgets. If you are having trouble forgiving someone, ask God to help you to forgive and to give you a revelation of His love for you so that you can forgive. When you are filled with His love for you, you will find yourself loving that person. When you are filled with His love for you, the bitterness, resentment and anger towards that person will leave you and you will find yourself praying blessings over that person. Do you see that it is **God's Will** to set you free? It is for your benefit because unforgiveness will hold you in bondage. God wants **you** free. He's made His love available to you. Receive His love. Believe that He loves you and be set free.

It is God's Will that His peace rule in our heart. **It is God's Will** that we have a thankful heart. He wants us to start thanking Him for the good things in our life. This will get our minds off of ourselves and onto Him. He doesn't need exaltation but as we exalt Him our focus will move from us to Him and this will benefit us.

So let's reflect again on God's **practical Will** that we have discovered in the book of Colossians. These things are important for us to understand and apply to our life as they will prepare us to walk in God's **specific Will**. **It is God's Will** that we all receive the redemptive work of Jesus and know that all of our sins are forgiven (past, present and future sins). **It is God's Will** to set us free from all accusations and condemnation that the enemy brings. **It is God's Will** that we stand firm and be established in our faith, not going back to the law to earn salvation and not rejecting our belief in Jesus for humanistic

worldly beliefs but to continue to behold Jesus. **It is God's Will** that we know Jesus intimately, personally and in reality because in Him are hidden all the treasures of wisdom and knowledge. **It is God's Will** that our hearts and minds be set on heavenly things, not on earthy things. **It is God's Will** that we know that our identity is no longer that of a sinner. Our new identity is that we are the righteousness of God in Christ Jesus by faith. **It is God's Will** that we know we have been chosen and we have been made holy because we now live in Jesus who is holy. **It is God's Will** that we be established in His love so that we can forgive and have His peace ruling in our heart. **It is God's Will** that we be thankful.

All these things are **God's practical Will** for our life. Because you believe in Jesus and have received His life, you are saved by grace through faith and have eternal life. You cannot earn your way to heaven. It is a free gift that is received. When we get born again, we no longer look to the law to guide us as Jesus nailed the law to the cross **for the believer**. Now that we are free from the law to live our life by grace through faith, we look to the Holy Spirit to lead and guide us as to where He wants us to go, to bring change to us in the area of our conduct, to reveal truth to us that sets us free, to help us, to strengthen us in the most holy faith, to counsel us and encourage us **with His Word**. Our right conduct does not earn us a place in heaven. Our belief in Jesus and what He has done for us is the determining factor as to our eternal destiny. However, it is **God's Will** (not His command) that our conduct be in line with His Word for our freedom and the benefit of those around and about us. I want to say it again. Following God's Will is not the determining factor that will give us entrance into heaven. It is not a command to follow God's Will. **However, when we surrender to the Holy Spirit and His Will for our life, we will receive and walk in truth that sets us free and be made reservoirs of every kind of wisdom and spiritual understanding**. As a born again believer, we do not submit to God's Will because **we have to**. We submit to God's Will because we know that God is for us and not against us. We know His love and acceptance and we have received His grace

and this is what causes us to **want to** walk in all the fullness of the Will of God for our lives. When we miss the Holy Spirit, He is not going to condemn us. When we were under the law and we missed obeying all of the law, the law condemned us. The Holy Spirit does not condemn us but rather He teaches us if we miss Him.

To know **God's practical Will** is **to know** what the Word of God says and to have our soul (which is our mind, will and emotions which flow out of our heart) renewed, changed and freed by the power of His Word.

You have discovered through this Chapter some truths in the Bible that have revealed the **practical** Will of God to you. My prayer is that you will also desire God's **specific** Will for your life. Don't get impatient as you wait for His specific Will for your life. Continue to be faithful in His practical Will and in His timing He will reveal His specific Will and invite you to join Him by opening up doors for you.

> *"Therefore, **I urge** you, brothers, in view of God's mercy, to offer your bodies as living sacrifices, holy and pleasing to God – this is your spiritual act of worship. Do not conform any longer to the pattern of this world, **but be transformed by the renewing of your mind**. Then you will be able to test and approve **what God's will is** – his good, pleasing and perfect will" (Romans 12:1-2, emphasis added).*

When we get our minds renewed with the Word of God, our thinking will be transformed and we will know what God's practical and specific Will is for our life.

> *"Epaphras, who is one of you and a servant of Christ Jesus sends greetings. He is always wrestling in prayer for you, that you may stand firm in all the **Will of God**, mature and fully assured" (Colossians 4:12, emphasis **added).***

Prayer: Father, fill me and my loved ones with the knowledge of Your practical and specific Will for our life through all spiritual wisdom and understanding and help us to

surrender to Your Will day by day by the power of Your Holy Spirit. Help us to get our minds renewed with the Word of God so that our thinking will be transformed and so that we will know what Your good, pleasing and perfect Will is for our life, in Jesus' Name.

Freedom from Sickness, Disease, Lack, Mental and Emotional Bondage

"My son, pay attention to what I say; listen closely to my words. Do not let them out of your sight, ***keep them within your heart****; for they are* ***life*** *to those who find them* ***and health to a man's whole body****" (Proverbs 4:20-22, emphasis added).*

Did you see that God's Word brings life and health to our whole body?

Listen to what God is saying to you in your situation. Do what the Doctor tells you to do but pay attention and listen closely to what God says about you in His Word. Keep before you what God says. Meditate on the following scriptures and speak them **out loud** and His Word will **live** in your heart and bring **life** and **healing** to your body and soul. God's Word will be planted in your heart **as a seed** and as you meditate upon His Word **that seed will grow and produce the desired result in your life**. As the seed of God's Word is **conceived** in your heart it will sprout inside of you and give birth. **Conceive** the Word of God and it will bring forth life. Mary **conceived** the Word and she gave birth to baby Jesus.

Keep meditating on healing scriptures in God's Word until the victory is manifested in your body, for faith comes by hearing and hearing the Word of God.

The word “meditate” means to ponder, to speak or to mutter.

In other words, when we meditate upon the Word of God, we speak it out loud and we ponder it in our heart. I suggest you read this Chapter out loud. I always read God’s Word out loud unless I am in a public place.

I would like to point out something before we go on. Satan is a counterfeit and he tries to copy what God is doing. There is right meditation and there is wrong meditation. Wrong meditation is when people empty their minds to try to find peace. Right meditation is when we fill our minds and hearts with the Word of God and what Jesus has done for us in His redemptive work.

> *"O Lord my God, I called to you for help and you healed me" (Psalm 30:2).*

> *"He sent forth* ***his word and healed them****; he* ***rescued them from the grave****" (Psalm 107:20, emphasis added).*

God the Father sent forth His Word (Jesus) and healed me. Jesus died for me and literally became a curse for me. Jesus took the curse which included taking upon His body all my sickness, disease, pain, lack, mental and emotional bondage nailing it to the cross and redeeming me. He paid the ransom price for my redemption. He freed me from the curse and released His blessings (which includes healing, deliverance, provision, life and wholeness). In other words, Jesus healed me over 2,000 years ago. He paid the full purchase price and set me free. Whom the Son sets free is free indeed.

You are not too sick that God can’t heal you. The above scripture says that God rescued them from the grave (death). Think about that. Nothing is impossible with God. With man it is impossible, but not with God.

> *“For he has rescued us from the dominion of darkness and brought us into the kingdom of the Son he loves, in whom we*

*have **redemption**, the forgiveness of sins" (Colossians 1:13-14, emphasis added).*

He has rescued us from the dominion of Satan including everything that pertains to him and planted us in heavenly places with Jesus who has **redeemed us** and forgiven us of all our sins.

Redemption means to obtain the release of a captive by paying the ransom price demanded in full.

We have all seen movies where someone was kidnapped and the Kidnapper demanded ransom money. Upon payment of the ransom money in full, they would release the person whom they kidnapped.

Isaiah 61:1 says that Jesus came to proclaim **freedom for the captives**. In Jesus' redemptive work, He paid the ransom money in full. He paid the purchase price for our freedom. He redeemed us with His blood so that we could walk free from our Captor (free from sin, sickness, disease, pain, emotional bondage, lack, addictions, etc.).

All of us need Jesus' redemption. We have all been captivated by sin because of Adam's sin. The price for sin had to be paid for and sin needed to be punished so Jesus agreed to leave heaven as God and be born of a woman for the full purpose of redeeming mankind of our sin **and the punishment that was due us because of our sin**.

Sometimes we think that God is punishing us with sickness because of our sins. That is not true. Yes, sin needed to be punished but Jesus took the punishment for us. We are forgiven and will never be punished for our sins. He set us free from all punishment because we believe in Him as our personal Savior and Lord. This is the only requirement for our freedom in Christ. Don't believe the lies of the enemy that you still need to be punished for your sins.

It is so very important for us to understand what Jesus did for us and why He did it in order for us to receive His healing. So let's take a few minutes to look at Jesus' redemption.

Jesus' redemptive work started in the Garden of Gethsemane. He sweated drops of blood for us. We were on His mind.

> *"And being in anguish, he prayed more earnestly, and* ***his sweat was like drops of blood*** *falling to the ground" (Luke 22:44, emphasis added).*

Jesus was never in anguish before he entered the Garden of Gethsemane. The reason why He was in anguish in the Garden is that He knew that the sin of the world was about to be placed on Him and that He would be separated from His Father. He knew that the time had come for Him to redeem mankind.

Just prior to this He said to His apostles "My soul is overwhelmed with sorrow to the point of death" (see Matthew 26:38).

Jesus goes off by Himself in the Garden and falls with His face to the ground and prayed "My Father, if it is possible, may this cup be taken from me. Yet not as I will, **but as you Will**" (see Matthew 26:39). He was saying, if there is any other way for me to redeem mankind, let it be done but if not, may Your Will be done. Jesus surrendered to God's Will. God's Will was for Jesus to redeem mankind.

You see there is no redemption without the shedding of blood. Jesus was praying so intently in the Garden that he sweated drops of blood. Blood vessels literally broke underneath His skin from the intense pressure that was on Him and the blood formed on His skin like sweat.

Jesus was scourged with forty lashes. The whip consisted of a number of long strips of leather and attached to each strip of leather were pieces of sharp objects i.e. glass, metal, bone, etc. When the soldiers struck Jesus with this whip, the objects dug

into His flesh and as they pulled the whip back, hunks of His flesh were pulled out causing Jesus to bleed profusely. There wasn't any skin left on His back. His back was one big open wound. No wonder He needed help carrying the cross up the hill to Calvary.

The soldiers twisted together a crown of thorns and put it on His head (see John 19:2). As they pressed this crown of thorns into Jesus' head, He bled from the many punctures that the thorns caused. It says in Matthew 27:29-30 that the soldiers took a staff and hit Him over and over on His head causing the thorns to go deeper into His scalp and causing Him to bleed even more.

Jesus hands and feet were nailed to the cross and more blood flowed.

A soldier, just prior to Jesus' death, pierced His side, and blood and water flowed from Jesus.

All of this is the redemptive work of Jesus. This is what Jesus willingly did to free you and me. He redeemed us to set us free from our sins and the curse which includes sickness, disease, pain, lack, mental and emotional bondage, etc. He redeemed us to make us whole in every area of our life. **The price for our sins has been paid for by Jesus.**

I've accepted Jesus and I've received the redemptive work of Jesus. Now it is up to you. Will you believe in Jesus and in His redemptive work for you personally? Will you receive Him as your personal Savior and Lord?

Christianity is not about doing everything right. It is about believing in Jesus and what He did for us in His redemptive work. Even as a Christian, you might not know what Jesus did for you. Please get your mind renewed with the Word of God so that you will walk in the fullness of God and so that you will know Him and what He has done for you.

Sometimes when we are sick and the manifestation of healing is not coming quickly we are told that we need to have

more faith. Let me tell you something that will set you free from struggling to have more faith. We are not to put faith in our faith but rather we are to put our faith in Jesus (the Word of God) and what He has already done for us in His redemptive work. We are to put our faith in the Word of God, not in our self. We are to put our faith in God that He will do what His Word says He will do. We put our faith in His promises. We put our faith in God's faithfulness, not in our faithfulness. With that having been said, the only way we can put our faith in God's Word and promises is **to know** what Jesus has done for us and what He promises us in His Word.

> *"In him we have **redemption** through his blood, the forgiveness of sins, in accordance with the riches of God's grace that he lavished on us with all wisdom and understanding" (Ephesian 1:7, emphasis added).*

Jesus took our sins and the full punishment that was due to us because of our sins. He paid the price for our redemption in full. He became our ransom so that we could be freed from our Captor, and He gave us His very own righteousness as a gift.

> *"He did not enter by means of the blood of goats and calves, but he entered the Most Holy Place once for all by his own blood, having obtained **eternal redemption**" (Hebrews 9:12, emphasis added).*

Jesus died for us and when Jesus rose from the dead, He carried His blood into the true tabernacle in heaven and presented it to God the Father by placing it on the mercy seat. Jesus has already made healing and provision available to you and me. We receive healing and provision the same way we got saved: by grace through faith. What a wonderful Savior. What a wonderful act of love.

> *"But he was pierced for our transgressions, he was crushed for our iniquities; the punishment that brought us peace was upon him, and **by his wounds we are healed**" (Isaiah 53:5, emphasis added).*

In Jesus' redemptive work, He was scourged with forty lashes, mocked, persecuted, insulted, spit on, beaten, abused, betrayed, abandoned, rejected, blasphemed, cursed and crucified on a tree. He was wounded for us both physically and emotionally because of our sins. He took the full punishment/wrath/judgment that was due us so that when we believe in Him as our personal Savior and Lord we will never be punished or judged for our sins. His back was ripped open from the forty lashes, His scalp was penetrated profusely from the crown of thorns, His hands and feet were nailed to the cross and His side was pierced by the spear of the soldier. By these wounds we **are** healed, not going to be healed. The scripture says that we **are** healed. We believe this by faith. In fact, we **were** healed over 2,000 years ago. The manifestation of healing will come forth by believing God's Word, believing that we are healed and by planting His Word into our hearts so that it will bring forth **life** and **health**.

> *"**Give thanks** to the Lord, for he is good; his love endures forever. **Let the redeemed of the Lord say this** – those he redeemed from the hand of the foe" (Psalm 107:1-2, emphasis added).*

Let us give thanks to the Lord for redeeming us. He paid the price for our redemption which includes forgiveness of sins, physical, emotional and mental healing, deliverance, wholeness, provision in every area of our lives and victory. We are no longer victims. We are Victors/Conquerors/Overcomers in Christ Jesus. Let us praise God for what He has done for us.

> *"Heal me, O Lord, and I will be healed; save me and I will be saved, for you are the one **I praise**" (Jeremiah 17:14, emphasis added).*

Declaration: Jesus you already healed me over 2,000 years ago in Your redemptive work and You took the curse and destroyed it in my life by nailing it to the cross. Therefore, I declare, by faith in your finished works, that I am healed, delivered, freed, made whole and well provided for. I am

redeemed by Your blood. I am forgiven. You paid the full ransom price and delivered me from all sickness, mental, emotional and physical pain, lack, etc. I am free. You set me free. Thank You for all that You did for me. I praise You and glorify Your holy Name for You alone are worthy to be praised. I exalt You and honor You and bless You for You are good all the time.

> *"It was I who taught Ephraim to walk, taking them by the arms;* ***but they did not realize it was I who healed them****. I led them with cords of human kindness, with ties of love; I lifted the yoke from their neck and bent down to feed them" (Hosea 11:3-4, emphasis added).*

Prayer: Father, in Jesus' Name, **help me to recognize** all that Jesus accomplished for me. **Help me to recognize** Your kindness, Your love for me personally and Your provision. **Help me to recognize** Your delivering hand upon me, Your healing touch in my life and help me to give You all the glory.

> *"People brought all their sick to him and begged him to let the sick just touch the edge of his cloak, and* ***all*** *who touched him were healed" (Matthew 14:36, emphasis added).*

> *"Large crowds followed him and he healed them there" (Matthew 19:2).*

> *"The blind and the lame came to him at the temple, and he healed them" (Matthew 21:14).*

Prayer: Just like people brought the sick to You, Jesus, I come before You and I thank You for healing me (mention those specific areas in your body and soul that you are believing God for healing). I receive Your healing now. I receive my inheritance in Christ Jesus. Healing is part of my inheritance. It belongs to me as Your child. Thank You for the manifestation of Your healing in my body and soul. Help me to grasp by faith what grace has already made available to me.

*"When the sun was setting, the people brought to Jesus **all** who had various kinds of sickness, and laying his hands **on each one**, he healed them" (Luke 4:40, emphasis added).*

*"Hearing this, Jesus said to Jairus, 'Don't be afraid; **just believe**, and she will be healed' " (Luke 8:50, emphasis added).*

We don't have to do everything right to be healed. We don't have to be perfect before God will heal us. Jesus told Jairus to not be afraid and to believe in order for his daughter to be healed.

*"But the crowds learned about it and followed him. He **welcomed them** and spoke to them about the kingdom of God, and healed those who needed healing" (Luke 9:11, emphasis added).*

Just like Jesus welcomed the crowds, He welcomes me into His Presence. He will not turn me away. As a believer, He does not judge me for my sins because He took the full judgment of God for me in His redemptive work. He will not condemn me. He loves me unconditionally.

Prayer: I receive Your healing, Jesus, for You care for me. No weapon formed against me shall prevail. It will not prosper in my life. It will bear no fruit in my body or in my soul for You are for me and not against me. By your wounds, I am healed.

"Even while the boy was coming, the demon threw him to the ground in a convulsion. But Jesus rebuked the evil spirit, healed the boy and gave him back to his father" (Luke 9:42).

God is the same yesterday, today and forever. What Jesus did when He walked on earth, He is still doing today. He came to set the captives free. Whom the Son sets free is free indeed.

Prayer: I come to You, Jesus, and I receive the freedom that You died to give me. I receive the victory that You accomplished for me in Your redemptive work. I praise You and

thank You for wholeness. By faith in your redemptive work, I declare that I am healed, delivered, made whole and set free.

> *"You know what has happened throughout Judea, beginning in Galilee after the baptism that John preached-how God anointed Jesus of Nazareth with the Holy Spirit and power, and how he went around doing good and healing **all** who were under the power of the devil, because God was with him" (Acts 10:37-38, emphasis added).*

> *"Crowds gathered also from the towns around Jerusalem, bringing their sick and those tormented by evil spirits, and **all** of them were healed" (Acts 5:16, emphasis added).*

> *"Philip went down to a city in Samaria and proclaimed the Christ there. When the crowds heard Philip and saw the miraculous signs he did, they all paid close attention to what he said. With shrieks, evil spirits came out of many, and many paralytics and cripples were healed. So there was great joy in that city" (Acts 8:5-7).*

> *"His father was sick in bed, suffering from fever and dysentery. Paul went in to see him and, after prayer, placed his hands on him and healed him. When this had happened, the rest of the sick on the island came and were cured" (Acts 28:8-9).*

These scriptures tell us that Jesus' disciples were going around healing the sick and people who were oppressed not only physically but emotionally and mentally as well. They followed Jesus' example. They prayed for the sick, laid their hands on the sick and the sick were healed. **It is God's Will for us to be healed and be in good health (spirit, soul and body).**

> *"Praise the Lord, O my soul; all my inmost being, praise his holy name. Praise the Lord, O my soul, and forget not all his benefits—who forgives all **your** sins and heals all **your** diseases, who redeems **your** life from the pit and crowns you with love and compassion, who satisfies **your** desires with*

*good things so that **your** youth is renewed like the eagle's" (Psalm 103:1-5, emphasis added).*

The Psalmist spoke to his soul. We can speak to our soul as well. We can tell our soul to put our trust in God. We can tell our soul to praise the Lord who alone is worthy to be praised. We can tell our soul to remember that God is good, loving and compassionate, who forgave all our sins and healed all our diseases. Hallelujah!

Read the above verses again but where it says "your" say "my" to make it personal. Ponder these truths in your heart and believe what God's Word says about you.

*"He **heals the brokenhearted** and binds up their wounds" (Psalm 147:3, emphasis added).*

Jesus not only heals my body but he also heals my soul (my mind, my thoughts, my will, my emotions which flow out of my heart). In other words, He heals the hurts and wounds in my heart.

*"Dear friend, I pray that you may enjoy good health and that all may go well with you, even as your **soul** is getting along well" (3 John:2, emphasis added).*

Jesus wants us to enjoy good health spiritually, emotionally, mentally, physically and financially. This is His desire for us. That is why He did what He did for us in His redemptive work. He came to make us whole in every area of our lives (spirit, soul and body).

Prayer: Thank You, Jesus, for healing my **soul as well as my body**. Thank You that I have blessed emotions. You nailed all my negative emotions to the cross of Calvary so that I could be whole in You. I receive wholeness to my emotions now. I am filled with heavenly emotions: love, joy and peace. Thank You, Jesus, that I have Your emotions.

"Trust in the Lord with all your heart and lean not on your own understanding; in all your ways acknowledge him, and he will make your paths straight. Do not be wise in your own eyes; fear the Lord and shun evil. ***This will bring health to your body and nourishment to your bones****" (Proverbs 3:5-8, emphasis added).*

Think about this scripture for it is self-explanatory.

*"****Pleasant words*** *are a honeycomb,* ***sweet to the soul and healing to the bones****" (Proverbs 16:24, emphasis added).*

"A cheerful look brings joy to the heart, and ***good news gives health to the bones****" (Proverbs 15:30, emphasis added).*

God's Word is the good news that brings health to me. God's Word brings life and healing to my spirit, soul and body. It is alive and actively working in me as I meditate upon it.

"If my people, who are called by my name, will humble themselves and pray and ***seek my face*** *and turn from their wicked ways, then will I hear from heaven and will forgive their* ***sin*** *and will* ***heal*** *their land" (2 Chronicles 7:14, emphasis added).*

When does God forgive us of our sins? When we are saved! God's healing is our inheritance and can be received the moment we are saved (forgiven). Forgiveness of sins and healing go hand in hand. They are both part of our salvation. They are both part of the redemptive work of Jesus Christ. This scripture is talking about salvation. It is talking about humbling ourselves before God and receiving salvation which includes the forgiveness of our sins and healing. In fact, this scripture refers to sin (singular). The only sin that will send us to hell is the sin of rejecting Jesus as our personal Savior and Lord.

Prayer: Thank you, Father, that I have already humbled myself before You by believing in Jesus and what He has done

for me. Because I believe I am forgiven and I am healed, in Jesus' Name. Help me to seek Your face daily and to get my mind renewed with Your Word which will transform my thinking and my ways.

"Be merciful to me, Lord, for I am faint" (Psalm 6:2a).

God is a merciful and gracious God. When I am weak, He is strong. I need Him and want Him in my life 24/7. If you desire this, tell Him in your own words.

*"When he came down from the mountainside, large crowds followed him. A man with leprosy came and knelt before him and said, "Lord, if you are willing, you can make me clean." Jesus reached out his hand and touched the man. "**I am willing**", he said. "**Be clean!**" Immediately he was cured of his leprosy" (Matthew 8:1-3, emphasis added).*

It is God's will for me to be healed. Jesus **IS** willing to heal me. In fact, He has already done it. I put my faith in the grace of God and the fact that my sins are forgiven and I am clean.

Prayer: Jesus I receive your cleansing power. I am clean.

*"Who **wants** all men to be saved and to come to a knowledge of the truth" (1 Timothy 2:4, emphasis added).*

The word "wants" in this scripture is the same Greek word for "willing" in Matthew 8:3 above. Just like Jesus wants me to be saved so that I can have a relationship with Him, he wants my soul and body healed. The way God feels about salvation is the exact same way He feels about healing.

*"When Jesus had entered Capernaum, a centurion came to him, asking for help. Lord, he said, my servant lies at home paralyzed and in terrible suffering. **Jesus said to him, I will go and heal him**" (Matthew 8:5-7, emphasis added).*

Jesus willingly went to the cross and healed us. Did you get that? Just like Jesus was willing to go and heal the centurion's

servant, He willingly went to the cross and healed me and you. Read the above scripture again.

"He called his twelve disciples to him and gave them ***authority*** *to drive out evil spirits and to heal* ***every*** *disease and sickness" (Matthew 10:1, emphasis added).*

Jesus has given us authority over sickness, disease, demons, pain, etc. but we must use our authority. It is in the Name of Jesus that we have authority.

> *"Therefore [because He stooped so low], God has highly exalted Him and has freely bestowed on Him the name that is above every name,* ***that in (at) the name of Jesus every knee should (must) bow****, in heaven and on earth and under the earth, and every tongue [frankly and openly] confess and acknowledge that* ***Jesus Christ is Lord****, to the glory of God the Father" (Philippians 2:9-11, Amplified, emphasis added).*

Do you know that the devil himself has to acknowledge that Jesus Christ is Lord? Do you see the power that is released when we pray in the Name of Jesus? Every sickness and disease must bow to the Name of Jesus. There is no name greater than Jesus' Name. There is no name more powerful than Jesus' Name.

> *"As you go, preach this message: The kingdom of heaven is near. Heal the sick, raise the dead, cleanse those who have leprosy, drive out demons. Freely you have received, freely give" (Matthew 10:7-8).*
>
> *"One day as he was teaching, Pharisees and teachers of the law, who had come from every village of Galilee and from Judea and Jerusalem, were sitting there. And the* ***power of the Lord was present*** *for him to heal the sick" (Luke 5:17, emphasis added).*
>
> *"When Jesus had called the Twelve together, he gave them* ***power and authority*** *to drive out* ***all*** *demons and to cure*

diseases, and he sent them out to preach the kingdom of God and to heal the sick" (Luke 9:1-2, emphasis added).

"So they set out and went from village to village, preaching the gospel and healing people ***everywhere****" (Luke 9:6, emphasis added).*

"When you enter a town and are welcomed, eat what is set before you. Heal the sick who are there and tell them, The kingdom of God is near you" (Luke 10:8-9).

"Stretch out your hand to heal and perform miraculous signs and wonders ***through the name of your holy servant Jesus****" (Acts 4:30, emphasis added).*

It is because of what Jesus did for me in His redemptive work that I **am** healed. Jesus already purchased my healing. When He said "It is finished" on the cross, He was saying that salvation and healing have already been provided for me. All I need to do is receive the healing he suffered to give to me by simply believing in what He did for me. I am saved by grace through faith in Jesus Christ. I am healed the same way: by grace through faith in Jesus.

Declaration: Thank You, Jesus, I believe you have already **healed me. I receive Your healing by faith.**

"Just then a woman who had been subject to bleeding for 12 years came up behind him and touched the edge of his cloak. She said to herself, "If I only touch his cloak, I will be healed." Jesus turned and saw her, "Take heart, daughter." He said, "Your faith has healed you." And the woman was healed from that moment" (Matthew 9:20-22).

This woman believed that she would be healed the moment she touched His garment. When she touched His garment healing virtue flowed from Jesus to her.

Prayer: I believe in You, Jesus, and I receive Your healing virtue in my body and soul just like this woman with the issue of blood.

> *"As Jesus went on from there, two blind men followed him, calling out, "Have mercy on us, Son of David!" When he had gone in doors, the blind men came to him, and he asked them, "**Do you believe**, that I am able to do this?" "Yes, Lord", they replied. Then he touched their eyes and said, "**According to your faith** will it be done to you." And their sight was restored" (Matthew 9:27-30a, emphasis added).*

These two blind men were persistent. They **followed Jesus** even into the house. They were not going to go away until they had **received** their healing. Will you be persistent? Will you receive the healing that Jesus has already provided for you? Receive it and by faith wait for the manifestation of that healing to appear in your body or your soul **by continuing to meditate upon God's promises**. Be persistent just like these two blind men were. Don't give up.

Prayer: Father, in Jesus' Name, help me to be persistent in meditating upon Your promises until the manifestation of Your healing appears. Help me to never give up. Help me to keep my eyes on Jesus and Your Word, not on my circumstances.

> *"Now faith is being sure of what we hope for and certain of what we do not see" ((Hebrews 11:1).*

We walk by faith and not by sight. If we have the manifestation of our healing, we don't need faith because we have what we believed God for. However, if we are still sick, then we need faith because it is faith in God's Word that will bring to pass what we hope for and do not yet see.

Faith sees. Faith sees the answer. Faith sees the end result. Faith sees what Jesus accomplished for us. Faith comes when we put the Word into our heart and meditate on it. The Word of God (the Bible) is the only thing we are to meditate on. Jesus is the Word of God. Therefore, we can meditate on Jesus and who

He is and all that He has done for us. By reading and meditating on these healing scriptures, you are meditating on the Word of God. The Word (Jesus) is filling your heart, and your mind is being renewed **and transformation in your soul and body is taking place**. The Bible says that whatever is in our heart will come out of our mouth. As you put these healing scriptures into your heart, they will begin to come out of your mouth. Faith comes by hearing and hearing the Word of God.

God's Word is alive and active. As we continue to meditate on His Word and His promises we are focusing on Him, and life that comes from His Word is being imparted to us. The Word is literally becoming alive on the inside of us bringing manifestation of healing and wholeness. Sometimes a miracle takes place and healing is instantaneous but most of the time it is little by little.

"I tell you the truth, if you have faith as small as a mustard seed, ***you can say to this mountain****, "Move from here to there" and it will move. Nothing will be impossible for you" (Matthew 17:20b, emphasis added).*

A mustard seed is very small but when **planted** produces a very large tree. God's Word is meant to be **planted** in our heart as a seed and it will produce a great harvest. We don't need huge faith to be healed. It is not about us having a big faith. It is about us putting our small faith in a BIG God and simply believing His promises. God wants us to have child-like faith. A child simply believes. Child-like faith will move mountains. Let faith IN GOD arise within you as you meditate upon His Word. Child-like faith says that it is mine. I have it now whether I see it manifested or not.

Prayer: Thank You, Father, for helping me to plant the Living Word of God into my heart so that when I speak to this mountain of sickness, pain, lack, etc. in my life and command it to move out of me, in Jesus' Name, I will believe it.

"By faith ***in the name of Jesus****, this man whom you see and know was made strong. It is Jesus' name and* ***the faith that***

comes through him *that has given this complete healing to him, as you can all see" (Acts 3:16, emphasis added).*

Put your faith in Jesus' Name. No sickness, pain or demon can withstand the Name of Jesus.

It is the faith of Jesus that resides in me and faith in the Name of Jesus that brings forth healing in my body and soul. As a believer, I have Jesus living in me (the living Bread, the Word of God). As I meditate upon the Word of God and get to know Jesus more and more, **faith in His promises and in His faithfulness** will arise. Faith comes through Him as the above scripture says. Faith comes through getting to know Jesus the living Word of God. It is the Word of God that becomes alive in me (Rhema), not the written Word (logos). When I draw on the Rhema Word of God in my heart, it will arise within me and produce healing, etc. Jesus' faith is activated in me as I declare God's promises and mediate on them. Jesus' faith that already resides in me because Jesus resides in me, begins to arise.

Prayer: Father, in Jesus' Name, help me to get the Rhema Word of God into my heart. Help me to put my faith in Your promises and Your faithfulness, not in myself. Help me to see with eyes of faith. I draw upon the Living Word that is already in my heart to arise within me now.

Close your eyes and picture yourself receiving the healing touch of Jesus as you meditate on God's promises. You see this through eyes of faith in God's Word. It is okay to picture things with eyes of faith. In the Old Testament God told Abraham that his descendants would be as numerous as the stars in the sky and the sand on the seashore (see Genesis 22:17). God gave Abraham these pictures to see so that he would believe God for the impossible.

It is the same with joy. The Bible says that in the Presence of the Lord is joy and the joy of the Lord is my strength. Close your eyes and picture your whole being filled on the inside to

overflowing with the presence and joy of Jesus. This will bring strength to your spirit, soul and body.

It is the same with peace. Jesus is our Prince of Peace. Close your eyes and picture your whole being filled on the inside to overflowing with the peace of Jesus. See Jesus filling you, saturating you and immersing you in His peace.

You can look up scriptures on peace and meditate on them. Write each scripture down as it has a greater impact when you do this. Also, write down what the scripture means to you personally.

It is the same with His love. God's love is unconditional, unfailing and unending. His love never runs out. It reaches to the heavens. Close your eyes and picture your whole being filled to overflowing with the love of Jesus. Meditate on what Jesus did for you in His redemptive work and see Jesus filling you, saturating you and immersing you with His love. Let Jesus baptized you with His love.

You can look up scriptures on God's love and meditate on them and write them down as mentioned above.

> *"Jesus went throughout Galilee, teaching in their synagogues, preaching the good news of the kingdom, and healing* ***every*** *disease and sickness among the people. News about him spread all over Syria, and people brought to him* ***all*** *who were ill with various diseases,* ***those suffering severe pain****, the demon-possessed, those having seizures, and the paralyzed, and he healed them" (Matthew 4:23-24, emphasis added).*

Did you notice all of the different things that Jesus healed the people of in the above scripture? It was the power of the Holy Spirit flowing through Jesus that brought healing and deliverance to the people. The Bible says that Jesus is the same yesterday, today and forever.

*"Lord", he said "my servant lies at home paralyzed and in terrible suffering." Jesus said to him, "**I will go to heal him**." The centurion replied, **"Lord, I do not deserve to have you come under my roof.** But just say the word, and my servant will be healed. Then Jesus said to the centurion, "Go! It will be done **just as you believed it would**." And his servant was healed at that very hour" (Matthew 8:6-8, 13, emphasis added).*

This centurion said, "Lord, I do not deserve to have you come under my roof". The centurion did not feel worthy for Jesus to come into his home. However, Jesus extended grace which is unmerited, unearned, undeserved favor to the centurion and healed his servant. You may be feeling like you are unworthy to receive anything from Jesus. If you are a believer, you can come boldly to God's throne of grace and receive mercy and find grace to help you in your time of need (see Hebrews 4:16). He will always extend grace to you when you humble yourself before Him. Don't let the condemnation that the enemy brings keep you from running to God's throne of grace. If you are a believer, Jesus has already set you free from condemnation, guilt and shame (see Romans 8:1). Cast it aside and receive His grace today.

Prayer: Father, in Jesus' Name, I come boldly to Your throne of grace so that I may receive mercy and find grace to help me in my time of need.

*"When evening came, many who were demon-possessed were brought to him, and he drove out the spirits with a word and healed **all** the sick. This was to fulfill what was spoken through the prophet Isaiah: "He took up our infirmities and carried our diseases" (Matthew 8:16-17, emphasis added).*

"Then they brought him a demon-possessed man who was blind and mute, and Jesus healed him, so that he could both talk and see" (Matthew 12:22).

We see people bringing others to Jesus who needed healing and He healed them. He didn't say, "I'll do it tomorrow or in a week". He didn't say, "Maybe I'll do it or no, I won't do it". He didn't say "You're not good enough for me to heal you". He didn't question the sick person. He just healed him.

> *"When Jesus landed and saw a large crowd, he had* ***compassion*** *on them and healed their sick" (Matthew 14:14, emphasis added).*

Jesus is a compassionate God and that's why He was willing to take all the punishment that was due us on His own body on the tree so that we could be forgiven and healed. He cares for us. He wants us well in every area of our life.

Prayer: Heavenly Father, in Jesus' Name, I thank You that You are full of compassion for me. I come boldly to You and receive everything that comes from Your hand. Your Word says that every good and perfect gift comes from You (see James 1:17). Help me to receive Your compassion and all that You freely give to me. Please continue to reveal Your unconditional love to me so that I can receive all that You have already provided for me.

> *"And when the men of that place recognized Jesus, they sent word to all the surrounding country. People brought all their sick to him and begged him to let the sick just touch the edge of his cloak and* ***all*** *who touched him were healed" (Matthew 14:35-36, emphasis added).*

Jesus willingly responded to the people. He did not judge them or condemn them for their sins. He simply healed them.

> *"Great crowds came to him, bringing the lame, the blind, the crippled, the mute and many others and laid them at his feet; and he healed them" (Matthew 15:30).*

Nothing is too difficult or too much for Jesus to take care of. He did not turn away a single person and He will not turn me or

you away either when we come humbly before His throne of grace.

> *"Jesus rebuked the demon, and it came out of the boy, and he was healed from that moment" (Matthew 17:18).*

> *"When Jesus had finished saying these things, he left Galilee and went into the region of Judea to the other side of the Jordan. Large crowds followed him, and he healed them there" (Matthew 19:1-2).*

Since Jesus died and rose from the dead, He is no longer limited to a human body. Jesus is everywhere. He is in touching distance to heal me and in touching distance to heal you. In fact, since I am a believer, Jesus lives on the inside of me and His healing power is already inside of me. My part is to believe this and receive His healing by faith.

> *"Praise be to the God and Father of our Lord Jesus Christ, who has blessed us* ***in the heavenly realms*** *with every spiritual blessing in Christ" (Ephesians 1:3, emphasis added).*

Did you see that we are blessed with every spiritual blessing in Christ and this blessing is available to us in the heavenly realms? How do we get that blessing from the heavenly realms to our natural realm? Faith is the agent that takes the blessing. Grace has made it available and faith receives it. It is our faith in Jesus and what He has already done for us. Grace and faith go hand in hand. We need both grace and faith operating in our life.

> *"The blind and the lame came to him at the temple and he healed them" (Matthew 21:14).*

Jesus healed at the temple, in the fields, in homes and on the road. He healed wherever He was. He healed everyone who came to Him. He is no respecter of persons.

> *"And I will do – I Myself will grant – whatever you may* ***ask*** *in My name [presenting all I AM] so that the Father may be glorified and extolled in [through] the Son. [Yes] I will*

*grant – will do for you – whatever you shall **ask** in My name [presenting all I AM]" (John 14:13-14, Amplified, emphasis added).*

In the Greek, one of the meanings of the word "ask" means to demand something that is due.

We ask (demand) in the mighty Name of Jesus. It is the Name of Jesus that the sickness, etc. must bow to. We are not demanding Jesus. We are demanding the sickness to leave, in the Name of Jesus. We are demanding our bodies to come in line with God's Word and be healed. Just like David spoke to his soul, we can speak to our bodies.

As you do this, and when you say the Name of Jesus, think about Jesus and who He is. He is Almighty God, all powerful and all loving God.

For example: In the **Name of Jesus**, I demand my body to function in the perfection to which God created it to function in. I demand my immune system to be healthy and whole. I demand my sinuses to serve my body well and to operate perfectly in the Name of Jesus. I demand all allergies to leave my body, to go where Jesus is telling you to go and to never return to me or transfer to anyone else. I declare that I am redeemed from all allergies. Allergies have no hold on my body. Allergies are defeated in my body by the blood of the Lamb. I am allergy free. I demand my brain and memory to be healed and made whole. I declare that my memory is blessed (see Proverbs 10:7).

You can make it personal to your life. Whatever it is that you need in your body and soul, you can demand to come in line with God's Word and be healed, in the Name of Jesus. You can speak life and health to your body and soul, in the Name of Jesus.

"You have not chosen Me, but I have chosen you – I have appointed you, I have planted you – that you might go and bear fruit and keep on bearing; that your fruit may be lasting (that it may remain, abide); so that whatever you ask

*the Father in My name [**as presenting all that I AM**] He may give it to you" (John 15:16, Amplified, emphasis added).*

When I pray for healing, I can present all that Jesus is and all that Jesus has done for me to the Father.

Prayer: Father, in Jesus' Name, I am reminded of all that Jesus has done for me in His redemptive work. He forgave me and took all my sins away and He gave me His very own righteousness. He took the full punishment that was due me for my sins and He bore that punishment for me to free me from the curse of the law which includes freedom from all sickness, disease, pain, emotional bondage, mental anguish, lack, etc. He fulfilled the law fully for me (on my behalf) so that I can now enjoy Your blessings. Thank You for blessing me with abundant provision, good health, a sound mind and wholeness. Thank You for watching over Your Word to bring it to pass in my life. I can now say that I am redeemed from (name of sickness). Father, in Jesus' Name, I am very grateful for all that Jesus did for me and I thank You for the manifestation of healing in my body and in my soul.

*"And when that time comes, you will ask nothing of Me – you will need to ask Me no questions. I assure you, most solemnly I tell you, that my Father will grant you whatever you ask in My name **[presenting all I AM]**" (John 16:23, Amplified, emphasis added).*

Who is Jesus to you? How do you present all that He is? You can make your own list in your own heart but let me share with you who Jesus is to me. Above all He is my Savior, my Lord and my God in whom I put my trust and in whom I rely on. He is trustworthy, faithful, full of grace, mercy, compassion, gentleness and love. He is the roaring Lion of Judah (mighty in battle). He is all knowing, all present and all powerful. He is the One and Only true God. There is no one like Him. He is holy, majestic and righteous. He is also my Confidante, my Grace, my Healer, my Deliverer, my Rock upon whom I stand, my

Protection, my Refuge, my Hiding Place, my Fortress, my Guidance Counselor, my Life, my Redeemer, my Ransom, my Bridegroom, my Husband, the Lover of my soul and the Lifter of my head, the Love of my life, my Strong High Tower, my Peace, my Joy, my Righteousness, my Victory, my Sustainer, my Strengthener, my Developer, my Advocate, my Defender, my Teacher, my Anointing, my abundant Provider, my Sanctification, my good Shepherd, my Friend, my Comforter, my Encourager, my Wisdom, my Example, my Stronghold, my Everything, my All in All. Whatever I need or want Jesus to be to me, He is.

When you use the Name of Jesus, remember who He is to you.

> *"He who believes – [that is], who adheres to and trusts in and relies on the Gospel and Him Whom it sets forth – and is baptized will be saved [from the penalty of eternal death]; but he who does not believe – who does not adhere to and trust in and rely on the Gospel and Him Whom it sets forth – will be condemned. And these attesting signs will accompany those who believe: in My name they will drive out demons; they will speak in new languages; they will pick up serpents, and [even] if they drink anything deadly, it will not hurt them; they will lay their hands on the sick,* ***and they will get well****" (Mark 16:16-18, Amplified, emphasis added).*

One version says "they will recover". Recover means to be brought back to its rightful position (pre-sickness, pre-lack). We can recover lost time, lost finances, lost health, etc. Hallelujah!

God's Word is seed that is conceived in our hearts. Just like a farmer plants seed into the ground with sunshine and water that seed will grow and it will produce a crop. As we plant God's Word (seed) into our hearts, it will grow as we focus on Jesus (the Son) and water that seed by continuing to read and meditate on the promises in God's Word. Just like the farmer's seed will produce a crop, God's Word (seed) will also produce a great harvest in our lives (see Mark 4:26-29). When a farmer plants

apple seeds, he will reap a harvest of apples. When we plant healing seeds, we will reap a harvest of health. So continue to meditate upon healing scriptures until the manifestation of the healing that Jesus has already made available to you in the heavenly realms has come. Receive by faith what grace has already made available to you.

Prayer: Father, in Jesus' Name, help me to conceive Your Word in my heart so that a bountiful harvest will come forth.

Freedom from the spirit of Anti-Christ

Father, I pray that Your Spirit would arm us with truth that will give us the power to stand firm in all the Will of God and to stand firmly against the spirit of anti-Christ all of our life, in Jesus' Name.

- **First Antidote to the spirit of Anti-Christ**

In the books of 1, 2 and 3 John, John instructs us to continue or remain in the faith because there are false teachers who are operating in the spirit of anti-Christ who want to lead people away or prevent them from believing in who Jesus is, what He has done for us and His awesome love. John gives us the antidote to the spirit of anti-Christ. Since we are in the last days, would you say it is very important that we know what the antidote is to the spirit of anti-Christ so that we will believe right all the days of our life? Let's look at what John says.

> *"Dear children, this is the last hour, and as you have heard that the antichrist is coming,* ***even now many antichrists have come****. This is how we know it is the last hour.* ***They*** *(the antichrists) went out from us, but* ***they*** *(the antichrists) did not really belong to us. For if* ***they*** *had belonged to us, they would have remained with us, but* ***their*** *going showed that none of* ***them*** *belonged to us. But (he makes a distinction here)* ***you*** *have an anointing from the Holy One, and all of* ***you*** *know* ***the truth****. I do not write to you because*

you do not know the truth, but because you do know it and because no lie comes from the truth. ***Who is the liar****?* ***It is the man who denies that Jesus is the Christ. Such a man is the antichrist – he denies the Father and the Son.*** *No one who denies the Son has the Father, whoever acknowledges the Son has the Father also" (1 John 2:18-23, emphasis and parenthesis added).*

Then he goes on:

"See that ***what you have heard from the beginning remains in you****. If it does, you also* ***will remain*** *in the Son and in the Father. And this is what he promised us – even eternal life" (1 John 2:24-25, emphasis added).*

What was it that they had heard from the beginning that saved them?

First of all, they received salvation because they heard and believed that Jesus died for their sins, was resurrected from the dead and that He was the Son of God, meaning that He was God in the flesh.

Secondly, they heard and believed that God loved them (see John 3:16).

John was saying **don't listen** to those who oppose Jesus as the Christ, the Messiah. They are **anti-**Christ. They are against Christ. Stay away from their teachings for they will lead you astray. John is saying to those he is writing to that they already know **the Truth** and he is instructing them to remain in Jesus and to hold on to the gospel of grace that they heard; hold on to the **Truth** that Jesus died for them and forgave them of all their sins; hold on to the **Truth** that Jesus was resurrected from the dead and is alive today; hold on to the **Truth** that God loves them unconditionally and they will continue to have eternal life.

"Dear friends, do not believe every spirit, but test the spirits to see whether they are from God, because many false prophets have gone out into the world. This is how you can

recognize the Spirit of God: ***Every spirit that acknowledges that Jesus Christ has come in the flesh is from God, but every spirit that does not acknowledge Jesus is not from God****. This is the spirit of the antichrist, which you have heard is coming and even now is already in the world. You, dear children, are from God and have overcome them (meaning the antichrists), because the one who is in you is greater than the one who is in the world. They are from the world and therefore speak from the viewpoint of the world, and the world listens to them. We are from God, and whoever knows God listens to us; but whoever is not from God does not listen to us. This is how we recognize the Spirit of truth and the spirit of falsehood" (1 John 4:1-6, emphasis and parenthesis added).*

John is warning us that we are to listen to people who acknowledge that Jesus Christ has come in the flesh and anyone who does not acknowledge Jesus is operating in the spirit of anti-Christ and we should not listen to them.

Did you know that Jesus, who came to earth in the body of a human being, is God? Please allow me to lead you to some scriptures that prove that Jesus is God in the flesh. It is so important for us **to understand and believe that Jesus is God** who came in the flesh for this is **truth that will protect us from the spirit of anti-Christ**. Those who walk in the spirit of anti-Christ are opposing Jesus and who He is. They come across as spiritual but they do not believe that Jesus is God. They only believe that He was a good man. If He was only a good man, **He could not take away our sins**. If He was only a good man, **He could not make us righteous.** He had to be God in order to do this.

In my childhood and early adult years, I was raised in a Church that taught the Trinity. God the Father, God the Son and God the Holy Spirit and they are One. One day, after I had become a born again Christian, someone came to my door and they brought confusion to me. They didn't believe in the Trinity and they didn't believe that Jesus was God. They said He was

only a good man. After speaking to them I wanted to see for myself what God's Word had to say about the Trinity so I asked God to show me. About a half an hour later I began reading His Word and that very day He began to show me the trinity in the Bible and over the next couple of years He showed me scriptures from Genesis to Revelation that reveals the Trinity and proves that Jesus is God. Although I have been shown many scriptures, here are just a few scriptures that the Holy Spirit enlightened my mind with while I was reading the Word of God. I pray that the Holy Spirit will also enlighten your mind too and give you understanding that **Jesus is God** so that you will never question this again.

Notice that God says in these next two scriptures that He is the Alpha and Omega, the First and the Last, the Beginning and the End. All three of these phrases mean the same thing.

> *"This is what* ***the Lord says*** *– Israel's King and Redeemer, the Lord Almighty****. I am the first and I am the last****; apart from me there is no God****" (Isaiah 44:6, emphasis added).*

> *"****He who was seated on the throne said****, "I am making everything new!" Then he said, "Write this down, for these words are trustworthy and true." He said to me: "It is done.* ***I am the Alpha and the Omega, the Beginning and the End****" (Revelation 21:5–6b, emphasis added).*

In the first scripture, **God is saying** that He is the First and the Last and that there is no God but Him.

In the second scripture, **God is also speaking** here. He was sitting on His throne and He said: "I am the Alpha and the Omega, the Beginning and the End".

Notice in this next scripture that Jesus says He is the Alpha and the Omega, the First and the Last, the Beginning and the End. We know that Jesus is the One the scriptures refer to as "coming again". Right?

*"**Behold, I am coming soon!** My reward is with me, and I will give to everyone according to what he has done. **I am the Alpha and the Omega, the First and the Last, the Beginning and the End**" (Revelation 22:12-13, emphasis added).*

The Bible tells us that Jesus died and rose again so we know that it is Jesus speaking in these next two scriptures.

*"Do not be afraid. **I am the First and the Last**. I am the Living One; I was dead, and behold I am alive for ever and ever! And I hold the keys of death and Hades" (Revelation 1:17b, emphasis added).*

*"These are the words of him **who is the First and the Last**, who died and came to life again" (Revelation 2:8b, emphasis added).*

We know that He who is the First and the Last is God and Jesus says He is the First and the Last. Jesus is telling us that He is God.

*"I am the Alpha and the Omega", says the **Lord God**, "who is and who was, and who is to come, **the Almighty**" (Revelation 1:8, emphasis added).*

These scriptures cannot get any clearer. Jesus is God. He is the Alpha and the Omega, the First and the Last, the Beginning and the End. He is who the above scripture refers to as "he who is and who was and who is to come, the Almighty".

Now let's look further into the Word to see another truth about who our **Savior** is.

*"But **I am the Lord your God**, who brought you out of Egypt. **You shall acknowledge no God but me, no Savior except me**" (Hosea 13:4, emphasis added).*

In this scripture, God is identifying Himself by saying that He is God and that He is our Savior and that there is no Savior except Him.

Now let's look at this next scripture.

"But when the kindness and love of ***God our Savior*** *appeared, he saved us, not because of righteous things we had done, but because of his mercy. He saved us through the washing of rebirth and renewal by the Holy Spirit, whom he poured out on us generously through* ***Jesus Christ our Savior"*** *(Titus 3:4-6, emphasis added).*

God says in Hosea 13:4 above that there is no Savior but Him and in Titus 3:6 also above Jesus Christ is identified as our Savior.

"And we have seen and testify that ***the Father has sent his Son to be the Savior of the world"*** *(1 John 4:14, emphasis added).*

This scripture also attests to Jesus as our Savior. Since God is the only Savior of the world and Jesus came as our Savior, that makes Him God.

Let's continue with yet another truth about who our **Judge** is.

"You have come to thousands upon thousands of angels in joyful assembly, to the Church of the firstborn, whose names are written in heaven. You have come to ***God, the judge of all men****, to the spirits of righteous men made perfect" (Hebrews 12:22b-23, emphasis added).*

Now the above scripture identifies God as the Judge of all men.

*"****There is only one Lawgiver and Judge****, the one who is able to save and destroy" (James 4:12a, emphasis added).*

This scripture says that there is only one Judge.

Now let's look closely at this next scripture.

*"In the presence of **God and of Christ Jesus**, who will **judge** the living and the dead, and in view of **his** appearing and **his** kingdom, I give you this charge" (2 Timothy 4:1, emphasis added).*

Did you notice this scripture refers to God and Christ Jesus who will judge? This appears to be plural but then the scripture goes on to say "in view of **his** appearing and **his** kingdom". "His" is singular. We already established that there is only one Judge and that Judge is God. This scripture identifies Jesus Christ as God and as our Judge.

Do you see that?

Now let's look at another truth about **God's Son**.

God the Father is speaking in this next scripture and listen to what He says about His Son and who He calls His Son. I was so excited the first time I saw this in the Bible.

*"But about **the Son** he says, "Your throne, **O God**, will last forever and ever, and righteousness will be the scepter of your kingdom. You have loved righteousness and hated wickedness; therefore **God**, your God, has set you above your companions by anointing you with the oil of joy" (Hebrews 1:8-9, emphasis added).*

God the Father refers to Jesus as God. He says "Your throne, O God". He identifies Jesus as God. In Verse 9 He refers to both Himself and Jesus as God by saying "therefore God (referring to Jesus), your God (referring to Himself) has set you above your companions".

Isn't that exciting to see Jesus' deity so clearly in scripture? It is so important to know the Word of God.

After Jesus rose from the dead and appeared to Thomas, look at who Thomas calls Jesus.

*"Thomas said to him, "My Lord and **my God**!" (John 20:28, emphasis added).*

Thomas did not believe the other apostles when they told him that they saw Jesus. He doubted them. But when Jesus appeared to Thomas, Thomas exclaims "My Lord and my God!". There is an exclamation mark after these words. Thomas called Jesus his Lord and his God.

Scripture very clearly tells us that we are not to take the Name of the Lord in vain. Therefore, I believe Thomas was not misusing God's Name but rather declaring who Jesus was when Jesus showed him the nail holes in His hands and the wound in His side. Thomas received a revelation right there and then that Jesus is God. In fact, he makes it personal that Jesus is His Lord and His God.

Now let's look at another truth about the **King of kings and Lord of lords**.

> *"I charge you to keep this commandment without spot or blame until the appearing of our Lord Jesus Christ, which God will bring about in his own time – **God, the blessed and only Ruler, the King of kings and Lord of lords**" (1 Timothy 6:14-15, emphasis added).*

Would you say that a King is a Ruler? Yes, of course, a King is a Ruler. This scripture says that God is the **only** Ruler and then He identifies Himself as the King of kings and Lord of lords.

Notice in the following two scriptures that Jesus is identified as the **King of kings and Lord of lords**.

> *"They will make war against the **Lamb (we know that the Lamb refers to Jesus)**, but the **Lamb** will overcome them because he is **Lord of lords and King of kings** – and with him will be his called, chosen and faithful followers" (Revelation 17:14, emphasis and parenthesis added).*

> *"On his **robe** and on his thigh he has this name written: **King of kings and Lord of lords**" (Revelation 19:16, emphasis added).*

We know that it is Jesus that the above scripture is referring to because just prior to this scripture in verse 13 it says "He is dressed in a **robe** dipped in blood, and His Name is the Word of God." We know that Jesus shed His blood for us and we know that Jesus is the Word of God (see John 1:1, 14).

Can you see that?

Let's look at another truth about the Great **I AM**. We will get to some scriptures about the Holy Spirit and the Trinity soon. Please bear with me.

> *"**God said** to Moses, "I AM who I AM. This is what you are to say to the Israelites: **I AM** has sent me to you" (Exodus 3:14, emphasis added).*

Moses asked God what he should say to the Israelites when they asked what His Name was. God told Moses to tell them, "I AM". In the above scripture, God identifies Himself here as "I AM".

Look at this next scripture.

> *"I tell you the truth, **Jesus** answered, before Abraham was born, **I am!**" (John 8:58, emphasis added).*

Did you notice the exclamation mark at the end of this scripture? Jesus was emphasizing and identifying Himself as the great "I AM". He says that before Abraham was, He was. Well, we all know that Jesus was physically born after Abraham but He says in this scripture that before Abraham was, He was and He calls Himself "I AM". In other words, He always was. He didn't just come into existence when He was born of Mary. He has always been because He is God.

> *"I am telling you now before it happens (Jesus is speaking here about His upcoming crucifixion.), so that when it does happen you will believe that **I am He**" (John 13:19, emphasis and parenthesis added).*

Jesus is identifying Himself as God. Can you see that?

Let's look at another truth about the **forgiveness of our sins**.

*"When **Jesus** saw their faith, he said to the paralytic, "Son, **your sins are forgiven**". Now some teachers of the law were sitting there, thinking to themselves, "Why does this fellow talk like that? He's blaspheming! **Who can forgive sins but God alone**?" (Mark 2:5–7, emphasis added).*

First of all, we see from this scripture that only God can forgive sins. We also see that Jesus told the paralytic that his sins were forgiven. The teachers of the law (those who were very familiar with the Old Testament) were so upset with Jesus' statement to this paralytic because they knew that only God could forgive sins. Jesus was identifying Himself as God by forgiving this man's sins and this is what made the teachers of the law so angry with him as they thought He was blaspheming God by this statement.

*"Then Jesus said to her, "**Your sins are forgiven**". The other guests began to say among themselves, "**Who is this who even forgives sins?**" (Luke 7:48-49, emphasis added).*

They knew that only God alone could forgive sins and yet Jesus is telling this woman that her sins are forgiven.

Let's take a look at a couple of scriptures that refer to the **Holy Spirit forgiving sins**.

Notice in the following scripture that it is the Holy Spirit who says "**Their sins and lawless acts I will remember no more**". In other words, this scripture says that **the Holy Spirit also forgives sins**. Also, notice in this next scripture that the Holy Spirit identifies Himself as God by saying that He made a covenant with them and He put His laws in their hearts and wrote them on their minds. He identifies Himself as "Lord". This scripture is packed with truths that the Holy Spirit is God so look closely as you read it.

*"The **Holy Spirit** also testifies to us about this. First **he** (the Holy Spirit) **says**: "This is the covenant **I** will make with*

*them after that time", **says the Lord**. "**I** will put my laws in their hearts, and **I** will write them on their minds." Then he adds: **"Their sins and lawless acts I will remember no more"** (Hebrews 10:15–16, emphasis and parenthesis added).*

It was the Holy Spirit saying these things.

Now let's look at some scriptures that refer to the **Trinity**.

*"In the beginning **God created the heavens and the earth**" (Genesis 1:1, emphasis added).*

Notice in this next scripture the **singular God**, then notice the **plural God** by the words "**us**" and "**our**".

*"Then **God** (singular) said, "Let **us** (plural) make **man** in **our** image, in **our** likeness" (Genesis 1:26a, emphasis and parenthesis added).*

From the above two scriptures, we see that it was God who created the heavens and the earth and it was God who created man.

In verse 26 that you just read God refers to Himself as plural and in verse 27 below He refers to Himself as singular.

*"So God created man in **his** own image, in the image of God **he** created him; male and female **he** created them" (Genesis 1:27, emphasis added).*

Notice again in the next scripture the plural in the word "us" and the singular in the word "Lord". Remember we are talking about the Trinity here.

*"Come, let **us** (plural) go down and confuse their language so they will not understand each other. So **the Lord** (singular) scattered them from there over all the earth and they stopped building the city" (Genesis 11:7-8, emphasis and parenthesis added).*

So we see from these scriptures that God refers to Himself as both singular and plural.

Remember it was God (both singular and plural) who created man.

This next scripture refers to Jesus who is the head of the body, the church and who is the firstborn from among the dead.

> *"For by him (that's Jesus)* ***all things*** *(this includes man)* ***were created****: things in heaven and on earth, visible and invisible, whether thrones or powers or rulers or authorities;* ***all things were created by him*** *(that's Jesus) and for him. He is before all things, and in him all things hold together. And he is the head of the body, the church; he is the beginning and the firstborn from among the dead so that in everything he might have the supremacy" (Colossians 1:16-18, emphasis and parenthesis added).*

So we see that Jesus created all things. He created man as well as all things. We read in Genesis 1:1 above that God created the heavens and the earth and in Genesis 1:26 that God made man. God said, "Let us make man in our image". Jesus was present with the Father when all things were created.

In this next scripture, you will see that the Holy Spirit also created man.

> *"The* ***Spirit of God has made me*** *(Job is speaking here); the breath of the Almighty* ***gives me life****" (Job 33:4, emphasis and parenthesis added).*

Job is saying that the Holy Spirit created him and then he says that the Almighty gave him breath. We know that God is the Almighty One. So this scripture tells us that the Holy Spirit is God and He created Job (man). You just read in Genesis 1:26a "God said, Let **us** make man in our image". We see here that **us** refers to God the Father, God the Son and God the Holy Spirit, yet they are One.

Let's look at some more scriptures that refer to the Trinity: God the Father, God the Son and God the Holy Spirit.

> *"Who have been chosen according to the foreknowledge of **God the Father**, through the sanctifying work of the **Spirit**, for obedience to **Jesus Christ** and sprinkling by his blood. Grace and peace to you in abundance" (1 Peter 1:2, emphasis added).*

So we see all three persons of the Trinity in this scripture and each one has a different function.

> *"Then Jesus came to them and said, "All authority in heaven and on earth has been given to me. Therefore, go and make disciples of all nations, baptizing them in the name of **the Father, and of the Son and of the Holy Spirit** and teaching them to obey everything I have commanded you" (Matthew 28:18–20a, emphasis added).*

> *"As soon as **Jesus** (we see Jesus) was baptized, he went up out of the water. At that moment heaven was opened, and he saw the **Spirit of God** (we see the Spirit) descending like a dove and lighting on him. And a **voice from heaven** (this is the Father's voice) said "This is my Son, whom I love; with him I am well pleased" (Matthew 3:16-17, emphasis and parenthesis added).*

> *"May the grace of the **Lord Jesus Christ**, and the love of **God** (this is referring to the Father), and the fellowship of the **Holy Spirit** be with you all" (2 Corinthians 13:14, emphasis and parenthesis added).*

> *"For there are **three** that bear record in heaven, the **Father**, **the word (which is Jesus)**, and the **Holy Ghost**: and **these three are one**" (1 John 5:7, KJV, emphasis and parenthesis added).*

Notice in the next scripture that the **Holy Spirit is referred to as a person** by the words "he" and "his" throughout. Also, notice that the **Holy Spirit speaks and hears**. Some people

think that the Holy Spirit is only a force (like the wind). Can the wind speak? Can the wind hear? Can the wind forgive sins? Can the wind guide us?

> *"But when he, the **Spirit of truth**, comes, **he will guide** you into all truth. He will not speak on his own; **he will speak** only what **he hears** and **he will tell you** what is yet to come" (John 16:13, emphasis added).*

This scripture says that the Holy Spirit is the Spirit of Truth. John 14:6 says that Jesus is the way, the Truth and the life. We see that both the Holy Spirit and Jesus are Truth. The Holy Spirit is the Spirit of Jesus. They are One, just like we are one with our own spirit.

> *"For through him (this is talking about Jesus) we both have access to the Father by **one Spirit**" (Ephesians 2:18, emphasis and parenthesis added).*

This scripture tells us there is only one Spirit. It also tells us that through Jesus we have access to the Father by that **one Spirit**. **The Father and Jesus have the same Spirit**. **There is only one Spirit and that Spirit is the Spirit of the Father and the Spirit of Jesus.**

> *"You, however, are controlled not by the sinful nature but by the Spirit, if the **Spirit of God** (referring to the Spirit of the Father) lives in you. And if anyone does not have the **Spirit of Christ**, he does not belong to Christ" (Romans 8:9, emphasis and parenthesis added).*

This scripture refers to the Spirit of God and the Spirit of Christ. They are one. Can you see all three persons of the Trinity here?

Notice that this next scripture refers to Spirit, Lord and God all in one verse.

> *"There are different kinds of gifts, but the **same Spirit**. There are different kinds of service, but the **same Lord**. There are different kinds of working, but the **same God***

works all of them in all men" (1 Corinthians 12:4, emphasis added).

The above scripture says that the Spirit is the Lord and God.

"While they were worshipping the Lord and fasting, ***the Holy Spirit said****, "Set apart for* ***me*** *Barnabas and Saul for the work to which* ***I*** *have called them" (Acts 13:2, emphasis added).*

Now, these people were praying to the Lord, and the Holy Spirit **spoke** to them and said to set apart for Him Barnabas and Saul for the work to which He had called them.

*"****The Spirit told Philip****, "Go to that chariot and stay near it" (Acts 8:29, emphasis added).*

Again, we see that it was the Holy Spirit who **spoke** and gave directions to Philip.

"But ***God*** *(referring to the Father) has revealed it to us by* ***his Spirit****" (1 Corinthians 2:10a, emphasis and parenthesis added).*

God reveals things to us by His Spirit. The Holy Spirit speaks to us and leads us. He reveals to us things that God the Father wants us to know. God the Father and His Spirit are One, just like the Holy Spirit and Jesus are One.

Let's look at some scriptures that tell us more about the Holy Spirit and who He is.

Notice in the following scripture reference that the **Holy Spirit is our helper and intercedes for us**. Also, notice that the **Holy Spirit has a mind**.

"In the same way, the ***Spirit helps us*** *in our weakness. We do not know what we ought to pray, but the* ***Spirit himself intercedes for us*** *with groans that words cannot express. And he who searches our hearts knows* ***the mind of the Spirit****, because the Spirit intercedes for the saints in*

accordance with God's will" (Romans 8:26-27, emphasis added).

It is important to know this so that we will not believe teachers who are proclaiming that the Holy Spirit is only a force. We need to know and understand the scriptures so that we will not believe a lie.

Notice in the following scriptures that the **Holy Spirit can be grieved.** Can a force be grieved? No.

*"And do not **grieve the Holy Spirit of God**, with whom you were sealed for the day of redemption" (Ephesians 4:30, emphasis added).*

Notice in the following scripture that the **Holy Spirit can be resisted**.

*"You stiff-necked people (referring to unbelievers), with uncircumcised hearts and ears! You are just like your fathers: **You always resist the Holy Spirit!"** (Acts 7:51, emphasis and parenthesis added).*

Notice in the following scripture that the **Holy Spirit can even be insulted**.

*"How much more severely do you think a man deserves to be punished who has trampled the Son of God under foot, who has treated as an unholy thing the blood of the covenant that sanctified him, and who has **insulted the Spirit of grace**?" (Hebrews 10:29, emphasis added).*

Notice in the following scripture that the **Holy Spirit is our Teacher and Counsellor**.

*"But the **Counsellor, the Holy Spirit**, whom the Father will send in my name, will **teach you** all things and will remind you of everything I have said to you" (John 14:26, emphasis added).*

A force cannot teach us. A force cannot counsel us. A force cannot guide us. A force cannot intercede on our behalf.

Notice in the following scripture that the **Holy Spirit loves us**.

> *"I urge you, brothers, by our Lord Jesus Christ and by the* ***love of the Spirit****, to join me in my struggle by praying to God for me" (Romans 15:30, emphasis added).*

God wants us to hear and listen to His Spirit as His Spirit will help us, lead us, reveal Jesus to us, teach us, counsel us, love us, show us how to pray, etc.

Knowing and believing in Jesus as your personal Savior and Lord, believing that He is God and believing in the trinity is the first antidote to the spirit of anti-Christ. I would encourage you to get anchored and established in this **truth** and remain in this truth.

There are so many more scriptures that refer to the trinity and prove that Jesus is God. I pray you will see them as you read your Bible. For now, let's continue in the book of 1 John so that we may understand and grasp yet another truth that is an antidote to the spirit of anti-Christ.

- **Second Antidote to the spirit of Anti-Christ**

> *"How great is the love the Father has lavished on us, that we should be called children of God! And that is what we are!" (1 John 3:1).*

God wants us to know how great His love is for us. He has lavished it on us. He has called us His children. John emphasizes this with an exclamation mark.

> *"This is how we know who the children of God are and who the children of the devil are: Anyone who* ***does not do what is right*** *is not a child of God; nor is anyone who* ***does not love his brother****" (1 John 3:10, emphasis added).*

Now let's look at this verse a little closer to get a better understanding of what John is saying here. What does he mean when he says "anyone who does not do what is right is not a child of God"? We know that we are saved by believing in Jesus Christ as our personal Savior and Lord (see Romans 10:9-10, 13) but what is it that we need to do to be **recognized as a child of God**?

Let's go down a few verses.

> *"**This then is how we know that we belong to the truth**, and how we set our hearts at rest in his presence whenever our hearts condemn us. For God is greater than our hearts and he knows everything. Dear friends, if our hearts do not condemn us, we have confidence before God and receive from him anything we ask, because we obey his commands and do what pleases him. **And this is his command**: **to believe** in the name of his son, Jesus Christ, and **to love** one another as he commanded us" (1 John 3:19-23, emphasis added).*

You just read that God commands us to believe in Jesus and to love one another. There are only two commands that God gives us in the New Testament and they are to believe in Jesus and to love. Remember in verse 10 above it says "Anyone who does not do what is right is not a child of God". What is the doing what is right that John is talking about here? It is believing in Jesus and loving one another. This is the doing what is right that John refers to in verse 10. This is what will cause us to be **recognized as a child of God**.

When we first believed, God circumcised us from our old sinful fleshly nature and He deposited in us His very own nature. **His nature is love**. We have God's nature or God's love in us. He knew that we would not be able to love as He loved us with our own love so under the New Covenant of grace He placed (or put) His faith and His love in our hearts and wrote His faith and His love on our minds (see Hebrews 8:10b and Hebrews 10:16). The laws He has written on our hearts and our minds are not the

10 commandments. The 10 commandments are part of the Old Covenant which Jesus fulfilled on our behalf and nailed to the cross for the believer because we were not able to fully obey them. I will elaborate more on this in the Chapter "Freedom to Embrace the Grace of God". The laws that He has written on our hearts are to believe and to love as mentioned in 1 John 3:23 above. These are the New Covenant laws or commands.

> *"Dear friends, let us love one another, for love comes from God. Everyone who loves has been born of God and knows God. Whoever does not love does not know God because* ***God is love****" (1 John 4:7-8, emphasis added).*

To not know God is to not know that He loves you. Or can I say it this way? To know God is to know His love for you. We need to know God's love for us personally by experiencing His love for us. When we know and experience God's love for us and are filled with God's love, we will then be able to love others with the love that God deposits in our heart (writes on our heart). When we try to love with our own love (our own self-efforts in loving others), our love will only go so far. It will run out. It will only love those who love us. But when we are filled with the length and breadth and height and depth of the love of Christ for us personally and know His love by experience (see Ephesians 3:17-19), then and only then will **we be able to love others as Christ loved us**. He laid His life down for those who were insulting Him, mocking Him, persecuting Him, rejecting Him, spitting on Him, beating Him and killing Him.

> *"This is how* ***God showed his love*** *among us: He sent his one and only Son into the world that we might* ***live through him****. This is love:* ***not that we loved God, but that he loved us*** *and sent his Son as an atoning sacrifice for our sins" (1 John 4:9-10, emphasis added).*

Sometimes in the Church, we have taught and preached that we need to love more. We have put the cart before the horse. **What we really need to understand and get established in is the fact that God loved us so much that He sent His one and**

only Son as a sacrifice so that our sins would be forgiven. When we set our attention on God and we truly believe that God loves us unconditionally, that our sins are all forgiven and the punishment for our sins paid for by Jesus Christ at the cross, that we are fully accepted by God even when we fail Him and we have this revelation established in our hearts, we won't have to be told to love more. God's love will **automatically** flow from our hearts.

The scripture that you just read says: "**This is love**: **not that we loved God, but that he loved us and sent His Son as an atoning sacrifice for our sins**".

It is about God's love for us. I love being loved by God. I love meditating on God's love for me. When I do this, I am being filled up with His love so that I can go out into the world and love the unlovable. In the New Covenant, it has never been about our love for God but rather God's love for us. However, when we really know the love of God for us, we will be able to love Him and we will be able to love others that are not so lovable.

Think about Jesus saying to you "Do you see anything in Me that would cause you to love Me". I heard this from a preacher and it touched my heart deeply. Let me say it again. Jesus is saying to you "Do you see anything in Me that would cause you to love Me". WOW! My response was a big YES! Yes, Jesus, I see so much in You that makes me want to love You.

> *"Dear friends, since **God so loved us**, we also ought to love one another. No one has ever seen God; but if we love one another, God lives in us and **his love is made complete in us**" (1 John 4:11-12, emphasis added).*

Did you see that? It says that "**His** love is made complete in us". It is **His** love that lives in us that enables us to love those who oppose us, who persecute us and cause us pain. Those who do not believe in Jesus Christ cannot love like this because they

do not have God's love written on their hearts and on their minds.

> *"And we **know** (understand, recognize, are conscious of, by observation and by experience), and **believe** (adhere to and put faith in and rely on) the love God **cherishes** for us. **God is love**" (1 John 4:16, Amplified, emphasis added).*

God wants us to know, recognize and understand by consciously observing and receiving **His** love for us. God wants us to meditate upon this truth. God wants us to **believe** that He cherishes us. When we **believe** that He cherishes us, **we will be able to rely on His love to flow through us to others**. His love will not fail. Our love will fail us. God is the source of love and His love is beyond measure but we need to **receive it** and **believe** that He loves us.

I want to say something here. God's love is so immense that if He showed us all of His love at once we would surely die because we would not be able to handle it. Some people may think that they know God's love for them but let me tell you that there is much more of God's love to know and receive. I want to continue to receive His love for me and to know His love more and more as I journey through this life with Him. The prayer that Paul prayed over the Church in Philippian 1:9 was that their love may abound more and more in knowledge and depth of insight.…" As we grow in the knowledge of Christ our Savior and receive more and more of His love for us, our love will continue to increase.

> *"Whoever lives in love lives in God, and God in him. In this way, **love is made complete** among us so that we will have confidence on the day of judgment, and because in this world **we are like him**" (1 John 4:17, emphasis added).*

As we receive God's love for us personally and walk in **His** love, we are like Him in this world. As He is, so are we. As He is loving, so are we loving. Now don't condemn yourself if your love has fallen short. Instead, meditate on God's love for you so that you can grow in love. Remember that we are on a journey

with Jesus and we are becoming more and more like Him in character, in love, etc. This is a life long journey so receive the grace of God and don't beat yourself up. That is what the devil wants you to do. Instead, soak in His love for you and it will automatically flow out of you. The more we are filled with God's love for us, the more we will be able to love others.

> *"There is no fear in love. But perfect love drives out fear, because fear has to do with punishment. The one who fears is not made perfect in love" (1 John 4:18).*

Years ago I used to think that if I had fears, my love was not made perfect. That was a wrong belief. This scripture is not referring to my love being perfect. Rather, it refers to God's love that is perfect. So if I have fears in my heart, I need to know God's perfect love for me. I need to believe and receive God's love for me. When I know God's perfect love for me, it will drive fear far from me.

> *"It has given me great joy to find some of your children* ***walking in the truth****, just as the Father has* ***commanded us****. (Now remember in 1 John 3:23 God commands us to believe in Jesus and to love one another as Jesus loved us.) And now, dear lady, I am not writing you a new command but one we have had from the beginning.* ***I ask that we love one another****. And this is love that we walk in obedience to his commands.* ***As you have heard from the beginning, his command is that you walk in love****" (2 John 4–6, emphasis and parenthesis added).*

John is talking here about **walking in love**. Yet he says that some of this lady's children were **walking in the truth**. **To walk in truth is to walk in love**. In other words, when we know and believe **the truth** that God loves us unconditionally, **His love** will flow from us. **Truth and love are connected together. They cannot be separated**.

He also says that this is not a new command but one we have had from the beginning. It was always and will always be God's intention that His children walk in love because He is

love. His nature is love. As a born again believer, we have a new nature: God's nature (His divine nature) and His nature is love. God's love lives in us because Jesus lives in us and Jesus is full of love.

John is talking in this next scripture to his friend, Gaius.

> *"It gave me great joy to have some brothers come and tell about your faithfulness to the **truth** and how you continue to **walk in the truth**. I have no greater joy than to hear that my children are **walking in the truth**. They have told the church about your **love**" (3 John 3-4, 6a, emphasis added).*

Here John talks about walking in truth three times and then he talks about love. Did you get the connection there between truth and love again?

It is when we know and believe **the truth** that God loves us that we will automatically walk in **love**. Because John saw his dear friend Gaius walking in **love**, John knew that he was walking in the **truth**. Gaius had a revelation of the truth of the love of God for him which enabled him to walk in love.

In order to walk in the truth or to walk in love, we must experience firsthand the love of God for us. This is foundational.

As long as we, as believers, think God is going to punish us for our sins, then we will walk in fear because we have not yet experienced God's perfect **love** for us (see 1 John 4:18 mentioned earlier in this Chapter). Jesus has already taken upon Himself all our punishment. As long as we **believe and remain in Jesus**, we will never be punished for our sins. In fact, the only sin that God punishes is the sin of rejecting His Son. Jesus has already taken upon Himself all of God's wrath for our sins. When the scriptures say that he took "all", it means He took "all". My friends get a hold of this **truth**. The **truth** is you are forgiven for all your sins **because** you believe in Jesus as your personal Savior and Lord.

John had a revelation of God's love for Him personally. John believed and declared that He was loved. We know the scripture says that John was the disciple who Jesus loved. Right! We are familiar with this scripture. Do you know where this scripture is found? Let me tell you. It is found in the gospel written by John. John, himself, declared it in John 13:23. He says "one of them, **the disciple whom Jesus loved**, **was reclining next to him**."

John believed that Jesus loved him and because he believed it, he declared it. I used to think: "WOW, John is the disciple who Jesus loved. He had a special place in Jesus' heart." Now that I understand and believe that Jesus loves me the same as He loved John, I can believe and declare that "Jeannette is the disciple that Jesus loved". You can put your own name in there. You can do that now. Say your name and then say "is the disciple that Jesus loved".

I also want to point out something else in the scripture in John 13:23 where John states that he is the disciple whom Jesus loved. He goes on to say that He was reclining next to Jesus. This was at the last supper. I don't see anywhere in scripture where Jesus told the apostles to sit in certain seats at the Last Supper. I don't see that Jesus had reserved a seat right next to him for John. I believe it was John who chose to sit right next to Jesus. It was John who chose to lean his head against Jesus' breast. Because John believed that Jesus loved him, he wanted to be as close to Jesus as he could possibly be. When we know Christ's love for us like this, we will automatically love Him and love others as He loved us because we have been made full with His love.

The second antidote to the spirit of anti-Christ is walking in the truth, knowing the love of the Father, the Son and the Holy Spirit experientially, and loving others with His love that resides within us. This will protect us from the **lies** of false teachers who are operating in the spirit of anti-Christ. The spirit of anti-Christ will try to lead us away from Jesus but **when we**

know the truth that Jesus loves us personally, it will lead us to stay right at His side, close to Him like John.

I woke up early one morning and the Holy Spirit was speaking to me. He said that if we are willing to **die** to self, He will use us and teach us things so that others may benefit. The following scripture came to my mind that I had just read the day before:

> *"I tell you the truth, unless a kernel of wheat falls to the ground and dies, it remains only a single seed. But if it dies, it produces many seeds. The man who loves his life will lose it, while the man who hates his life in this world will keep it for eternal life. Whoever serves me must follow me; and where I am, my servant also will be" (John 12:24-26).*

Jesus is speaking in this scripture. He was speaking to His disciples about His death. It was time for Him to die. He was the single kernel of wheat that would fall to the ground and die for mankind and through His death many seeds would be birthed (given life). He loved not His life to keep it. He did not cling to or hold on to His life on earth. It was His choice to do so. He could have called twelve legions of angels (see Matthew 26:53) to rescue Him. Instead, He willingly chose not to do that but to die so all who believe in Him would have eternal life. **It was His love for us that kept Him on the cross** and because He died for us He has given birth (life) to every believer.

This next scripture is right after Jesus had washed the feet of the apostles.

> *"You call me Teacher and Lord, and rightly so, for that is what I am. Now that I, your Lord and Teacher, have washed your feet, you also should wash one another's feet. I have set you an example that you should do as I have done for you" (John 13:13-15).*

I have a note in one of my Bibles that says "The act of washing feet is given to **inspire** self-denying acts of kindness to all in need". It is not the literal washing of feet that Jesus was

inspiring His apostles to do but rather it was self-denying acts of kindness (love).

> *"If you have any encouragement from being united with Christ, if any comfort* ***from his love****, if any fellowship with the Spirit, if any tenderness and compassion, then make my joy complete by being like-minded,* ***having the same love****, being one in spirit and purpose. Do nothing out of selfish ambition or vain conceit, but in humility consider others better than yourselves. Each of you should look not only to your own interests, but also to the interests of others" (Philippians 2:1-5, emphasis added).*

In the same way, it is our choice whether or not we surrender to God's perfect Will for our lives. It doesn't mean that we are not saved if we have not come to the place of being able to surrender our will. It simply means that we are willingly choosing to lay down our lives for others even if it means going through some unpleasant things in our lives. When we go through unpleasant trials and storms, we will grow spiritually and get some understanding of how to get the victory even in the midst of the storm. This will enable us to help others who may be going through similar things. This is loving others as Christ loved us. He willingly chose to lay down His life for us so that we would benefit from what He suffered. In the same way, we willingly choose to lay down our lives for others so that they will benefit from what we suffered. If we really want to serve God in this life, we will follow Jesus' example. It doesn't make us any more righteous but it will cause us to bear much fruit for God's Kingdom.

If, at this time, you are unable to lay down your life and suffer for others, don't condemn yourself. God doesn't love you any less. In fact, He wants to reveal His unconditional love to you. Just keep meditating on scriptures on the love of God for you personally so that you will know His love experientially. Keep basking in Jesus' love for you like John did and His love will make you whole. Keep receiving His love and allow Him to fill you up and make you full with His love. Remember under

the New Covenant of grace it isn't about us. It is all about Jesus and what He did for us. Being made full (complete) with His love is the only way that we will be able to love others as He loved us. His love will flow from us automatically.

> *"A **new** command I give you: Love one another. **As I have loved you**, so you must love one another" (John 13:34, emphasis added).*

The commandment under the Old Covenant law was to love your neighbor as yourself (see Matthew 22:39). However, under the New Covenant of grace, we are commanded to love others as Christ loved us. Only the recreated man can love like this because God's love has been written on the heart and mind of the new re-created man. God Himself put His love in our hearts so that we could love like this. His love is already written on our hearts but in order to let His love flow from us, we need to meditate on His love for us. I have dedicated a Chapter in my book "Sorrow to Everlasting Joy" on knowing and experiencing God's love. We need to grasp how wide and long and high and deep is the love of Christ for us personally and know this love experientially (see Ephesians 3:17-19). Unless we know the love of Christ for us personally and intimately, we will not be able to love others as Jesus loved us. Once we are filled up to overflowing with God's love for us, then and only then will we be able to love others as Jesus loved us.

When we know that Jesus is God in the flesh and believe in Him as our personal Savior and Lord and when we know Christ's perfect love for us, we will not be deceived by false teachers who are operating in the spirit of anti-Christ.

The understanding of God's Word is the greatest defense against the spirit of anti-Christ (which is a spirit of deception) (see 2 Timothy 3:15-16).

The truth set forth above will keep us from believing the lies of those operating in the spirit of anti-Christ. **This truth** my friends is what will keep us believing in Jesus. It will keep us

focused on Jesus and what He has done for us. **This is the antidote to the spirit of anti-Christ.**

Freedom to Receive God's Blessings

*"When God made his **promise** to Abraham, since there was no one greater for him to swear by, he swore by himself, saying, "I will surely **bless you** and give you many descendants" (Hebrews 6:13-14, emphasis added).*

God made a promise to Abraham to bless him and his descendants. God originally gave this promise to Abram in Genesis 12:1-3. Please look up this scripture and read it for yourself. **In Christ**, we are descendants of Abraham (see Galatians 3:29).

My NIV Bible has a footnote for Genesis 12:1-3 as follows: "This **promise** to Abraham is one of the most significant passages in the entire Bible. **It points ultimately to the redemption of the whole world.** Abraham's family became a divinely appointed channel through which blessing would come to all men. This promise was formalized in a covenant (Genesis 15:17-21), and was repeated four additional times: twice to Abraham (Genesis 17:6-8; 22:16-18), once to Isaac (Genesis 26:3-4) and once to Jacob (Genesis 28:13-14). **This promise** is emphasized in the New Testament in Acts 3:25, Romans 4:13, Galatians 3:8,29 (**where it is called "the gospel"**), and Ephesians 2:12. Its importance to the Gentiles is evident, for it is clearly stated that Gentiles who were "separate" and "foreigners

to the covenants of the promise" have been brought to it by the blood of Christ (Galatians 3:8; Ephesians 2:12,13)."

I want you to specifically take note of the fact that **the promise is called "the gospel"**. The whole world can receive redemption by believing in the gospel of Jesus Christ. God announced the gospel in advance to Abraham that all peoples on earth (who believe) would be blessed (redeemed) through Jesus Christ (see Acts 3:25-26). He announced to Abraham that Jesus Christ would come from His bloodline.

> *"The Scripture foresaw that God would justify the Gentiles by faith, and* ***announced the gospel in advance to Abraham****" (Galatians 3:8, emphasis added).*

> *"If you belong to Christ, then you are Abraham's seed, and* ***heirs*** *according to the promise" (Galatians 3:29).*

The promise was that we would be blessed **in Christ Jesus** (both Jew and Gentile).

Let's continue on in the book of Hebrews.

> *"Men swear by someone greater than themselves, and the* ***oath confirms*** *what is said and puts an end to all argument.* *Because God wanted to make the unchanging nature of his purpose very clear* ***to the heirs*** *of what was* ***promised****,* ***he confirmed it with an oath****. God did this so that, by* ***two unchangeable things*** *in which it is impossible for God to lie, we who have fled* ***to take hold of the hope*** *offered to us may be greatly encouraged" (Hebrews 6:16-18, emphasis added).*

Just as we lay our hands on the Bible to take an oath, God laid His hand on Himself and made an oath **to the heirs** to confirm what He **promised** to Abraham and his descendants. The promise was that Abraham and his descendants would be blessed. **The oath that He took to confirm His promise was that there would be two things that He would never change**. Why? So that He could put an end to all argument. The

argument that He put an end to was: that as believers in Christ Jesus we are blessed just like Abraham.

> *"We have **this hope as an anchor for the soul, firm and secure**" (Hebrews 6:19, emphasis added).*

We see here in the above scripture that our hope in these two unchangeable things (God's two-part oath) is like an anchor for our soul that holds us firm and secure in Christ? So what are the two unchangeable things (God's oath) that puts an end to all argument?

> *"The former regulation is set aside because it was weak and useless (for the law made nothing perfect), and **a better hope** is introduced by which we draw near to God. And it was not without an **oath**! Others became priests without any oath, but **he became a priest with an oath** when God said to him: "The Lord **has sworn and will not change his mind**: **You are a priest forever**." Because of **this oath**, Jesus has become the guarantee of a better covenant" (Hebrews 7:18–22, emphasis added).*

The above scripture is talking about Jesus. So we see here the **first unchangeable thing** is that Jesus is our High Priest forever. This is what we need to remember and believe. Jesus is our High Priest forever. Our part is to believe in Him and what He did for us in His finished work on the Cross and remain in Him. As long as we remain in Him, He is our High Priest forever. This will never change. Hallelujah!!!

Now let's look at the second unchangeable thing (God's oath).

> *"For when there is a change of the priesthood, there must also be **a change of the law**" (Hebrews 7:12, emphasis added).*

So we see that there was a change of the priesthood. Now let's look at the change of the law.

"For if there had been nothing wrong with that ***first covenant****, no place would have been sought for another.* ***But God found fault with the people*** *and said: "The time is coming, declares the Lord, when I will make a* ***new covenant*** *with the house of Israel and with the house of Judah.* ***It will not be like the covenant I made with their forefathers*** *when I took them by the hand to lead them out of Egypt, because they did not remain faithful to my covenant, and I turned away from them, declares the Lord.* ***This is the covenant*** *I will make with the house of Israel after that time, declares the Lord.* ***I will put my laws in their minds and write them on their hearts.*** *I will be their God and they will be my people. For* ***I will forgive*** *their wickedness and will* ***remember their sins no more****" (Hebrews 8:7-12, emphasis added).*

In the Old Covenant, the onus was on the Israelites to obey the law, which they could not fully do. Therefore, God found fault with the people because they did not remain faithful to Him. He did not find fault with the Old Covenant law, only the people. In 1 Thessalonians 5:23 it says that **God is faithful** and He will do it; that is He will keep us. In the New Covenant, the onus is on **God's faithfulness** to keep us. Jesus obeyed the law completely for us. Our part is to believe in Jesus and what He did on the Cross for us. It is so simple. The bible says that Jesus is able to save completely those who come to God through him because he always lives to intercede for them (see Hebrews 7:25).

We, as Christians, can make it so difficult for people to walk in victory. I've done it myself. We put many burdens on people. You need to do this and you need to do that. If you follow these seven steps you will be healed. If you do this and do that, you will prosper and walk in victory. God said that when we enter into the New Covenant which is believing with our heart that God raised Jesus from the dead and confessing with our mouth that Jesus Christ is Lord, we are saved (see Romans 10:9) and we now have the blessings of Abraham. We are no longer under the curse. The blessings of God are chasing after us and overtaking

us. This is something to shout about! However, if we do not take the time to get rooted and grounded in the Word and find out what belongs to us as children of God we will not know these things and, therefore, we will not benefit from them. It is so important to get the Word of God in our hearts and coming out of our mouths.

> *"First he said, 'Sacrifices and offerings, burnt offerings and sin offerings you did not desire, nor were you pleased with them' (although the law required them to be made). Then he said, 'Here I am, I have come to do your will'.* ***He sets aside the first to establish the second****. And by that will we have been made holy through the sacrifice of the body of Jesus Christ* ***once for all****. Day after day every priest stands and performs his religious duties; again and again he offers the same sacrifices, which can never take away sins. But when this priest had offered for all time one sacrifice for sins, he* ***sat down*** *at the right hand of God. Since that time he waits for his enemies to be made his footstool, because* ***by one sacrifice he has made perfect forever*** *those who are being made holy. The Holy Spirit also testifies to us about this. First he says: 'This is the* ***covenant*** *I will make with them after that time', says the Lord.* ***'I will put my laws in their hearts, and I will write them on their minds'****. Then he adds:* ***'Their sins and lawless acts I will remember no more'. And where these have been forgiven, there is no longer any sacrifice for sin"*** *(Hebrews 10:8-18, emphasis added).*

It was God's Will to set aside the first Covenant to establish the second Covenant. The first Covenant being the law and the second Covenant being grace. When Jesus died on the cross, He nailed the law to the cross, thus He abolished in His flesh the Old Covenant of law and established the New Covenant of grace for all those who would believe in Him. The law has not been abolished for the unbeliever for God uses the law to lead them to Christ (see Galatians 3:24) BUT for the believer the law (including its curse) has been abolished. When Jesus sat down at the right hand of God, He was saying "It is finished". The New

Covenant of grace has been established. Under the New Covenant of grace, he said: "**Their sins and lawless acts I will remember no more. And where these have been forgiven, there is no longer any sacrifice for sin."**

The above scripture says that under the New Covenant of grace all our sins and lawless acts have been forgiven. When we come to the cross and believe in Jesus and in His finished work, our sins and lawless acts have all been forgiven (past, present and future). He said we have been made holy once for all. There is only one sacrifice and it covers all our sins (past, present and future). This, my friend, is the New Covenant of grace.

So, the **second unchangeable thing** that puts an end to all argument is the establishing of the New Covenant of grace. Since there was a change of priesthood, there had to be a change of Law (Covenant). By Jesus' sacrifice, He did away with the Old Covenant of law for the believer and established the New Covenant of grace where all our sins and lawless acts have been forgiven and are remembered no more. This will never change.

In Abraham's time, these two unchangeable things (God's two-part oath) had not yet taken place but God in His faithfulness brought them about in His perfect timing to confirm His promise to bless Abraham **and his descendants**.

God has never failed to fulfill His oaths. God did not establish the law of Moses or the Levitical priesthood by **an oath** and, therefore, He was free to abolish or change them at His Will.

These two unchangeable things (God's two-part oath) is the hope that we have as an anchor for our soul which will hold us firm and secure in Christ Jesus. These two unchangeable things confirm God's promise to bless us (Jew and Gentile). By these two unchangeable things God **fulfilled His promise** to Abraham and his descendants. This brings stability and security to our lives and will hold us steadfast in Jesus. **Our hope in these two unchangeable things will cause us to draw near to God and receive the blessings of Abraham.**

Let's look at them again. The two unchangeable things (God's two-part oath) are:

1. Jesus is our High Priest forever.
2. Jesus, by His one sacrifice, established the New Covenant of grace where all our sins and lawless acts have been forgiven and are remembered no more.

These will never change because of God's oath.

This is the hope that is an anchor for our soul (our mind, our will and our emotions which flow out of our heart). An anchor keeps us stable. It keeps us steadfast. This is the hope that we have in Christ and the confidence that we have to receive God's promise of blessings in our life. It is no longer about us being good enough and faithful enough to earn God's blessings (redemption). It is all about God's goodness and faithfulness to us. Our part is to believe in Him, receive His blessings and remain in Him.

> *"Therefore he is able to **save completely** those who come to God through him, because **he always lives to intercede for them**" (Hebrews 7:25, emphasis added).*

Jesus is always before the Father interceding for me and you so that we will grab hold of this truth and remain in it.

What an awesome and great salvation we have been given. There is no greater blessing.

Freedom to Embrace the Grace of God

I would like to take you to some scriptures about Jesus feeding the thousands and also scriptures on the Chief Baker and the Chief Cupbearer in Joseph's life. I am going to lay a foundation with these scriptures and then tell you how they relate to Holy Communion, the redemptive work of Jesus and the establishing of the New Covenant of grace. If you need a healing or something from the Lord, please pay close attention so that you can apply these truths to your life.

Let's begin with the feeding of the thousands.

"Jesus called his disciples to him and said, "I have compassion for these people; they have already been with me ***three days*** *and have nothing to eat. I do not want to send them away hungry, or they may collapse on the way." His disciples answered, "Where could we get enough bread in this remote place to feed such a crowd?" "How many loaves do you have?" Jesus asked. "Seven," they replied, "and a few small fish." He told the crowd to sit down on the ground. Then* ***he took the seven loaves*** *and the fish, and when he had* ***given thanks****,* ***he broke*** *them and* ***gave them to the disciples****, and they in turn to the people. They all ate and were* ***satisfied****. Afterward the disciples picked up seven basketfuls of broken pieces that were* ***left over****. The number of those who ate was four thousand men, besides women and children" (Matthew 15:32-38, emphasis added).*

You will see the similarity when he fed the five thousand in the next scripture.

*"**Taking the five loaves** and the two fish and looking up to heaven, he **gave thanks** and **broke the loaves**. Then he **gave them to his disciples** to distribute to the people. He also divided the two fish among them all. They all ate and were **satisfied**, and the disciples **picked up** twelve basketfuls of broken pieces of bread and fish" (Mark 6:41-43, emphasis added).*

Let's look at the Last Supper in the following scripture.

*"While they were eating, **Jesus took bread**, **gave thanks** and **broke it**, and **gave it to his disciples**, saying, "Take and eat; this is my body" (Matthew 26:26, emphasis added).*

Do you see the similarity between the feeding of the thousands and the Last Supper? In each scripture reference, Jesus took the bread, gave thanks, broke it and gave it to His disciples.

Now let's take a look at the Last Supper scriptures in 1 Corinthians but before we do that I want you to see something in the preceding scriptures.

"When you come together, it is not the Lord's Supper you eat, for as you eat, each of you goes ahead without waiting for anybody else. One remains hungry, another gets drunk. Don't you have homes to eat and drink in? Or do you despise the church of God and humiliate those who have nothing? What shall I say to you? Shall I praise you for this? Certainly not!" (1 Corinthians 11:20-22).

Paul had nothing good to say about the manner in which the Corinthians were partaking of the Last Supper (Holy Communion). In fact, he rebuked them for they were just filling their stomachs. They were not honoring Jesus. They were not remembering what Jesus accomplished for them in His redemptive work. It was only a meal for them to fill their stomachs.

Let's carry on with the next verses at the Last Supper.

" For I (Paul) received from the Lord what I also passed on to you: The Lord Jesus, on the night he was betrayed, took ***bread****, and when he had given thanks,* ***he broke it*** *and said, "This is my* ***body****, which is for you; do this in remembrance of me." In the same way,* ***after supper*** *he took the* ***cup****, saying, "****This cup is the new covenant*** *in my* ***blood****; do this, whenever you drink it, in remembrance of me." For whenever you eat this bread and drink this cup, you proclaim the Lord's death until he comes" (1 Corinthians 11:23-26, emphasis and parenthesis added).*

At the Last Supper Jesus **broke the bread** and when He broke the bread He said: "This is my **body**". The bread is symbolic of the **broken body** of Jesus. Jesus' body was nailed to the cross. The bread is also symbolic of the Old Covenant law being nailed to the cross. Please bear with me as I will elaborate on this more.

Also, I want you to see that at the Last Supper, the bread came before the cup (wine) just like the Old Covenant law came before the New Covenant of grace.

The cup (wine) at the last supper is symbolic of the **blood** of Jesus that He shed for us. It is also symbolic of the New Covenant of grace. He said, "This cup is the **new Covenant** in my blood". The cup (wine) at the Last Supper came after the bread just like the New Covenant of grace came after the Old Covenant law.

I want to point out here that when Jesus fed the thousands, He only gave them bread. They must have been thirsty as well but there is no mention of anything to drink. Why? Because it wasn't the time for Jesus to die and shed His blood for us. It wasn't the time to establish the New Covenant of grace but that was soon to come. The feeding of the thousands was **pointing** to the bread at the Last Supper and the broken body of Jesus on the cross.

*"Therefore, whoever eats the bread or drinks the cup of the Lord in an **unworthy manner** will be guilty of sinning against the body and blood of the Lord. A man ought to examine himself before he eats of the bread and drinks of the cup. For anyone who eats and drinks **without recognizing the body of the Lord** eats and drinks judgment on himself. That is why many among you are weak and sick, and a number of you have fallen asleep" (1 Corinthians 11:27-30, emphasis added).*

So as I said, the Corinthians were eating and drinking as if it was only a meal to fill their empty stomachs. It had no spiritual meaning to them whatsoever. They were not honoring Jesus and what He accomplished for them in His redemptive work. In fact, they were dishonoring Him. They were not recognizing what Jesus did and the symbolism of Holy Communion. They were not recognizing that Jesus had fulfilled the Old Covenant law for them and had established the New Covenant of grace. They were not discerning this.

The establishing of the New Covenant of grace was a historical and life-changing event for those who would believe in Jesus and in His finished work.

I noticed in the book of John that the Last Supper scriptures only mention Judas Iscariot partaking of the bread which represented the Old Covenant law. He did not receive the wine representing the New Covenant of grace. In John 13:30 it says "As soon as Judas had taken the **bread**, he went out."

Now I want to take you to the scriptures about the Chief Cupbearer and the Chief Baker in Joseph's life. We know from the scriptures that Pharaoh was not pleased with his Chief Cupbearer and his Chief Baker and he threw them into prison. While in prison, both had dreams and both dreams were interpreted by Joseph who was also in prison.

These dreams are very interesting. I want you to see what these dreams meant and their relationship to the bread and the cup (wine) at the Last Supper and the redemptive work of Jesus which led to the establishing of the New Covenant of grace.

- The Chief Cupbearer's dream and Joseph's interpretation.

*"So the chief **cupbearer** told Joseph his dream. He said to him, "In my dream I saw a **vine** in front of me, and on the vine were **three branches**. As soon as it budded, it blossomed, and its clusters ripened into **grapes**. Pharaoh's **cup** was in my hand, and I took the grapes, squeezed them into Pharaoh's **cup** and put the **cup** in his hand. This is what it means," Joseph said to him. "The three branches are **three days**. Within **three days** Pharaoh will lift up your head and **restore you to your position**, and you will put Pharaoh's cup in his hand, just as you used to do when you were his cupbearer" (Genesis 40:9-13, emphasis added).*

- The Chief Baker's dream and Joseph's interpretation.

*"When the chief **baker** saw that Joseph had given a favorable interpretation, he said to Joseph, "I too had a dream: On my head were **three baskets** of **bread**. In the top basket were all kinds of baked goods for Pharaoh, but the birds were eating them out of the basket on my head." "This is what it means," Joseph said. "The three baskets are **three days**. Within **three days** Pharaoh will lift off your head and **hang you on a tree**. And the birds will eat away your flesh" (Genesis 40:16-19, emphasis added).*

So we see from these scriptures that the Chief Cupbearer had a **favorable** outcome, but not so for the Chief Baker.

There is a lot of symbolism in these dreams. Let's take a closer look at them.

- The three days in both dreams represent the three days after Jesus' death and before His resurrection.
- The Chief Baker's **bread** represents the bread at the Last Supper and the bread points to the broken body of Jesus which was hung on the cross.
- The Chief Baker was **not restored** to his position. He was hung on a tree and died just like Jesus died on a tree. **This represents the death of the Old Covenant law.**

The Old Covenant was nailed to the cross and abolished through the broken body of Jesus (see Colossians 2:14). Jesus fulfilled the Old Covenant law for us who believe as we could not fulfill it ourselves.

- The grapes on the vine that the Chief Cupbearer squeezed into Pharaoh's **cup** represent the cup (wine) at the Last Supper and the cup (wine) points to the blood of Jesus and the New Covenant of grace. The shedding of His blood, His resurrection and restoration to His heavenly throne represents the establishing and ratification of the New Covenant of grace.

- The Chief Cupbearer **was restored** to his position, unlike the Chief Baker. This points to Jesus who was raised to life, having given birth to the New Covenant of grace and being seated on the throne of grace (see Hebrews 4:16).

- The Chief Cupbearer and Chief Baker's dreams and interpretations were **prophetic** as they both pointed to Jesus and what Jesus would accomplish for us in His redemptive work. They symbolize the bread and the cup of the new covenant (wine) at the Last Supper.

When we partake of the **bread** at Holy Communion we are to remember that Jesus, through His broken body, abolished the Old Covenant law for the believer and when we partake of the **cup (wine)** at Holy Communion we are to remember that through Jesus' shed blood, He established the New Covenant of grace.

We are to remember that a change of Covenant took place. This is very important to understand. As believers, we are under a New Covenant. This was the whole purpose of Jesus' redemptive work. When Jesus took the wine at the Last Supper, He said: "This cup is the **new Covenant** in my blood." We are no longer under the Old Covenant law.

If God wanted us to remain under the Old Covenant law it would not have been necessary for Him to send His one and only Son to shed His blood for us and establish a New Covenant. So

we need to recognize what Jesus did for us and embrace the New Covenant of grace.

Now I want you to see something else in this next scripture.

> *"For he himself is our peace, who has made the two groups one and has destroyed the barrier, the dividing wall of hostility, by setting aside in his flesh the law* ***with its commands and regulations****" (Ephesians 2:14-15a, emphasis added).*

When Jesus nailed the Old Covenant law to the cross, it included the 10 commandments. We are no longer under the 10 commandments today. We are under grace. We are no longer led by the law (which represents our self-efforts, our self-righteousness). **We are led by the Spirit**. The Holy Spirit is the Spirit of truth. Can you see that? Please read it again.

The law is all about us and what we can do for God. It is about our self-righteousness. It is all about us being good enough to make it to heaven on our own merit. **Grace is all about Jesus** and what He has already done for us. It is about His righteousness, His goodness (not ours). The reason why God made it impossible for us to fully obey the Old Covenant law is so that we would not depend on ourselves, our own efforts and self-righteousness to be good enough to earn salvation.

> *"I am the* ***living bread*** *that came down from heaven. If anyone eats of this* ***bread,*** *he will live forever. This* ***bread*** *is my flesh, which I will give for the* ***life of*** *the world" (John 6:51, emphasis added).*

There is a difference between the Old Testament bread, the Old Covenant bread and the Living Bread that came down from heaven. When I refer to the Old Covenant bread, I am referring to the law, not the Old Testament bread. Jesus only abolished the Old Covenant **law and its 10 commandments** on the cross. He did not abolish the Old Testament.

The Living Bread (the Word of God) is Jesus Himself. The Bible says that the Word of God (which is Truth) is alive and active. It brings life to us. The Word of God is living. As we

read and meditate on the Word of God it becomes alive in us. Jesus is the Word of God (the Living Bread) and He is alive. Reading and meditating on the Word of God does not make us any more righteous than we already are, but **it sure enables us to walk in the victory that Jesus died to give us**. The Word of God is our inheritance in Christ Jesus. To read and meditate on the Word of God is to receive our inheritance. It is so important to get the Word of God into our hearts and coming out of our mouths. The choice is ours to make. I pray that you will choose life.

The Old **Covenant** bread (the law, not the Old **Testament** bread) brought condemnation and **death**. The New Covenant Bread (Jesus, the Grace of God, the Word of God) brings freedom and **life**. Jesus is the Living Bread.

At the Last Supper, Jesus was symbolically depicting before the apostles what He would accomplish in His redemptive work.

- His body would be broken just like the bread was broken at the feeding of the thousands. By dying for us the Old Covenant law would be abolished and the curse nailed to the cross (see Galatians 3:13) for the believer just like the Chief Baker was hung on a tree and was not restored to his position, and

- By shedding His blood, being raised from the dead and His ascension into heaven to once again sit on His throne, the New Covenant of grace was established just like the Chief Cupbearer was restored to his position.

Jesus' ministry on earth was to prepare people's hearts to make the transition from the Old Covenant law to the New Covenant of grace.

Jesus is the Bridge that transports us from one to the other. He came to be a bridge for those living under the Law so that by believing in Him they could come and live under grace and receive His life. When Jesus fed the thousands, He was preparing them for this transition. He was pointing them to the

Last Supper that was soon to be a reality. Although He was feeding their stomachs, He would soon be feeding their spirits.

In the Old **Testament,** we see the manna that came down from heaven and the bread that strengthened Elijah which only fed their bodies and only pointed to Jesus. **They were only a type of Christ or a shadow of Christ**. The reality was yet to come.

We also see the Old **Covenant** law which also only pointed to Jesus. It was put into place so that people would realize that they were sinners in need of a Savior, who is Jesus.

The Old Testament bread and the Old Covenant law both only pointed to Jesus. But now we have Jesus Himself, the actual Living Bread of Life (not just a shadow).

Just prior to this next scripture reference, Jesus was on the road to Emmaus with two disciples and when they arrived at their house, the two disciples invited Jesus in to eat with them. Let's look at what took place.

> *"When he was at the table with them, he took bread, gave thanks, broke it and began to give it to them.* ***Then their eyes were opened and they recognized him****, and he disappeared from their sight" (Luke 24:30-31, emphasis added).*

Jesus had been in their midst. He was right there with them. The Living Bread was in their home. The actual Living Bread of Life (not just a shadow).

When Jesus broke the bread, He gave them Living Bread. He gave them Himself. They partook not of the bread of the Old Covenant law but of the Living Bread of the New Covenant of grace and when they had partaken of it, **their eyes were opened**. When we embrace the grace of God alone, not mixing it with the law, our eyes will be opened too. The veil was removed from their eyes. They recognized Jesus for who He truly was. God! They recognized Him as the resurrected Christ (their Messiah). The eyes of their hearts were also opened so that they could now understand what He was saying to them while on the Road.

They had not recognized Him **before they partook** of the Living Bread of the New Covenant of grace nor did they understand what He was saying to them on the Road although their hearts were wanting more.

When we partake of the New Covenant Living Bread (the grace of God), our eyes will be opened as well, the veil which separates us from God's holy presence removed and we will recognize Him. Only by the grace of God can the veil be removed from our eyes.

At Jesus' death, the veil that separated the Holy Place from the Holy of Holies was rent in two from top to bottom. This is because God tore the veil, not man. God made a way for man to enter the Most Holy Place (His presence) through the shed blood of Jesus Christ. There is no other way to enter into His presence. God was the only One who could tear the veil in two from top to bottom. The veil was 30 feet long, 30 feet wide and 30 feet high (see 1 Kings 6:20). The veil was very thick so that no one could inadvertently fall into the Holy of Holies by tripping or leaning up against it. No amount of man's efforts could tear that veil showing us that it is impossible for man to save himself. Only God could tear the veil and only God can save us and bring us into His presence.

Just as God rent the Red Sea in two, He tore the veil that separated the people from coming into the Holy of Holies (God's presence). Just as the renting of the Red Sea delivered the Israelites from their enemies and from slavery to the Egyptians, the renting of the veil freed believers from the Old Covenant law and slavery to sin.

In 1 Corinthians 11 it says that "this cup is the **new covenant** in my blood". A Covenant is always established with the **shedding of blood**. Jesus was resurrected from the grave and He took **His blood** to heaven and presented it before the mercy seat of God. Just like the Old Covenant Priests took the blood of animals into the Most Holy Place once a year and sprinkled it on the mercy seat, Jesus entered heaven, which is the true tabernacle, not just a copy, and sat down on the mercy seat

(the throne of God). The High Priest had to enter the Holy of Holies every year but Jesus did it once and for all time. His work was finished once and for all. Let's look at that scripture.

> *"For Christ did not enter a man-made sanctuary that was only a copy of the true one; he entered heaven itself, now to appear for us in God's presence.* ***Nor did he enter heaven to offer himself again and again, the way the high priest enters the Most Holy Place every year with blood that is not his own****" (Hebrews 9:24-25, emphasis added).*

Jesus entered heaven with His own blood. Through Jesus' resurrection, He became our High Priest forever and ratified (confirmed) the New Covenant of grace. A **new birth** had taken place. **The birth of a New Covenant**. Jesus is now our Living Bread. He is grace personified. He is grace clothed in flesh. The Old **Covenant** bread (the law) brought condemnation and death but the New Covenant Living Bread (grace) brings life and freedom to all who believe. Jesus is alive. He is our Living Bread.

> *"For the* ***bread of God*** *is he who comes down from heaven and gives* ***life*** *to the world" (John 6:33, emphasis added).*

> *"Then Jesus declared, "I am the* ***bread of life****. Whoever comes to me will never go hungry, and whoever believes in me will never be thirsty" (John 6:35, emphasis added).*

Jesus is our Living Bread. He is alive. He is our sustenance. He sustains us. He came to give life to our spirit, soul and body. He came to make us whole.

Just like the thousands were satisfied and made full **physically**, when we believe in Jesus and feed on Him, the Living Bread (the Grace of God, the Word of God) we will be satisfied and made full (whole) in our **spirit, soul and body**.

> *" Is not the* ***cup*** *of thanksgiving for which we give thanks a* ***participation*** *in the* ***blood*** *of Christ? And is not the* ***bread*** *that we break a* ***participation*** *in the* ***body*** *of Christ?" (1 Corinthians 10:16, emphasis added).*

We need to recognize that Jesus' body which represents the Old **Covenant** bread (the law that only pointed to Jesus) was broken for us by becoming a curse for us. Jesus literally took the curse for us.

Jesus was born as a man living under the law. He was born under the Old Covenant law. His body was hung on a tree as a man living under the law, **yet fully God**. **He literally took the curse** of the law on His body and His body was broken for us. The curse is set out in Deuteronomy 28. The curse was nailed to the cross (see Galatians 3:13). He abolished in His flesh the law for those who would believe in Him. His blood was shed for us. He died for us. Through His death, burial and resurrection, **He destroyed the curse over our lives**, forgave us of all our sins, did away with the Old Covenant law for the believer and gave birth to the New Covenant of grace. **We participate** in the body and blood of Jesus **as we recognize and properly discern** what Jesus has done for us in His redemptive work **by receiving His grace and no longer living under the law as if we could earn our own salvation**. Jesus has become our High Priest forever and He has done away with the Old Covenant law for us who believe in Him and has given birth to the New Covenant of grace.

Grace is unearned, unmerited, undeserved favor of God. Grace is a gift.

I want to mention something else here about the Chief Cupbearer. In his dream he says that he saw a vine in front of him with three branches and as soon as it budded, it blossomed and its clusters ripened into grapes.

Jesus is our Vine and we are the branches. In the natural process, grapes form, grow and ripen from being connected to the Vine. It is the same with us. We will grow and mature by being connected to Jesus who is our Vine (the grace of God).

> *"For the law was given through Moses;* ***grace and truth*** *came through Jesus Christ" (John 1:17, emphasis added).*

Grace and truth in this scripture is a singular unit. We know that Jesus is Truth. He is the Word of God. In this scripture, we also see that Jesus is Grace. Grace is not a subject to be studied but a person. This scripture says that "**grace came**". Grace is Jesus Christ. He came from heaven. To reject the grace of God is to reject Jesus Himself. Grace and Truth go together. They cannot be separated. They go hand in hand. Jesus is Grace. Jesus is also Truth.

When we embrace the Word of God which is truth and we stay connected to the grace of God, who is Jesus our Vine, we will bear much fruit for the Kingdom of God.

> *"I am the vine; you are the branches. If a man remains in me and I in him, he will bear much fruit;* ***apart from me you can do nothing****" (John 15:5, emphasis added).*

Apart from the truth and the grace of God which go together, we can do nothing. We will not be able to bear fruit that lasts.

Paul wanted the Corinthians to recognize and properly discern the body and blood of Jesus Christ when they partook of Holy Communion. He said, "That is why many among you are weak and **sick**, and a number of you have fallen asleep."

Remember I said at the beginning of this Chapter to pay close attention if you are in need of a healing. Well, this is what you need to pay close attention to. Because people who were sick did not understand the purpose of eating and drinking the body and blood of Jesus, they died from their sickness or remained sick. They did not understand that the Old Covenant law and the curse of the Old Covenant law (which includes sickness) had been nailed to the cross and destroyed for them, that a New Covenant had been birthed, and that **Jesus' finished work had made healing and all the blessings of God (see Deuteronomy 28:1-13) available to them.**

Do you see the importance of recognizing and properly discerning the body and blood of Jesus Christ?

Remember when Jesus fed the thousands with bread, they were satisfied. That bread was pointing to Jesus, the Bread of Life (the Living Bread, the new wine, the grace of God, the Word of God). When we feed on Jesus, He will satisfy us, make us full (whole in every area of our lives), nourish and strengthen us to live a life of victory. Also, remember when Jesus fed the thousands, there were many baskets full of food leftover. This speaks to our Living Bread, Jesus, being more than enough. His grace never runs out.

> *"The **former regulation is set aside** because it was weak and useless (for **the law** made nothing perfect), and a **better hope** is introduced, by which we draw near to God. And it was not without an oath! Others became priests without any oath, but he became a priest with an oath when God said to him: "The Lord has sworn and will not change his mind: 'You are a priest forever.' Because of this oath, Jesus has become the guarantor of a **better covenant**" (Hebrews 7:18-22, emphasis added).*

We are under a better covenant today if we believe in Jesus.

God does not want us mixing law and grace together because it is a deadly mixture.

The next scripture is a picture of when a believer mixes grace and law together.

> *"No one sews a patch of **unshrunk cloth** on an **old garment**, for the patch will pull away from the garment, making the tear worse. Neither do people pour **new wine** into **old wineskins**. If they do, the skins will burst; the wine will run out and the **wineskins will be ruined**. No, they pour **new wine into new wineskins, and both are preserved"** (Matthew 9:16-17, emphasis added).*

Jesus was giving an illustration of what happens when believers mix grace and law together. **Grace is like the new wine** and the **Old Covenant law is like the old wineskins**. Old wineskins cannot expand anymore because they have already

been used and expanded as much as they are going to expand. The old wineskin, the law, has already done its work in the life of a believer and is no longer useful for a believer. When new wine, which causes the wineskins to expand, is poured into old wineskins, the wineskins will burst (because there is no more room for expansion) ruining the wineskins and causing the wine to be poured out making the new wine ineffective. When this happens, both the wine and old wineskins are useless. They have both lost their effectiveness and their power. He is saying that neither grace nor the law is effective when we walk in mixture. However, when new wine (the grace of God) is poured into new wineskins (the New Covenant of grace), both are preserved and both are powerful. So you see here **grace upon grace**. You see pure unadulterated grace when new wine is poured into new wineskins. In this situation, there is no mixture and this will cause believers to be fruitful, very effective and powerful for the Kingdom of God. Jesus was saying that in order to receive the grace of God and have it be effective and powerful in your life, you have to get rid of the old wineskin (the law).

In the same way, grace is like the patch of unshrunk cloth and the Old Covenant law is like the old garment that has already been washed and shrunk. When the old garment is washed again, the new unshrunk patch will shrink and pull away from the old ruining the garment.

This is so important for you to understand. As a believer, you can unknowingly be mixing law and grace together. You receive God's grace for the salvation of your spirit but then go back under the law for the salvation of your soul. I did this before I came to understand that my soul is saved the same way my spirit was saved: by grace through faith. The enemy does not want you to understand that you are the righteousness of God in Christ Jesus, that you are fully accepted by Jesus and loved by God unconditionally. He does not want you to understand grace in its totality because when you understand grace and walk **in grace alone** you will be very effective and flow in God's power, bearing much fruit for the Kingdom of God. The devil does not

want you to be effective or fruitful in Christ Jesus. He does not want you to realize that you are now his master. He wants to keep you under the law because the law ministers death and ineffectiveness but grace ministers life and effectiveness. He is a thief and he comes to rob, steal, kill and destroy (see John 10:10a). However, Jesus came to give us abundant life, a grace-filled life (see John 10:10b). The devil wants to steal from you the righteousness that Jesus died to give you by keeping you in mixture. When you feel condemned, you think you are not doing enough so you go back under the law to be made more righteous instead of simply **believing that you have been made right which will produce right behavior and transformation**. The devil wants you to think that grace is something that you will take and use as a license to sin so that you will not receive the grace of God in its totality. Grace will cause you to reign over sin (see Romans 5:17), not go out and sin more. In fact, if you would take this message as a license to sin instead of the means to overcome sin in your life, you have not understood grace at all and are still living under the law.

In summary, Jesus, the Son of Man, (yet fully God) who was born under the law represented the bread of the Old Covenant law which only pointed to the resurrected Christ. He allowed His broken body to be nailed to the cross thus abolishing the Old Covenant law and by the shedding of His blood and His death, He was raised to life the Son of God (the Living Bread) giving birth to the New Covenant of grace.

Whenever we partake of Holy Communion, let us remember what Jesus accomplished for us in His redemptive work and recognize and properly discern the body and blood of Jesus Christ. **We honor** the body and blood of Jesus Christ by receiving His free gift of grace and His gift of righteousness; by purposing in our hearts to walk in grace alone (not mixing it with the law). **1 Corinthians 11 says that when we recognize and properly discern the body and blood of Jesus our bodies will be strong and healthy, not weak and sick.**

Freedom from Two Major Religious Systems

There are two major religious systems that are like the thief that robs, kills and destroys in John 10:10a.

- The religious system of the law, and
- The religious system of this world (humanism).

Neither one is good. They both will rob us of life and will lead us away from our true Shepherd who came to give us life. Life is not found in the system of the law or in the humanistic system of this world. It is found in Jesus Christ who is our Chief Cornerstone. Jesus is the only foundation upon which we build our life.

Sometimes believers mix grace and law together, and sometimes believers mix Kingdom living with worldly humanistic living.

I walked in a mixture of grace and law for a lot of years in my Christian life because I did not understand the grace of God. I got saved by grace through faith but then I went right back under the law to earn the salvation of my soul. This is mixing grace and law together. I am so thankful that God gave me understanding that my soul is saved the same way my spirit was saved: by grace through faith.

You can still be saved when you walk in mixture. However, if Christians continually and deliberately choose to live under the system of the law or choose to live a worldly humanistic lifestyle, they are rejecting the grace of God and are in danger of getting so far removed from sound doctrine and truth that they no longer believe in Christ as their Savior and Lord. They can become more and more deceived, buying into the lies and the deception of the enemy so much that they no longer are able to distinguish truth from falsehood.

When the Bible says that Jesus will keep us, it is referring to those who have made the choice to continue to believe in Him. He has still given us a free will to choose to believe in Him or not. If you choose to live under the law or like people without Christ who are living in this world's humanistic system, will you be found still believing in Christ at the end of your life or will you have strayed so far from Him that you no longer believe in Him?

Grace and Truth will not lead us into worldly living (humanism) or under condemnation (legalism). It sets us free from both. Isn't that wonderful!

Let's look at the following scripture reference and notice how Paul walked in a **legalistic righteousness** before he received Christ in his life.

> "*For it is we who are the circumcision, we who worship by the Spirit of God, who glory in Christ Jesus, and who put no confidence in the flesh – though I myself have reasons for such confidence. If anyone else thinks he has reasons to put confidence* ***in the flesh****, I have more: circumcised on the eighth day, of the people of Israel, of the tribe of Benjamin, a Hebrew of Hebrews; in regard to the law, a Pharisee; as for zeal, persecuting the church; as for* ***legalistic righteousness****, faultless. But whatever was to my profit I now consider loss for the sake of Christ. What is more, I consider everything a loss compared to the surpassing greatness of knowing Christ Jesus my Lord, for whose sake I*

have lost all things. I consider them rubbish, that I may gain Christ and be found in him, ***not having a righteousness of my own that comes from the law, but that which is through faith in Christ – the righteousness that comes from God and is by faith****. I want to know Christ and the power of his resurrection and the fellowship of sharing in his sufferings, becoming like him in his death, and so, somehow, to attain to the resurrection from the dead" (Philippians 3:3-11, emphasis added).*

Paul walked in a legalistic righteousness before he received Christ but not after. He considered the self-righteousness that he walked in under the law rubbish once he received the righteousness that comes from God by grace through faith in Christ Jesus.

Please notice in this next scripture reference that we are reconciled to Christ only as long as we continue to believe in Him?

"Once you were alienated from God and were enemies in your minds because of your evil behavior. But now he has reconciled you by Christ's physical body through death to present you holy in his sight, without blemish and free from accusation --, ***if you continue in your faith, established and firm, not moved from the hope held out in the gospel****. This is the gospel that you heard and that has been proclaimed to every creature under heaven, and of which I, Paul, have become a servant" (Colossian 1:21-23, emphasis added).*

Believing in Jesus and becoming born again is the only requirement for salvation. If we no longer believe in Jesus and no longer want Him in our life, we have lost our salvation. I'm not talking about a Christian who gets so discouraged that they say some things they really don't mean. Just because we sin and don't do everything right does not mean we have lost our salvation. None of us does everything perfectly all the time. However, if a Christian chooses to get so embedded in this world's humanistic belief system or so embedded in living under

the law, they are playing with fire and it is possible to come to that place of rejecting Jesus and not wanting Him in their life. This is when their salvation is lost because they have not continued in their faith.

> *"So then, just as you received Christ Jesus as Lord,* ***continue to live in him, rooted and built up in him, strengthened in the faith as you were taught****, and overflowing with thankfulness. See to it that no one takes you* ***captive*** *through* ***hollow and deceptive philosophy****, which depends* ***on human tradition and the basic principles of this world rather than on Christ****" (Colossians 2:6-8, emphasis added).*

The Passion translation says in verse 8:

> *"****Beware*** *that no one distracts you or intimidates you in their attempt to lead you away from Christ's fullness by pretending to be full of wisdom when they're filled with endless arguments of* ***human logic****. For they operate with* ***humanistic*** *and clouded judgments based on the* ***mindset of this world system****, and not the anointed truths of the Anointed One" (Colossians 2:8, emphasis added).*

Do you see how one can be led astray if we listen to people who are operating in human logic and the philosophy and mindsets of this world's belief system rather than on Christ and the truths found in the Word of God?

> ***Be quick to abstain from senseless traditions and legends****, but instead be engaged in the training of truth that brings righteousness" (1 Timothy 4:7).*

Getting God's Word into our heart is when we apply the Word to our everyday living with the Holy Spirit's help. Otherwise, it is just head knowledge. If we stop putting the Word of God into our hearts, little by little the enemy will snatch away the Word that we had received.

"For the grace of God that brings salvation has appeared to all men. ***It*** *(the grace of God)* ***teaches us*** *to say "No" to ungodliness* ***and worldly passions****, and to live self-controlled, upright and godly lives in this present age" (Titus 2:11-12, emphasis and parenthesis added).*

It is so very important for us to embrace the grace of God for it is the grace of God that will teach us to say "No" to the traditions of men and going back to live under the law and "No" to humanistic logic and worldly living. It is the grace of God that teaches us to say "Yes" to godliness and Kingdom living.

This day please choose life, the abundant life that Jesus died to give you. It is a free gift. Don't have one foot in the Kingdom of God and one foot in this world. **As the gap widens between truth and this world's belief system, you will be torn in two.** Please firmly plant both of your feet in the Kingdom of God by embracing His grace.

Prayer: Father, in Jesus' Name, please protect me from lying and deceiving spirits who would try to pull me back into the law and from lying and deceiving spirits who would try to pull me into this world's belief system. I pray that your Spirit would show me where I am mixing grace with the law and/or this world's ungodly belief system and quickly bring me to repentance. Strengthen me in the most holy faith so that I will only believe the truth and walk in it all the days of my life.

Freedom from the Old Sinful Fleshly Man and the Curse

- **My Dream:**

I had a dream where I was taking a **bath** and all of a sudden I couldn't lift my two hands out of the **water**. It was like something was holding them under the water. This lasted only a short time and I was able to lift my hands back up out of the water. Then the same thing happened again. **In my dream**, I asked the Holy Spirit what that was and He told me it was my old sinful fleshly man trying to arise. Then my eyes were opened and I saw my old sinful fleshly man standing on the bathroom floor even though I was still in the bathtub. I commanded my old sinful fleshly man to leave in the Name of Jesus and it left but almost immediately it came right back. I had to command it to leave again which it did but it came right back. A third time I commanded it to leave and it left and did not come back.

Interpretation of my Dream:

The water that I was bathing in represents the Word of God. I was in the Word of God. The washing with water through the Word (see Ephesians 5:26). By bathing with water (the Word of God) we are being transformed by the renewing of our minds (see Romans 12:2). Our minds are being washed/cleansed from legalism as well as worldly humanistic living and thinking to Kingdom living and thinking. As we bathe ourselves in the

Word of God our minds are being renewed **so that** we will know God and who He is more and more and **so that** we will know who we are in Christ and what belongs to us as His child. The more our minds are renewed with the Word of God (the water in my dream), the less we will revert back to our old ways. The fact that the old sinful fleshly man was standing on the bathroom floor and not in the bathtub with me indicates its powerlessness to the Word of God (the water in my dream). If we don't know the Word of God, if we don't know that our old sinful fleshly man is dead and buried and that we are a new creature in Christ Jesus, if we don't resist the old sinful fleshly man with the truth of God's Word, it will try to rule our life. It will try to take over. **The water represents us meditating on the truth that our old sinful fleshly man is dead and buried and we have been resurrected a new man in Christ Jesus.**

It was because I was in the water (the Word of God) that I was able to use my authority over the old sinful fleshly man. The water also represents us meditating on the redemptive work of Jesus and the grace of God; meditating on the truth that we are now the righteousness of God in Christ Jesus, that He loves us unconditionally, that we are under a New Covenant with God, that we are accepted by Him and approved by Him as His child, that we are royalty, that He is for us and not against us, that no weapon formed against us shall prosper or bear any fruit in our lives, that we are the head and not the tail, that we are blessed by God because Jesus has taken the curse for us and destroyed it in our lives, that God delights in us, that we are His treasured possession and the apple of His eye. God wants us to see ourselves like this because this is how He sees us. The Word of God will help us to think the way God thinks and act the way God acts. These are truths that God wants us to get our minds renewed with because when we believe right, right living will automatically follow.

As we get these truths into our heart, our new re-created man is strengthened to resist the old man. In my dream, it was my new re-created man who took authority over the old sinful fleshly man standing outside the bathtub. I was no longer

that old man. That old man was no longer in me. My new re-created man was in me in the bathtub. The fact that I had to take authority over my old sinful fleshly man three times represents persistence in fighting the good fight of faith with the Word of God; continuing to stand firm on the Word of God by meditating on who I am in Christ Jesus and who God is to me until the victory comes. Our minds are in the process of being renewed. We are on a journey of renewing our minds with God's Word.

The devil wants us to think that the old sinful fleshly man is still alive but that's not what the Word of God says. Let's look at what the Word of God says in Galatians.

> *"**I have been crucified with Christ and I no longer live (this is past tense), but Christ lives in me.** The life I live in the body, I live by faith in the Son of God, who loved me and gave himself for me" (Galatians 2:20, emphasis and parenthesis added).*

KJV says " I live by the faith of the Son of God."

Did you notice that this is past tense? We **were** crucified with Christ. When? When we got born again.

When I awoke from my dream, the Holy Spirit showed me that I need to persistently resist the old sinful fleshly man by meditating on the truth that I have been crucified with Christ and I (the old sinful fleshly man) no longer lives but Christ lives in me. The new re-created man with God's divine nature lives on the inside of me. Whenever that old sinful fleshly man tries to rear its ugly head, I need to remind myself that the old is gone and the new has come; that I am a new creation in Christ Jesus. The old sinful fleshly man is dead and buried with Christ and I have been raised a new man in Christ Jesus. When Jesus was raised from the dead, I was raised with Him and the moment I believed in Jesus as my personal Savior and Lord this became a reality in my life.

A couple of times in my dream I wasn't able to lift my hands out of the water. We praise God with lifted hands.

Something was trying to stop me from praising God. The Holy Spirit told me in my dream that it was my old sinful fleshly man trying to stop me from praising God. I had to resist the old man with my new re-created man. I need to dwell on the truth that I am a new creation in Christ Jesus. As I focus on my new re-created man, I am resisting my old man. As I praise God that I am a new creation in Christ Jesus, I am resisting my old man. Praise is a powerful weapon against the old man.

Let's look at another scripture.

> *"Or don't you know that all of us who were baptized into Christ Jesus (immersed in Jesus at salvation) were baptized* ***into his death****? We were therefore* ***buried*** *with him through baptism into* ***death*** *in order that just as Christ was* ***raised from the dead*** *through the glory of the Father,* ***we too may live a new life****. If we have been united with him like this* ***in his death****, we will certainly also be united with him* ***in his resurrection****. For we know that our* ***old self was crucified with him*** *so that the body of sin might be done away with, that we should no longer be slaves to sin – because anyone who has died has been freed from sin.* ***Now if we died with Christ, we believe that we will also live with him****" (Romans 6:3-8, emphasis and parenthesis added).*

We die **daily** by **remembering** that the old sinful fleshly man is dead and buried and that we have been resurrected with Christ a new man with **God's divine nature** in us. Paul said that he dies every day to self (see 1 Corinthians 15:31, Amplified). This is recognizing that the old man is dead.

What is God's nature? God's nature is summed up in one word: love.

> *"****His divine powers*** *has given us everything we need for* ***life and godliness*** *through our* ***knowledge of him*** *(we get to know him through the word of God) who called us by his own glory and goodness. Through these he has given us his* ***very great and precious promises****, so that through them you may* ***participate in the divine nature*** *and escape the*

corruption in the world caused by evil desires" (2 Peter 1:3-4, emphasis and parenthesis added).

The word "powers" in verse 3 above in Greek is the word "dunamis" which means miraculous power. I like to think of it as dynamite power.

It is God's miracle-working power in us that enables us to live a godly life. As our minds are renewed with the knowledge of Him through the Word of God, we become aware of His very great and precious promises and through these very great and precious promises, we **participate in His divine nature (His love).** As we participate in His divine nature**, we are able to resist the temptations and seductions of the world**. That's what the above scripture says. Read it again. It says we will escape the corruption in the world caused by evil desires when we participate in the divine nature. We participate in the divine nature by first of all meditating on this truth until it becomes a reality in our lives.

"We died to sin; how can we live in it any longer?" (Romans 6:2).

I don't belong to sin anymore. I now belong to Jesus Christ. I no longer have a relationship with sin. I have a relationship with Jesus Christ. I am no longer partnering with sin. I am partnering with Jesus. This is what we need to meditate on so that our minds are renewed with truth that sets us free. If you are struggling with sin in your life that you want to overcome, meditate on these truths until the victory comes. Be persistent and don't give up. Ask the Holy Spirit to help you keep your eyes on Jesus and to help you grow in the knowledge of Him.

"For by the death He died, He died to sin [ending His relation to it] once for all, and the life that He lives He is living to God—in unbroken fellowship with Him" (Romans 6:10, Amplified).

This scripture is talking about Jesus. Jesus became sin for us by taking upon Himself all our sins and dying for us. His

relationship with God the Father was broken because of **our** sins that He bore for us. But He rose from the dead and is now seated at the right hand of God the Father never again to have His fellowship with His Father broken.

> *"Even so* ***consider yourselves also dead to sin and your relation to it broken****, but [that you are] alive to God—****living in unbroken fellowship with Him—in Christ Jesus****" (Romans 6:11, Amplified, emphasis added).*

Wow! Just like Jesus died to sin ending His relationship with it (it was our sin that was put on Him as He was sinless), we also are to count ourselves dead to sin and our relationship with it broken. Because we believe in Jesus and what He did for us in His redemptive work, we live in unbroken fellowship with God. Does this mean we will never sin again? No. Our soul has not yet been made perfect. Only our spirit has been made perfect in Christ. We are, however, striving to keep our eyes on Jesus and not on our shortcomings. **It is only in His power that we are able to do this.** It is because of what Jesus did for us that our relationship to sin is broken. We cannot live this Christian life in our own power and strength. We need the help and power of the Holy Spirit who lives in us. When we fail (and we will at times) we are not to condemn ourselves but rather run into the forgiving and accepting arms of Christ. His arms are always open. His grace is a free gift. It cannot be earned, merited or deserved. It must be received. It is **by the faith of the Son of God** that we believe that the power of sin is broken in our lives.

What I am trying to say here is when we get a revelation that our old man is dead and we are a new creature in Christ Jesus, our new man is strengthened and takes over just like it did in my dream. My new re-created man commanded my old sinful fleshly man to leave. As we get this truth into our hearts, it will set us free because the Bible says that the truth will set us free. Hallelujah!

> *"Do not lie to each other, since you have taken off your old self* ***with its practices*** *and have put on the new self* ***which is***

being renewed in knowledge *in the image of its Creator" (Colossians 3:9-10, emphasis added).*

Did you notice in this scripture that our new self is being renewed as we grow in knowledge of the Word of God? That having been said, what are the practices (deeds) that we have taken off (past tense) with our old man? Paul lists a number of sins just a few verses before the above scripture. Let's look at them.

*"**Put to death**, therefore, whatever belongs to your **earthly nature**: sexual immorality, impurity, lust, evil desires and greed, which is idolatry. Because of these the wrath of God is coming. You **used to** walk in these ways, in the life you **once lived**. But now you must rid yourselves of all such things as these: anger, rage, malice, slander, and filthy language from your lips" (Colossians 3:5-8, emphasis added).*

How do we put to death the things that belong to our earthly nature (old sinful fleshly man)? Paul tells us in the verses preceding these verses.

*"Since, then, you have been raised with Christ, **set your hearts on things above**, where Christ is seated at the right hand of God. **Set your minds on things above,** not on earthly things. For you died, and your life is now hidden with Christ in God" (Colossians 3:1-3, emphasis added).*

Paul tells us to set our minds on things above and not on earthly things. This is how we will walk delivered from the old sinful fleshly earthly man. Our fight is not the old man. **We are not to fight the old man or get our attention on the old man**. He is dead. We will, however, need to remind ourselves at times that our old man is crucified, dead and buried with Christ and that we are a new creature in Christ Jesus when the old man tries to rear its ugly head. We need to set our hearts on things above because that is where we are seated. We are seated with Christ as a co-heir at the right hand of God the Father. Our life is now hidden with Christ in God. What a beautiful place to be.

In the next scripture, **Peter** gives us some instructions on living.

> *"Dear friends, I urge you,* ***as aliens and strangers in the world****, to abstain from sinful desires which war against your soul" (1 Peter 2:11, emphasis added).*

This is not a command as if God is giving us more laws to obey. It is instruction on how to live in the Kingdom of God and as a Christian who has passed from death to life. In Christ, we are free to live this new life. Just as we give instructions to our children on how to live, Peter is instructing the Christian on how to live so that our minds are renewed.

Paul also gives us some instructions on living.

> *"Therefore, I urge you, brothers,* ***in view of God's mercy*** *to offer your bodies as living sacrifices, holy and pleasing to God—this is your spiritual act of worship. Do not conform any longer to the pattern of this world, but* ***be transformed by the renewing of your mind****. Then you will be able to test and approve what God's will is—his good, pleasing and perfect will" (Romans 12:1-2, emphasis added).*

Jesus redeemed us from our old self/our old man/our sinful nature/our flesh. These are all the same. I had been taught in the past that although our old man was crucified with Christ, we still have a flesh to fight. This is not true. Paul talks in Romans about fighting the flesh but this was before he was saved (see Romans 7:14-25). I have elaborated more on Romans 7:14-25 and this subject in my book "Sorrow to Everlasting Joy" in the chapter on what Jesus circumcised us from.

If we still have a flesh to fight then Jesus did not fully redeem us. The Bible says that we do have a fight to fight but it is not our flesh. It is the good fight of faith. When that old sinful fleshly man tries to rear its ugly head in our lives, we need to fight the good fight of faith. That's why it is so important for us to get our minds renewed with the Word of God because it is

the Word (the Sword of the Spirit) that will help us fight the good fight of faith. It is a good fight because we win every time.

When that old sinful fleshly man tries to rear its ugly head, we need to **remember** that it has been crucified and is dead and buried with Christ. We need to **remember** that we are resurrected with Christ a new creation (a brand new man). The old has gone and the new has come. We are in Jesus and He is in us. We are one. We need to **remember** that we have **His faith in us** to fight this good fight of faith. Faith comes from hearing and hearing the Word of God. As we spend time getting the Word (Jesus) into our hearts, our minds are renewed to think like God thinks and act like God acts. His faith will arise in us to fight the good fight of faith. We need to **remember** that grace teaches us to say "no" to ungodliness and worldly passions and to live self-controlled, upright and godly lives in this present age (see Titus 2:11-12). The old sinful man with its ungodly sinful nature and worldly passions is dead and buried. We are a new creation in Christ with the divine nature and godly passions. As we **remember** this, then we will take authority over that old sinful fleshly man when it tries to take over because we know that it has no more power over us. We need to **remember** that we are the top and not the bottom and we will stand against it with the faith of the Son of God. It has to bow its ugly knee. We need to **remember** that we are co-heirs with Jesus and we are seated with Him at the right hand of God the Father far above all rule, authority, power and dominion of the enemy of our souls. This is who we now are. This is something to praise God about.

This is the journey we are on. We are all on this journey to renew our minds with the Word of God so that when worldly passions try to rule us, when addictions try to bombard us, when sin tempts us, when the law condemns us, we can take authority and say "No, leave me now, in the Name of Jesus" and continue to fight the good fight of faith.

One last thought to leave you with that is so vitally important for us to understand and grab a hold of. Deuteronomy 28:15-68 lists the curses that will come upon and overtake all

who do not fully obey the Lord. Because I could not fully obey the Lord and all His commandments, Jesus fully obeyed all the commandments on my behalf. Now that I am in Jesus and since Jesus fully obeyed the law for me, it is as if I have fully obeyed the law myself. I am freed from the curse and the blessings of God are chasing after me and overtaking me. I have been saying that our old man is dead and buried with Christ. I have said that our old man, our flesh and our sinful nature are all the same. **I want to take this a step further and say that my old cursed man is dead and my new re-created blessed man is alive.** My new re-created man is greatly blessed. I also want to say that my old sick, diseased man is dead and my new healthy man is alive. My new re-created man is full of health and made whole (pre-sickness, pre-lack, etc.). On the cross, Jesus not only took my sins He literally became a curse for me. Therefore, He took all my sickness, disease, pain, emotional bondage, mental anguish, lack, etc. (which is all part of the curse) on His body on the cross for me and He set me free. He nailed the curse to the cross. My old cursed man has been nailed to the cross with Jesus, crucified with Him. It is dead and buried with Him. Jesus freed me from the curse and He released His blessings by establishing the New Covenant of grace. **My old man was cursed but my new man is blessed**. All the blessings listed in Deuteronomy 28:1-13 are mine. My new re-created man is blessed, healed, delivered, set free and made whole. My body is blessed. My mind is blessed. My memory is blessed. My emotions are blessed. My finances are blessed. My marriage is blessed. My household is blessed. The fruit of my womb is blessed. Wow! What a great redemption! Think about this. This is something to rejoice about!

This may not be a reality yet in your life but as you continue to fight the good fight of faith, you are reaching up into the heavenly realm with your faith in God's promises and receiving what grace has already made available to you.

Just as God breathed His breath of Life (His Spirit) into Adam so that he would live (see Genesis 2:7), He breathed His breath of Life (His Spirit) into my re-created man the moment I

was born again so that my new man would live and be blessed. God's Spirit (Life) is in me. I have this truth as an anchor for my soul.

My mind needs to be continually renewed with God's Word so that I can receive all that grace has made available to me. This should not be burdensome. After all, Jesus is the Word of God and as I spend time in the Word, I am actually spending time with Jesus Himself. The Word of God brings life to me and strengthens my re-created man.

Isn't it wonderful to know that Jesus loved us so much that He made a way for us to walk in victory? He has given us everything we need for life and godliness. He has given us His Word, His faith, His love, His acceptance, His approval, His peace, His righteousness, His joy, His Spirit, His gifts, His authority, His blessings and His grace to name a few. Let us keep these truths before us by meditating on His Word (thinking on and declaring His great and precious promises). Let us remember what Jesus did for us and know who we are in Christ Jesus and we will see the victory manifested that we are believing Him for.

A Word of Encouragement

I would like to leave you with one further thing before we close this Book.

One morning I was driving down the road and I was approaching a group of people standing on the sidewalk who were waiting for a bus. The Holy Spirit had me zoom in on one girl and as I looked her in the face the Holy Spirit spoke something to my spirit. I saw this girl standing close to the curb looking intently in the direction of the bus. I looked in my rear-view mirror and I could not see the bus coming yet but she was watching intently. She was waiting for this bus to come. She was expecting this bus to come. She was believing that the bus would soon be there. She knew that the bus was on its way and it was getting closer and closer all the time even though she could not see it with her natural eyes. It was just a matter of time for her to literally see the bus and to hop on it.

The Holy Spirit said it is the same with us who are believing God for whatever it is that we are trusting Him for. We are watching intently for the manifestation of whatever it is. We are waiting patiently and peacefully because we know it is just a matter of time. We see it in the spirit realm. We are expecting the manifestation because we know that our God has already supplied it for us even though we don't see it yet with our natural eyes. We believe that it is on its way and suddenly it will appear.

So please keep watching, keep waiting, keep expecting, **keep believing**, keep meditating on God's promises, believing them and receiving them because it is just a matter of time for us to see the manifestation of our prayers. God is faithful and He will do it.

Sorrow to Everlasting Joy

Jeannette Musselman is also the author of "Sorrow to Everlasting Joy" which is a must read for every believer no matter how long you have been saved as it reveals life transforming truths from the Word of God. It will help you grow in leaps and bounds. It is a book that reveals the heart of God and sets the captives free. It will help you see yourself through the eyes of Christ rather than through your own eyes and to believe what the Word of God says about you rather than what you think about yourself. You may be struggling with stress, depression, sorrow, fear, perfectionism, guilt, condemnation, shame, rejection, addictions, sin, unworthiness or thoughts that God is angry with you and that you don't measure up to God's standard (the law). Jesus came to set the captives free.

This book reveals what our inheritance is in Christ Jesus and the abundant life that Jesus died to give us. It also reveals the grace of God in a way that can be understood and received.

Did you know that Jesus died to set believers free from the law of Moses because there is no way that we could fully obey it? Jesus fully obeyed the law for us and took the curse of the law for us to redeem us so that we could walk in the blessings of the Lord. The law is good and is set in place to help people see that they are sinners in need of a Savior who is Jesus Christ. However, once we come to Jesus as our Savior and Lord we have been freed from the old covenant of law and are now under a new covenant: the covenant of grace. Grace is unearned, undeserved and unmerited favor of God.

Many believers walk in a mixture of law and grace but God wants us to walk in the pure unadulterated grace of God

because this is where the victory is. This is where we will be set free. This book will help you to come out from living under the old covenant of law to live under the new covenant of grace. At the last supper when Jesus took the cup He said that it was the cup of the **new covenant** (see 1 Corinthians 11:25). Knowing and walking in this new covenant of grace and the truths revealed in this Book brings freedom, joy and abundant living.